THE GREYHARBOR CYCLE · BOOK ONE

THE DARK GENOME

In the fog-locked port city of Greyharbor, a mortuary assistant inherits a parasitic organ of living shadow — and must climb a ladder of forbidden biological tinctures before the dark biosphere beneath the city devours everything he has left. To save it, he will learn what the darkness is really made of: every memory the world has forgotten.

A Novel of the Hollow

Thirty chapters and an epilogue · Progression fantasy with biopunk themes

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CHAPTER 1

The Body in the Fog

Seven bells for seven years. The curfew bell of Greyharbor rang at dusk the way it had every night since the Sporefall, but tonight the ringers added seven strokes at the end, and the fog took them one at a time, so that the last note arrived at the mortuary on Salt Row soft and worn, like a coin rubbed too long between fingers.

Soren Vale counted them anyway. He counted everything. The trade had grown the habit into him: the difference between six trays and seven was somebody's missing aunt, and a body logged with nine fingers was a story the coroner's man would want told twice. Counting kept the world where he had put it.

Salt Row was quiet at bell. Below the hill, the harbor lay under wool, masts black as burnt matches, the gaslight along the quay diffused to a yellow smear. On nights like this the fog carried a faint sweetness, crushed flowers and cold wax, and no one in Greyharbor could explain it and no one talked about it. Seven years since the luminous cloud had come down over the city for a single night, and half the Sixth District had walked up into it and not walked down. The anniversary came back every autumn like a debt, and the whole city paid it by staying indoors after dark.

Chalked notices on every corner said the same thing in the same tired hand: KEEP IN AFTER BELL. KEEP DOORS SHUT. DO NOT ANSWER TO VOICES YOU KNOW.

Soren had been sixteen the night the sky came down. He remembered it in pieces, the way he remembered most useful things: the light through the shutters lying on the kitchen floor in pale rings; his mother chalking the doorframe with salt and marks she would not explain; her hand flat on his chest, pressing him down onto the boards, saying his name once in the voice she saved for the mortuary. In the morning the light was gone, the fog had moved in like a lodger who paid no rent, and men in the quarantine board's gray coats were walking the streets with lists. His mother's name had gone onto one of those lists by spring, and nothing had come off any list since.

Upstairs, the mortuary's owner was arguing with the ledger. "Soren." Old Greech's voice came down the stairwell, gravel over a cough. "Boat's at the side door. You'll want the good apron."

"What's the cargo?"

"Sailor. Out of the Breadwin Channel, an hour before bell." Greech appeared at the foot of the stairs, sleeves rolled to the elbow, gray stubble, ink on his thumb. "Third this week. A man

could found a religion on drowned sailors in this city."

"Somebody has," Soren said. "It meets on anniversary nights and complains about the fees."

Greech snorted and went to sign the watch's docket. The harbor watchman delivered the body on a shutter. On his way out he paused with his hat in both hands. "Third one," he said, to nobody in particular. "Other two went to Saint Ellery's. The father there charged the parish a blessing fee and put them in one grave, side by side, like spoons." He said it the way men say things they don't want repeated, and left.

"One grave, like spoons," Greech repeated, disgusted. "That's a fee I'd have waived." He signed the docket with a flourish that bordered on vandalism. "This one sits with us tonight. The quarantine wagon comes at dawn, anniversary or no. What the parish does after that is between the parish and its God." Soren had stopped minding the arrangements two years ago, around the time he understood he would never be permitted to call himself anything grander than assistant.

The sailor was young, thirty at the outside, rigger's hands, no boots. They laid him on the second table, the one with the raised lip, and Soren lit both lamps, because anniversary nights deserved the courtesy of light.

"Anniversary work," Greech muttered, stamping the docket. "Bad luck, washing a body tonight. My mother said so."

"Your mother also said eels were the souls of tax collectors."

"And has an eel ever wronged you, boy? No. There's a woman who knew the world." He shuffled off to the office with the docket, keys jangling, and left Soren alone with the dead man and the fog.

Soren worked the way he always worked. Coat folded, pockets inventoried: a bent tin of matches, a lead token for the ferry, nothing written. Shirt next, buttons counted into the dish. Seven, one missing, replaced at some poor mouth with cheaper bone. Boots gone, sold or lost before the pull. A rope-burn across one palm, weeks old and healed wrong, the kind a man gets from a line under strain. He logged the hands, the teeth, the old break in the left forearm. A life, itemized, filed under a number until somebody claimed it or the parish paid. The skin was cold, but not canal-cold, not after an hour in November water, and that was the first thing that sat wrong. He said his observations aloud, a low running tally, because a thing said out loud was harder for a quiet room to change.

"Time of death doesn't match the pull," he told the sailor. "You've been out of the water longer than they think. Somebody kept you somewhere warm."

The dead man held still and let himself be read, which was what Soren liked about the dead. They never lied. They only stopped.

* * *

The lungs were where the night stopped being a night like other nights.

He had opened a hundred drowned chests, or near enough, and drowned lungs had a look he could have drawn from memory: heavy, wet, liver-dark, weeping froth at the knife. He made the short incision under the ribs the way he always did, and stopped with the blade still in his hand.

The lungs were dry. Dry as pressed flowers, pale as the pages of an old book, folded down at the corners. No water in them at all.

"Well," Soren said. "You didn't drown."

Against his breastbone, under his shirt, something ticked. Once. His mother's pocket-watch, dead these seven years, stopped at six minutes past four on a morning he did not let himself think about. He had worn it every day since he was sixteen, through the quarantine sweep that took her, through the year of letters that got no answers, through the six years of this. It had never once made a sound. He pressed his palm flat over it and stood very still, and the watch lay against his skin like a small cold stone, keeping its silence, pretending it had always been obedient.

The lamps guttered. Not flickered: guttered, drawn down, the way a candle dims under a snuffer, and both of them dimmed together, toward the table.

Soren leaned over the opened chest. Where the heart should have sat, nested in its sac like a pearl in a shell, was something else. Pale. Smooth as the inside of an eggshell, webbed with veins so fine they might have been inked with a pen, and the veins moved. Not the way a heart moves. They turned, all of them together, slowly, like compass needles finding north, and every needle pointed at the nearest lamp.

At the light.

As he watched, the gaslight lost another shade, and the thing in the chest brightened by exactly as much as the room went dark. He could see it drinking. His hands stayed flat on the table's edge, careful hands, mortuary hands, and his mind did the only thing it knew to do with a world gone wrong.

It counted. One lamp. One body. One organ where no organ had any business being, grown where a heart had been, and the heart gone as clean as if it had been paid for and collected. Somewhere beneath the fear, an older voice of his took over, the mortuary voice, the one that catalogued: unknown organ, one unit, site pericardial, previous owner unavailable for

interview. It was a ridiculous comfort. Numbers were a floor to stand on, and for now the floor was holding.

"Greech," he said, and his voice came out level, which surprised him. "Come look at this."

Upstairs a door closed. Then there were no footsteps at all, and the fog against the windows went silent, and the silence had edges to it, like glass.

Soren should have stepped back. He knew that the way he knew the fee schedule. Instead he took up the small bone saw and touched its flat side to the pale thing, as if it were any unknown and he any examiner. Cold, colder than the room. And beneath the cold, a warmth with a rhythm to it, small and quick and patient, nothing like a man's heart.

The veins turned. All of them, together, away from the lamps.

Toward him.

The light lost another shade. In the opened chest, the smooth surface gathered itself into fine folds, the way skin does around a waking mouth, and parted with a sound like a wet page turning.

The organ opened an eye.

CHAPTER 2

Lacuna

Greech did not come down. Soren called again, once, and then stopped calling, because the lamps came back up shade by shade on their own, and the eye closed. It closed the way a net closes, all the fine veins drawing in together, and then it was only a pale organ in a dead man's chest, and the room smelled of formalin and wet slate, and nothing in the world had changed except everything.

He sewed the sailor closed with the smallest stitches of his career, washed the table twice, logged the body in the parish book as cause of death: immersion, and then, in his own cheap notebook, in a hand he barely recognized as his, wrote: One (1) organ. Site: where the heart should be. It drank the light. It looked back. He read the line three times, decided it was true, and slept three hours in the back room with the lamps burning, which was two more than he meant to.

The quarantine wagon came at dawn. Two men in gray coats took the shutter without a signature, and one of them looked at Soren a moment too long, the way a man looks at a door he intends to come back to. Greech watched from the office window with his tea.

"You look like you slept in a drawer," Greech said.

"Long shift."

"Anniversary shifts are long. It's the city's way of reminding us who keeps the books." He drank his tea. Soren waited to feel the pull of the lie he was keeping, the pale thing under the stitches, and the pull never came, and that frightened him more than the eye had. A secret with no weight in it was a secret that had already chosen its owner.

* * *

He slept at noon in his room over the chandler's shop on Grennel Street, curtains drawn against a sky the color of dishwater, and dreamed the hunt.

He ran on four limbs that bent in too many places, through a fog that was a whole country. Around him ran the pack, and the pack made no sound at all, which was not strange in the dream, because sound was a kind of meat and they were saving it. Ahead of them something small and bright fell out of the sky like a coin knocked off a table, and the pack turned as one body, and he turned with them, and the chase was joy, pure and single, the first unbroken feeling he could remember since he was sixteen. They ran down stairways that grew as they descended. They crossed a canal that hung in the air like a curtain of cold. The bright thing led

them through eleven doorways, and behind each doorway was the same room, and in the room a lamp was burning, and they were not allowed to touch the lamp.

They caught the bright thing at the bottom of a garden where the flowers were teeth. The pack set it into his chest, under the bone, careful as sextons laying a coin in a dead man's hand, and said, in no voice at all, in pressure and intention: Keep it. We were only carrying it. It was always addressed to you.

Soren woke on the floor beside the bed with his hand over his sternum and two heartbeats under his palm.

His own he knew: fifty-eight at rest, a clerk's heart, a counter's heart. The other was small and quick and sat a half-inch behind the breastbone, and it came in late, like an echo that had decided to be a voice. There was a taste in his mouth of smoke he had never smoked, burnt hair and frost and under it something sweet, and when he got to the mirror he found a seam on his chest, thin and pink and exact as a surgeon's line, though nothing in this world had cut him.

The watch on its chain was warm. It had not told the time in seven years, and it was warm as a held coin.

The window was fogged from the inside, and the fog on the glass was crawling. He watched it come, bead by bead, toward the side of the room where he stood, and his breath showed in the noon air of his own bedroom, a small ghost that would not leave.

* * *

Mrs. Ferrow knocked the way she did everything, twice and firmly. "Rent," she said through the door. "And don't think I didn't hear you pacing half the night. On the anniversary too. Some of us keep the customs."

He counted out the coins with steady fingers and opened the door on the chain, because even with two heartbeats he was not going to explain his face to a landlady at noon. She was sixty and built like a dock bollard, chalking her doorstep behind her, and she looked at the money, then at him, then at the window behind him where the glass had gone clear again.

"You look like death's clerk," she said. "I've let rooms to death's clerks before. They pay prompt."

"You flatter me. Death keeps a better class of office."

"Mind you keep the hearth swept. Damp comes in on nights like this and takes the weak ones first." She said it lightly, and then did not move from the doorway for a moment, looking at him with the flat professional eyes of a woman who had survived three landlords, two wars of the wharf unions, and one Sporefall. "You've a smell on you," she said at last. "New. Like the cellar after rain. You want to get that seen to."

She went down the stairs. The chalk on her doorstep was a ward his mother could have drawn from memory, and Soren stood in the door of his own room, in his own rent, and understood that he was hungry in a way that food would not answer.

He tested it, because that was what he did with things. Downstairs the chandler sold him a loaf and strong tea and asked no questions, and he ate at the counter like a man who had read about eating somewhere. The bread went down like paper. The tea went down like warm rain. The hunger stayed exactly the size it was, and when he carried the lamp back up the stairs, the hunger turned its attention toward the flame with a slow, loving interest, and the flame bowed in its glass, and Soren climbed the rest of the way in the dark rather than feed it again in front of a witness.

* * *

He examined himself that evening the way he would examine any body that came in over the threshold, because method was the only family he had left. Lamp close, eyes clear, hands steady. The seam did not hurt. Under it, when the lamp came near, something moved, and the lamp dimmed, and the something brightened, and the transaction was so smooth and so greedy that he laughed once, a bad sound in an empty room.

He tried the ledger voice on himself. Subject: Soren Vale, twenty-three. Prior condition: poor. Present condition: two hearts, one appetite, no name for any of it. Whatever he was now, nothing had told him its rank. No mark, no paper, no bell. Only hunger, and fog that leaned toward him like a plant toward a window.

He locked the door. Three bolts, and the chair under the knob for a fourth opinion, and he sat up with the lamp turned high and the notebook on his knee, because he had decided, in the daylight, that whatever had been in the sailor's chest had chosen him in some formal sense, and things that chose you formally could be studied.

By midnight the lamp had lost two shades with the wick untouched.

By one the sounds of the room had begun to arrive late. The tick of the cooling stove came a half-breath after the stove had ticked. The creak of the chair arrived after his weight had already shifted, an echo standing in front of its own voice. He said, "Who's there," and heard the words leave him and not come back, stolen somewhere between his mouth and the wall, and the silence that swallowed them had edges to it, like glass.

The dark under the bed had stopped behaving like dark. It had a grain to it, like fur stroked the wrong way, and it was pooling toward the corner by the wardrobe where the light was worst, and from inside that pool came breathing. It arrived a half-second late, patient, and it was the wrong size for the space it was in.

Dockmen told a tale to frighten apprentices, and the tale had a name in it, and like most of the tales told in Greyharbor lately, the name had stopped being folklore the way a door stops being a door when it is kicked in.

Hush-hounds, the tale called them. They steal the sound of you before they take the rest.

There was a hush-hound in his locked room, and by the way the dark sat in the corner, it had been there long enough to get comfortable.

CHAPTER 3

Greyharbor Below

The lamp lost its third shade, and Soren stopped being a naturalist.

He took the fire-iron from the hearth in both hands and put his back to the wall, and when he tried to shout for Mrs. Ferrow through the floor, the shout left his mouth and did not come back, and he felt it go the way a man feels a coin leave his hand in a crowd. The dark in the corner stood up. It stood up all at once, the way a cat stands, with no intermediate stages, and it was taller than the wardrobe and patient as arithmetic, and where its eyes were, two coals that had been quenched in something colder than water looked at him with professional interest. It had no face that his eyes agreed to record. Looking straight at it gave him an impression of long limbs folded like a carpenter's rule, and a head that was mostly hinge.

The wallpaper split. Not torn: split, along a seam that had never been printed, the pattern peeling back from a line of cold, and behind the plaster there was no lath and no brick. There was a gape, breathing cellar-air and crushed flowers, and the hound poured itself through it the way night pours under a door, and the split stayed open, exhaling.

Through the floor, from somewhere below, Mrs. Ferrow's cat began to shriek.

Soren did his counting, one to ten, twice. Then he took the storm lantern off its hook, turned the wick low, and stepped through the wall of his own room, because a house with a hound in it does not stay a house, and because the hunger behind his sternum had risen up like a dog that has heard its lead.

* * *

Passage was one cold stride, like stepping through the skin of a window from the warm side of the world to the other. Then he was outside, under a sky, and the sky was a canopy.

Grennel Street went down and down before him, and it was Grennel Street, door for door, and it was not Grennel Street at all. Overhead, tiers of shelf-fungus stacked themselves into a

vault higher than any cathedral, rust-brown and bone-pale, sifting a slow snow of spores that fell without hurry, as if the whole roof were yawning. The eleven doors of his street were still eleven, and every one of them was a mouth now, grown shut with nacre and veined at the hinges. The chandler's shop had become a heap of pale fruiting bodies stacked in the shape of a shop, honestly shaped, mockingly shaped. The cobbles were bone. Vertebrae and skulls and long anonymous bones, all of it mossed green and worn smooth, laid in courses like a street some enormous mason had loved once.

His lantern was the only light, and the light was wrong. It arrived everywhere a half-second late. Sound was worse: when his boot pressed the bone cobbles there was no click, only a soft arrival of click afterward, like a servant following a master at a distance.

Lantern-mites came out of the canopy to graze around the glass, a drifting constellation of green sparks, each one the size of a grain of barley, and they did not touch the lantern. They hovered at the edge of its light, feeding on what leaked, and he understood, with his new organ's cold opinion, that they were livestock, and the light was pasture.

He counted the doors as he moved, eleven, and it steadied him the way it always steadied him, right up until the count became eleven mouths, and every mouth opened slightly as he passed, in greeting or in appetite.

The hound hunted him by echo. He learned its method over three streets of mossed bone: it sent a sound ahead of itself, a stolen sound, and watched what the sound did to him. Once it threw his own voice down an alley, saying, in his voice, with his fear in it, "Who's there." Once it let him hear Mrs. Ferrow's kettle, at boiling, in a street where there had never been a kitchen. It wanted him running. Running things are loud.

So he stopped running, and counted, one to ten, twice, and made his fear small, because it hunted fear the way his new hunger hunted light, and a small fear is harder to smell. Then he backed to the end of the street, where the drowned chapel had stood before the Sporefall, its yard grown through the fence like a green wave, and he took the spade that was leaning there, moss to the shoulder, blade pitted but true.

The hound came for him at the gate of the dead.

It came low and wrong, joints unfolding in the wrong order, and it stole his shout again, mid-throat, and that was its mistake, because a man who cannot scream does not need to. Soren side-stepped behind the gatepost, let the weight of it pass, and swung the spade not at the body but at the space the body was about to agree to occupy. The heel of the blade caught the skull where the ear would have been on anything honest. He dropped his knee onto the neck and drove down with everything the trade had built into his back, and the sound the hound made was the sound of a wet book closing.

Then the world got its voice back. Every stolen sound came home at once, out of the dying thing like air out of a lung: his shout, whole and furious, and Mrs. Ferrow's kettle, and the cat, and a night's worth of small noises, a wash of them rushing outward across the mossed bone. Soren knelt on the carcass, breathing, counting his own heartbeats, and the carcass went on dying in a way he had never seen anything die. It deflated. Not bled out: leaked out, as if the body had only ever been a coat hung on something else, and the something else was escaping through the seams.

The escaped thing was black. It pooled around his knees like mercury, and it did not spread. It gathered, flowing gently uphill, against the tilt of the street, toward him.

He was so hungry.

The hunger was not like appetite. It was like standing in a drought looking at a well. He told himself, in the ledger voice, that he did not know what it would do, and the black shadow-stuff reached his boot and climbed the leather like a kind tide, and the well said: yes.

He put his hands in it and drank.

It tasted of burnt hair and frost. Under those, clear as a watermark, it tasted of fear, the hound's own, the flavor of a thing that had hunted ten thousand years and been counted at the end, and the taste went into him and he knew it, and knew that knowing it was going to be the shape of his life now. The world rearranged itself around the meal. The spore-snow stopped falling: it hung. The mites' grazing became audible, a field of small green teeth. The dark everywhere acquired depth, became a country with districts, and in that country he could feel his own small light the way a lit window feels to a street.

If anything down here kept books, and something did, a new line had been written under his name. He had no way to read it yet. The line said Tenth.

He went to find the way back and could not. The split in the air where he had entered had healed like a mouth after a scream, without a scar. He walked the street end to end and counted the doors, and the count was twelve, and one of the twelve was swollen in exactly the shape of his own room's window, down to the bubble in the pane where Mrs. Ferrow's cat liked to sit. He stood in front of his own room wearing another street's architecture and made himself use the ledger voice. Subject's location: not negotiable. Subject's condition: fed. Subject's options: count them. He counted. The options came to one: walk until the street remembered he was a paying tenant somewhere else.

The hunger did not die. It rose from the meal the way a diner rises from a first course, and looked down the length of the table, and found it good.

Soren got up off the dead hound with the spade in one hand and its shadow drying black on his knuckles, and turned to look for the split in the world he had come through, and that was

when the applause began. Slow. Dry. Courteous. Each clap arriving a half-second after its hands met, which meant the clapper was very tall, and very far off the ground, and did not mind that he knew it.

On the balcony of the swollen townhouse opposite, among knotted woody galls the size of hams, something folded itself upright, joint by elegant joint, and kept clapping for him.

CHAPTER 4

The Tallyman

The Hollow let him go at dawn, the way a creditor lets a debtor leave town.

A split opened for him at the drowned chapel's gate, sighing cellar-air, and he stepped through it into Grennel Street under a real sky, dish-colored, drizzling. The spore-snow on his sleeves turned to ordinary water as he watched. The eleven doors were eleven doors. Mrs. Ferrow's cat sat in the window with the bubble in the pane, spat at him, and went back to sleep, and Soren leaned on the chandler's wall for a while with the spade still in his hand, shaking in the ordinary cold, alive.

The applause had followed him for three streets in the dark. It had never hurried him. That was the worst of it, he thought, walking home to leave the spade by Mrs. Ferrow's scrubbing step and wash the black off his knuckles in the horse trough: whatever had clapped had wanted him alive, and fed, and amused.

"You reek," said a woman's voice from the corner.

She was standing under the gutter outflow where nobody sensible stands, and she did not look like she had been there long, and she looked like she had always been there. Forties. Iron-gray hair in a braid thick as a ship's cable. A coat that smelled of camphor and iron filings, and in her right hand a small brass instrument like a pocket watch with a thumb-lever, which clicked twice while he watched, then clicked twice again, the second time as if checking its own work.

"Morning to you too," Soren said.

"Tenth Essence." She said it the way a clerk reads a charge sheet. "Fresh-taken, last night, in the vicinity of your own street, off a hush-hound you killed with a garden tool. You've been tracking the smell across my rounds since the anniversary. I found a sailor's shirt in a quarantine incinerator with a pale growth stitched into it, and I found a woman on Salt Row whose lodger stopped sleeping at the right hours, and then I found you." She clicked the brass thing again, twice, and looked at his chest, not his face. "Gravid. New-made. And here is my

professional problem, young man: you are walking around loose."

Soren put his hands in his pockets, where his knuckles could pretend to be calm. "And your name?"

"Ilse Vann. Tallyman, third circle, the Veridian Concord, out of House Blackwing. You will not have heard of us. That was expensive to arrange."

"Was it you I heard on the stairs the other night? Mortuary on Salt Row. Somebody closed a door and stopped existing."

Her eyes came up to his face for the first time, and there was something in them like approval trying not to hatch. "I counted five organs in that body through the floor. Unlicensed tissue, matured in a dead host, light-fed. I reported it. The report takes eleven hours to walk through the board, and the board takes another eleven to not act." She turned the brass counter over in her palm. "You cut it open and it did not die, and now it lives behind your sternum. So we are going to have a conversation about doors, and you are going to stand still for it."

They had the conversation walking, because she said standing still was for church.

The word for him, she said, was gravid. The organ was a Lacuna: a parasite grown from exposure to the Sporefall's leavings, some in one in ten thousand, sitting behind the breastbone, drinking light, hungry for essence, which was the shadow-stuff of the Hollow's creatures. A gravid who fed it climbed a ladder called the tiers, Tenth Essence at the bottom, First at the top, near-mythic and mostly graveyard. Each tier brought a new organ and a new hunger. The organs grew glands the way apprentices grew opinions: taste of fear, sight through smoke, a voice that could still a hound. The ladder was climbed on essence and survived through fever, and it was made survivable by tinctures, brewed on a licensed bench from Hollow reagents and a memorized gene-script, and if you brewed without a license you did not climb, you spliced. The Amalgam Heresy, the old books called it. There were reasons the word heresy had survived in a city that had burned its churches.

"And the price?" Soren asked. "Nothing climbs free. I weigh bodies. I know the toll schedule of the universe."

Vann stopped walking for a moment. "The Fade," she said. "Every tier burns memories into the Hollow. Scents go first. Then faces. Then names. The Hollow is built out of what it takes. Memory is the one coin both worlds accept, and the exchange rate is set by the Hollow." She clicked her counter, twice. "I have buried friends who could not remember why they had buried friends."

"And the Hollow. The place with the bone cobbles."

"The dark mirror of this city, wearing its streets. Reached through Folds. Inhabited. Governed. The Court of Lanterns sits at the top of it, and it considers you seed-stock." She said

the word without decoration. "There is a tide that comes off it when the Court is hungry. My brother went out to count a tide once. The count came back. My brother did not."

They had crossed half the town by then, through streets going about their frightened morning business, and she had never once raised her voice, and he had understood two things. First, that every word could be checked, because she gave him numbers, and liars round their numbers. Second, that the Concord was not the only party interested in a loose gravid.

"And the sweep," Soren said. They had come down through Salt Cross by then, past the weigh-house with its chained scale. "Seven years back. Gray coats, lists. People came back from some of those wagons."

"Some," Vann said. "The board calls the rest relocations. The board's own archive burns annually. Accidents with lamps." She clicked her counter, twice, slowly. "The Concord began counting the morning after the Sporefall and has not stopped. Counting is the whole of my trade, boy. It is the only prayer I know."

The quarantine board paid eleven marks for a gravid, delivered intact. She had watched the wagon men measure a boy in a fish cellar with calipers, and she described the sounds, briefly, so that he would know she was not frightening him for pleasure.

"So there are two doors," Soren said. "The one you're holding open, and the one with the calipers."

"There is always a second door. The Court holds a third, for exceptional stock." She did not smile. "I am offering you a bench, a teacher, and a leash you can see. I will not lie to you about the leash. The Concord wants its gravid counted, kept, and spent carefully. So does everything else in this city. The difference is that we write down what we spend."

He thought of the pale organ drinking the lamp, of the applause in the dark, of his mother's name on a gray coat's list. He thought about doors.

"The leash I can see," Soren said. "Show me the office. Show me the ledger. I don't sign what I haven't read."

Vann clicked her counter twice, and this time the second click sounded almost like a laugh. "You'll do," she said.

* * *

The tally-house was a mission hall behind the salt stores, and the courtyard at the back was walled in brick the color of dried blood, and the wall had been painted white once. It was covered now, from gate to gutter, in small glazed tiles, each with a face fired into the glaze, and beneath each face a name in chalk, and beneath many of the names a second line: SPOREFALL, or SWEEP, or TIDE, and a season.

"The Wall of the Counted," Vann said. "Everyone the city lost and cannot bury. Eleven thousand, four hundred and six as of this morning. The Concord keeps it. Somebody has to." She watched him, not the wall. "Read it or don't. But know that it is the honest wall. Nothing on it was collected. Everything on it was missed."

He read it, because he had never once in his life walked past a thing that could be counted, and the tiles went back seven years, alphabetized by some patient hand. Rain beaded on the glaze and would not run. Here and there the chalk beneath a face had been refreshed, the same letters in the same neat cursive, year over year, the way people tend graves they cannot visit. He was two-thirds down the V's when he stopped counting.

Her face was small under the glaze, a little thinner than he kept it in memory, a little younger around the eyes. She was looking out of the tile at him with the expression she wore when a body told on itself: level, kind, unsurprised. Beneath the face, in chalk that someone had refreshed recently, the name said MAERWEN VALE. Beneath the name: SWEEP. SPRING AFTER SPOREFALL. UNRESOLVED.

"That's my mother," Soren said.

The counter in Ilse Vann's hand clicked once, and went quiet.

CHAPTER 5

Tincture of the Novice

House Blackwing kept its front door behind a fishmonger's cold room on Candlecourt, down a flight of steps that smelled of salt, sawdust, and something older than either, and the first thing the house did to Soren was take his coat.

"The house takes coats," said the woman at the bench. "It takes names too, eventually, but that's a senior privilege." She was fifty and sharp as a bone folder, sleeves pinned to the elbow, forearms freckled with old scald-marks, a chalk stub riding behind her ear like a quartermaster's pencil. "Apothecary Ondrey. I brew. You are the fresh Tenth that Vann pulled off the street, which means for the next month you are the most flammable object in this building. Walk carefully, breathe carefully, and never brew alone."

The brewing hall ran the length of the house: benches bolted to the floor, fume cupboards of brass and glass, and along the far wall a chalkboard the size of a ship's sail, dense with looping close-written script that hurt to read, the way a stair hurts when you look down it. The script moved. Not obviously. The way weather moves.

"Gene-scripts," Ondrey said, watching him not watch the wall. "A tincture is a recipe and a contract, and the contract is written in that. Hollow biology reads it the way we read a face. You will memorize three before you are permitted to recite one, and if you ever recite one you do not understand, I will personally assist the splice in finding you. Sit."

She sat him at the junior bench, where the glassware was arranged like a surgery, and brewed his first tincture with him the way surgeons teach stitches: hands over his hands.

Reagents came out of the cold room one at a time, each named and logged. Fold-rain, which had to be caught in the Hollow within a minute of falling, or it turned to spite. Mite-ink, green-black, taken from lantern-mites at the graze. A pinch of hearth-salt from a house that had stood through the Sporefall. And last, from a numbered vial with his own mark on the ledger beside it, the ichor of the hush-hound he had killed on Grennel Street.

"That's yours," Ondrey said. "You harvested it, you banked it. First lesson of the trade, boy: the Hollow takes payment in what you were willing to kill. The tincture remembers."

The brewing itself was mostly waiting, and the waiting was the dangerous part, because while the copper distilled, the novice recited. The gene-script went into him by rote, two hours a night, chalk in hand at a scribing desk with a monitor's hand on his shoulder. When at last he stood at the bench and recited it through, from the first glyph to the last, the script did not feel like words. It felt like swallowing a rope that was being pulled gently from the other end. The

alembic above the copper ticked. The vapor came down the coil the color of dusk, and filled the receiving flask with something that moved when the lamp moved, and Ilse Vann, who had come to watch with her arms folded and her counter clicking its quiet double-checks, said: "Good color. Don't get attached."

"What does it actually do?" Soren asked, watching the dusk in the flask turn to face the lamp.

"Binds the Lacuna to your ledger," Ondrey said. "A raw gravid burns essence like a drunkard burns wages, up the ladder with nothing to show but appetite. The tincture puts a hand on the ladder. Steadies the organ, signs the growth-fever into a form your body can pay, and tells the Lacuna who its host thinks it is. Brewed, you climb. Unbrewed, you are consumed by an enthusiastic employee." She stoppered the flask. "And tomorrow you choose your Codex, and then comes the fever. Eat now. Sleep now. The bench will still be here. The bench is the only thing in this city that is always still here."

* * *

The Codex plates were brought out on a tray, because the formality mattered, Ondrey said. Four of them, each a hand's width of pale slate fired with a glyph, each resting in a cradle of moss that was faintly, warmly alive.

"Predator," Ondrey said. "Hunt, speed, and the kill-sense: you will feel, in any room, which heartbeat is already owed. The Hollow's oldest trade. It will make you quick and it will make you certain, and certainty is the most expensive thing on this tray."

"Chirurgeon. Flesh-shaping, mending, unmaking. You will never lose a patient again. You will also know, always, exactly how they would come apart. Some of our kindest graduates stopped being able to look at their families."

"Botanist. Spore-craft, growth, dominion of a sort over Hollow flora. The land listens to a Botanist. The land also argues."

"Symbiont. Pacts. You would carry passengers, and some of them would carry you." She set the tray down. "Provisional now. You choose with ink; at Ninth Essence the choice seals, and the Codex writes itself into your genome, where no clerk can reach it to correct it. Most gravid choose what they were already like. It saves the house time."

"Which did you choose?" Soren asked Ilse.

"Predator. Thirty years ago, at that bench, for worse reasons than yours." She did not look away from him. "My brother signed Botanist, and the tide took him out counting flowers. Choose with your eyes open, not with mine."

Soren looked at the four plates a long moment. He thought of the sailor's dry lungs, of the wall of the missing, of a thing applauding politely in the dark of his own street.

"I intend to find out who sowed my city," he said. "That's hunting. Give me the Predator plate."

Nobody tried to talk him out of it, which he noticed, and which told him something about the house. He signed the roll with his blood and his name, Ondrey pressed his pricked thumb to the glyph, and the slate drank the drop the way chalk drinks water, and somewhere behind his sternum the Lacuna turned over like a sleeping man being told good news.

The fever came at moonrise.

* * *

They strapped him to a plank bed in the novices' ward, because a body growing its first organ thrashes, and packed him in ice, because the Lacuna drinks light and heat and would drink him if it could. The fever was a tide. It ran up his spine in rings, and in the rings he dreamed of running, and for the first time the dream had no pack in it. He ran alone, through a Greyharbor made of bone and moss, wearing his own legs, counting streets, and the count came out even, and in the dream that frightened him more than anything with teeth.

He woke at dawn with a nurse unlacing the straps and the taste of smoke gone from his mouth at last, replaced by every other taste in the ward.

There were nine beds. He could hear nine heartbeats, distinctly, the way a man in a dark room knows where the lamps are. And under the far window, in the seventh bed, one heartbeat sounded different. Not louder. Earlier. It sounded like a bell that had been struck a half-second before anyone pulled the rope, and his new sense, quiet and factual, laid the knowledge in him the way a mortuary ledger takes an entry: that one is owed. Hours from now, not days. The old man in it was asleep, breathing the careful breaths of the recently dosed, and he had a visitor's posy on the sill, and Soren stood in the middle of the ward with his new organ opening like an eye and understood that he would now always know this, first thing, in every room he entered, for the rest of his life.

The old man died at noon, easy, in his sleep, a stroke the physician had called kind. Soren told no one about the bell. He wrote it in the back of his notebook instead, under the entry about the organ that had looked back at him, and the book was getting to be a strange book.

Ilse found him there in the afternoon, sitting on the ward steps with his watch warm in his fist.

"It works, then," she said. "The kill-sense. I could tell by how you walked past the porter. Predators walk like debt collectors."

"It told me who was going to die. It didn't ask me if I wanted to know."

"It never asks. Listen to me now, novice, because this is the speech I give once." She sat down beside him, and the counter in her hand was still. "You will climb. You're built for it, you're angry enough for it, and the Concord needs you at the higher tiers before the tide season. But every rung is paid for, and the currency is memory, and the Fade is not a thief. A thief takes the gold. The Fade takes the most valuable thing you carry, every time, because the Hollow builds itself out of what people cannot bear to lose." She looked at the watch in his hand. "It takes the kindest memory first."

CHAPTER 6

Curfew Hunters

The tide came off the canals on the ninth night after the anniversary, and it came in through Tarlock Stairs, where the water runs black under the gasworks and the militia keep a brazier and a bell that nobody has ever rung in time.

Soren heard it first as weather. Then the kill-sense opened in the back of his mind like a fan, and the night rearranged itself into debts: forty-two militiamen along the quay, none owed; a squad at the stairs, none owed; and down in the dark under the bridge arches, a crowd of small cold heartbeats, all of them owed, all of them coming up the stairs together.

It was his first night out with a harvest cell, and the cell's orders were the orders the Concord gave on every tide night since the Sporefall: walk the cordon's blind side, take what the tide threw off, be home by second bell. Gravid walked curfews because the tide hunted gravid blood, and it was better for everyone that it found the Concord's gravid first, in a place of the Concord's choosing, wearing the Concord's iron. Soren carried the house spike now, a broad short blade with a mortuary knife's balance, because a man could not take a borrowed spade to every war. His hands knew its weight in three days. His hands were quick to know weights.

"Breach," he said. "Below the arches. Twenty-odd. Small things."

"Tide's early," said Brack, who was the cell's fourth and oldest member and had spoken, by Soren's count, eleven words in two weeks. He began loading his fowling piece with the unhurried economy of a man buttering toast.

They went over the quay rail one at a time, because the cell worked the fish-market side where the militia line did not look, and Ilse had already paid the duty of pretending not to be paid. The curfew bell was tolling its long complaint overhead. Below the arches, the water was

folding. Not waving: folding, like cloth, and out of the folds the hush-hounds came up the wet steps in a silence so complete that Soren's ears rang with it.

The next ten minutes were work, and the work was ugly, and afterward Soren never told anyone the part where it felt like a trade he had been apprenticed to all his life. You killed a hound with iron and salt and standing ground. You did not let it steal your voice. You counted your companions' heartbeats the way the harbor counted ships.

His first kill of the field came at the third stair, a hound that flowed at him out of the bell-shadow of the arch. The spike did what Ondrey had promised the bench-steel would do: it went in on the bias, it came out on the bias, and the thing came apart around it like a coat giving up its lining. He had time to be sick later. The tide did not schedule time to be sick.

He was counting his own, at the top of the stairs, when the wall behind him unfolded.

The gallows-walker had been standing against the bridge abutment for a full minute, and he had walked past it twice, because it looked like rigging and shadow and a bad job of lamplight. It was fifteen feet of folded blade-limbs, a carrion giant, patient as a debt, and when it chose to move it moved like a falling chimney, and its two forelimbs came down where he was standing, and he was still deciding to duck.

A shot took the thing in the second joint of its left forelimb and knocked the whole stroke sideways into the stone. Salt and iron shot, close enough to smell. Then a hand had his collar and the world did a half-turn, and Soren found himself sitting in a puddle while a boy about nineteen went past him at a run, reloading as he ran, whooping in a way that was going to get someone killed, quite possibly himself.

"Vann!" the boy yelled. "Left leg, it pivots on the left leg!"

They killed it in ninety seconds, on the count, the way the Concord kills everything: Brack to the knee, Ilse to the neck-joint, the boy putting his last shell into the lantern-organ at its throat when it reared. The light went out of it like a tide leaving a gutter. The silence it left behind was enormous.

The boy turned around, walked back to Soren, and offered a hand up. He had a quick grin, a chipped front tooth, a coat two sizes too big with chalk dust in the seams, and eyes that were already doing arithmetic.

"Dax Merrow," he said. "Tallyman, ninth circle, which is the circle they put you in when the alternative is debtor's gaol. You're the new tenth, then. Soren, right? Vann talks about you the way sailors talk about weather."

"You saved my life," Soren said.

"Two seconds ago, yes." Dax produced, from an inside pocket, a small printed card, filled out in pencil. "I also want you to know that I keep accounts. One life, saved. One shell, expended, number nine shot, saltload. One coat, ruined, yours, from the puddle, not my fault but adjacent to me. I do a bit of brewing on the side to keep the ledger honest, so we can settle in installments. Most clients prefer installments."

"He's joking about the installments," Ilse said, coming up the stairs with her blade still out. "He's not joking about the card. He has filed one against every member of this house, including the Primate. Harvest now, comedy later. We have maybe a quarter bell before the militia finds its nerve."

* * *

The harvest was performed the way the Concord harvested: on the count, with knives on a bias, taking only what the ledger allowed. "Galls at the neck," Ilse said, kneeling over the first hound. "Cut on the bias, never squeeze. What you bruise, you burn. The Hollow keeps no refunds."

Dax worked three knives at once, talking the whole time in a low running line that Soren realized was not nerves but ballast. "Fourth one's got a two-gallon gall, Vann, we're rich, I'm buying my mother a hat. She'll hate it. It'll be wonderful." His hands never once matched his mouth. They were fast, exact, and gentle with the carcasses, and Soren filed that away, because he filed everything.

The hounds gave up galls at the neck, small cold purses of shadow. The walker's throat-lantern, split, gave up a measure of pale essence that smoked even in the rain. Soren knelt on wet stone with the canal breathing under him and fed for the first time in the field, and it was nothing like the desperate gulp off a dead hound's shadow. This was a meal with a tablecloth on it. The essence went down cold and bright, and every bite of it said: soon, and further, and more.

The kill-sense sorted the night for him while he worked. The militiamen up on the quay: none owed, though one was owed soon, a lung he could hear failing in the rain. The dead things: paid in full. It was in the middle of that comfortable arithmetic that he caught the perfume.

Crushed flowers and cold wax. Anniversary fog, bottled and worn as clothing.

He looked up. Across the canal, on the roof of the salt warehouse, stood a figure that had not been there and was there, tall, holding perfectly still, with a soft light at the throat like a lamp behind silk. It stood the way courtiers stand in engravings, one hand resting on a rail that no other human hand could have reached. It did not move. It did not need to move. The

perfume came across the water to him alone, and settled on him like a hand on the shoulder, and when he blinked, the roof was empty, and the night smelled only of salt and powder and dead walker.

"What is it?" Ilse said, sharp.

"Perfume," Soren said. "On the warehouse roof. Gone now."

Brack and Ilse exchanged the look of professionals sharing an entire report in one glance. "The Court of Lanterns does not send perfume to spice its weather," Ilse said slowly. "The Court sends perfume to open negotiations, or to close them. Which was it?"

"It stood still the whole time."

"Then negotiations are open." She said it flat, but her counter clicked twice in her pocket, and Soren had begun to learn that the counter never once told him something she hadn't already counted.

Dax, banking his piece, said, too lightly, "Rooftop perfume. Grand. I bill extra for Court work," and then was quiet, which was the loudest thing Soren had seen him do.

They packed the harvest, took the fish-market stairs two at a time, and were through the cordon before the militia finished arguing about its bell. At the door of the tally-house, going in, Soren put his hand in his coat pocket for his keys and found paper.

The card was thick as bark and dry as a file. It smelled of crushed flowers and cold wax, and it had been in his pocket through all of it, through the tide and the harvest and the quarters of a bell when his heart had tried to leave through his back, and he had never once felt it arrive.

The handwriting on it was old-fashioned, upright, and very beautiful, and there was nothing on the card but an address.

For the Seventh.

CHAPTER 7

The Missing Sixth Floor

Nine days after the card, Soren went back to work.

The Concord had wanted him moved into the tally-house dormitory, permanent, with his meals counted and his sleep counted, and he had refused in writing, twice, and then once more aloud, and Ilse had backed him with an argument he would remember: "A gravid who loses his daylight trade loses his alibi for being human. Let him keep the mortuary. Morticians have the best excuse in the city for smelling of the dead." So he kept Salt Row, and kept the ledger voice, and Greech, who missed nothing and mentioned less, said only, at the end of the first week back: "You've stopped smelling of the workshop. Whatever soap that is, don't bring it near the parish dead."

"It's new," Soren said.

"New things always are," Greech said, and went back to yelling at an invoice. Then, without looking up: "Gray coats came by Tuesday. Asking about the anniversary delivery. Asked whether the assistant was the same assistant." The pen scratched. "Told them the assistant was the same assistant, and that the assistant files like a bailiff, and they left. They didn't like the second part. Nobody likes the second part."

On the ninth night of his return, the fog came in low and close, with that faint sweetness in it that the whole city had agreed not to discuss, and the mortuary was quiet, and Soren went up the back stair to the drying loft with a lamp in one hand and a bundle of ledgers under his arm, the way he had gone up that stair four hundred times since he was seventeen.

The back stair had sixty-four steps. He had counted them on his first night in the house, when counting was all the family he had brought with him, and he had counted them a hundred times since, because stairs are honest and don't move.

Seventy-six.

He stopped on the landing that had never been there, twelve steps above the loft, and made himself do the arithmetic again, aloud, in the dead room's silence. Sixty-four steps to the loft. He had climbed seventy-six. Somewhere behind him in the dark, twelve steps had been added to a stair that had stood for ninety years, and they had been added without a sound, the way the Court put cards in pockets.

There was a door on the landing.

It was a good door, mortuary stock, black-grained, with a brass knob gone dull in the way brass goes dull only where hands have not touched it for years. There was no number on it.

There was nothing on it. And through the crack under it, the light of his own lamp was bending, leaning toward the gap the way the fog leaned toward his window on the morning he woke up with two heartbeats, and the smell coming through the gap was crushed flowers and cold wax.

He knew what a Fold was now. He had walked into one through his own bedroom wall with a fire-iron and a bad attitude. He stood on the impossible landing, being careful, being mortal, being the man who counts, and he thought about the wall of the missing, and about who in Greyharbor kept gardens in impossible places.

He opened the door, because in the end he was always going to open the door.

* * *

The sixth floor was a garden.

It was loam underfoot, black and soft and cold as the inside of a grave, and it went back much further than the building went, much further than the block went. Overhead hung a canopy of pale caps, tiers of them, gentle as the underside of a mushroom, sifting a light that did not come from anywhere. And in rows that a gardener's pride had laid out, in beds that a gardener's knee had weeded, teeth were growing.

Hundreds of them. Human teeth, and some not, planted upright in the loam like bulbs, root up, crown up, furred with a moss so fine it might have been velvet. They gave off a hum. Not a sound, exactly: a word-shaped warmth, each tooth humming with something that pressed on the ear the way a word presses on the mind when it is said too softly to be heard. Last words, he thought. He had a professional instinct for last words, and the whole field of them was humming at once, and his kill-sense, for the first time since he had grown it, told him nothing at all, because nothing in the garden was owed. Everything in it had already been paid.

Soren stood among the beds and counted, because that was what he had instead of screaming. Three hundred and thirty-one. Each root carried a tally mark filed into the tooth itself, neat as a clerk's stroke. He did not know the count they referred to. He wrote down the number in his notebook, because some counts keep you sane by agreeing to be kept.

Once, only once, he crouched at the edge of the third bed, where a tooth smaller than the rest hummed warm against his palm, and let himself begin to listen. The hum sharpened as he leaned, gathering itself toward a word the way fog gathers toward a lamp, and the word was almost a shape he knew, was about to be a voice, was a heartbeat away from being somebody's last breath said out loud into a stranger's hand, and Soren sat back on his heels and stopped listening, because he understood, in the marrow the trade had built into him, that a last word is a thing you are given or a thing you take, and he had no right to take this one. The tooth

hummed on, patient, unspent.

The wallpaper was on the stairwell behind him. That was the wrong thing to say and it was the true thing: the wall he had come in through was papered, and the paper ran up the wall and along the wall, climbing vine-work, flower after flower after flower, and the flowers were spelled. He saw it the way you see the second image in a puzzle picture. The vines were letters. The garden was a book, and the book was reading him.

At the height of a standing man's eyes, in letters of vine and tendril, in a hand older than the house and younger than the fog, the wallpaper said:

SOREN VALE.

And beneath the name, in the same patient growth:

THE SPOREFALL WAS PLANTED. ASK THE CONCORD WHO SOWED.

He read it four times. He copied it twice, once in his notebook and once by saying it aloud in the dead room's silence, because a thing said out loud is harder for a quiet world to change. When he spoke, every tooth in the garden chimed, faintly, together, like glasses at a funeral breakfast, and the hum of them rearranged into a single held note that he felt in his new organ like a hand laid flat on his sternum, and then it let go.

In the paper, in among the vines, there was a face. He had missed it because it was only a face the way the walker had been only rigging: eyes closed, mouth a folded leaf, breathing. He was sure it was breathing, because the vine-work around it swelled and settled, swelled and settled, with the patience of something that had been standing in that wall since before the Sporefall, waiting for a man who could see Folds to climb a stair that did not exist and read its name in the paper.

He did not ask it anything. He thought about it. He stood in the garden of the dead's discarded teeth with the question in his mouth like a hot coin, and he thought about the word sowed, and he thought about the Concord's wall, and about Ilse's counter, and about how much he did not yet know about who counted for whom.

"Who sowed?" he said at last.

The face did not wake. The teeth hummed. The light sifted down like flour through cloth, and the garden smelled of crushed flowers and cold wax, of anniversary fog, of perfume, and Soren Vale, novice of the Veridian Concord, stood alone in the sixth floor of a five-floor building and understood that he had just been handed the bill for something his city had been paying on since the sky came down.

He backed out. He closed the good door on brass that no hand had touched. He counted his way down: sixty-four steps to the loft, and the count came out honest, and he stood in the

drying loft among the hanging linens with his lamp up and his heart going like a pressman's wheel.

In the loft's dark window, his reflection turned away from the stair.

He did not. Not for one heartbeat, and then not for two, and the reflection stood there in the glass with its lamp raised, looking up at a landing that was no longer there, patient as arithmetic, keeping its own count, and it let him walk off alone into the house below.

CHAPTER 8

First Essence Burned

The safehouse was under the mortuary, which had been Greech's idea, or Greech's price, depending which Concord clerk you asked. The old plague laying-out hall beneath Salt Row had tables of bolted iron and a history of receiving things the city preferred not to mention, and for seven years the Veridian Concord had stored its Greyharbor archive there: crates of sealed glass, ledgers bound in fish-skin, a rack of tinctures graded by tier, and one long crate with no label that Ilse would not let him open.

"Catalogue, don't pry," she said that night, chalk in hand, ticking the rack. "Curious gravid die of curiosity and the house buries the question with them. Tinctures, four through nine: read them off."

He read. It was past second bell, the fog was close on the street above, and the undercroft smelled of camphor, glass, and his own family's trade. He had been at it an hour when his kill-sense, which had been resting quietly all evening like a cat in a laundry basket, opened all the way up.

Every heartbeat in the room was owed.

Ilse's. His own. It had never said his before.

"Vann," he said, and she was already turning, chalk still in her hand, and the counter in her pocket clicked, and clicked, and went to a run.

The iron-filing wards around the door guttered out one ring at a time, and the ramp down from the coal chute filled with footsteps that arrived a half-second late, and they came down into the lamplight: five of them, in nice coats, in dockside broadcloth, in one case in a bishop's grey, and every one of them was somebody. That was the horror of them. They had faces Soren knew from the parish ledger. They had pupils like lit wicks, and at every throat, under the jaw, a soft gold light beat like a lamp behind silk.

"Good evening," said the one in front, in the voice of a dockhand Soren had laid out in the spring, drowned off Ropewalk, twenty-six years old, no next of kin. The voice was kind. The mouth that made it was a stranger's mouth, and it smiled with great courtesy. "Forgive the hour. Her ladyship asks after the Seventh."

"The house," Ilse said, level, moving to put herself between the ramp and Soren, "keeps no Seventh."

"It does," the thrall said politely. "It has kept one since before he was born. But her ladyship is patient, and so are we, and we are only asked to deliver a greeting tonight. Stand aside, tallyman. This is the smallest of favors."

Ilse did not stand aside. Ilse did anything but stand aside.

Soren had seen her fight once, in the yard, drills with the porter, and had thought: quick, tidy. What she was under the lamp was something else, a counting of distances so fast it looked like prophecy. She broke the first thrall's knee with the chalk-holder's edge, took its wire-hand and used it, put a second one into the wall hard enough to crack the plaster through to brick. The third and fourth circled. The thrall-master watched from the foot of the ramp with its borrowed voice and its courteous hands, and between those hands, as the bishop-grey one came at her, it shook out a length of light.

The lantern-wire went through her guard like a bill through a shop window. It took her left hand at the wrist, clean, without a sound worth remembering.

The hand fell among the tincture crates. Ilse looked at it, one full second, the way she looked at everything, and then she was fighting one-handed, and winning the exchange, and screaming was something she had evidently decided against on principle. Her counter lay on the floor by his boot where it had fallen from her pocket, still clicking, faithful as a heart.

The thrall-master stepped past her toward Soren.

He had time to be afraid. Then the fear went through him and came out the other side organized, and the world slowed down the way the world does in dreams, and he understood what was happening to him because a part of him had been counting toward it since the canal. The essence of weeks of harvest rose in him like a tide finding its mark. His heartbeat and the second, smaller heartbeat behind his sternum, out of step since the night they met, came together on one count, and locked.

The provisional oath came back to him whole, finished by something older than his memory of it. Iron in his teeth. Iron filings and copper and rain. The Ninth.

And the Fade, prompt as any clerk, took its fee on the spot. He reached for something to steady himself with and found a hole with clean edges where a smell should be: the bakery on the harbor quay, morning, the smell of bread coming off the ovens across the water. He knew

what was gone the way you know a lifted coin. He would never smell that bakery again. He filed the loss and kept his feet, because the kill-sense had not stopped, and the kill-sense was looking at the thrall-master.

That one is owed, it said, with the calm of arithmetic. Now.

The thrall-master was fast. It was not faster than a man with nothing left to lose standing between two old lifting tables. Soren went down before it, the way bodies go down in his trade, under its reach, and his hand found the lift pawl on the iron frame, the ratchet that holds a table's counterweight for the living and lets it go for the dead. The thrall-master bent to take him by the collar, courteous to the last, and Soren Vale, mortuary assistant, third-generation counter of other people's endings, released the brake.

The brass column came up like a verdict. It caught the thrall under the jaw with the whole stored weight of the counterbalance behind it, and the borrowed voice stopped being borrowed, stopped being anything, and the body went up and back and broke across the head-board with a sound like the wet book closing that Soren had heard once before, on Grennel Street, with a spade in his hands.

The light at its throat guttered and died. The wire of lantern-light fell from its hands and was only a length of pale cord.

In the sudden stillness, the remaining thralls stopped. They turned, all four, with the smooth simultaneity of weathervanes, and looked at him kneeling among the tables with his hands still on the iron, and their wick-lit eyes did something he would spend a long time failing to describe: they lowered. The way eyes lower to a rank.

"How good," said one, in a voice like a bell heard through a wall, "that her ladyship's letter found its house."

They went up the ramp together, unhurried, and the dark took the sound of them a half-second late, and the perfume of crushed flowers and cold wax hung in the undercroft like a signature.

* * *

Soren tied off what was left of Ilse's wrist with the tourniquet cord she told him how to tie, her voice level the whole time, correcting his grip once. He carried her up the stair to the parish kitchen, set her down by the stove, and gave her the brandy Greech kept for witnesses. Her left sleeve was a weight of blood. Her face was gray as the fog and perfectly arranged.

"Report," she said, before he could speak. "Thirteen minutes ago you were Tenth Essence. You are not Tenth now. Say what you are."

"Ninth," Soren said. His voice worked. That seemed like a lot to ask of it. "The Codex sealed. Predator. I felt it set like a bone."

"Then you are the fastest climb this house has logged in forty years, and every old man on the Circle of Leaves will now be glad of you and afraid of you in exactly that order." She looked at her own bound wrist and clicked the counter once against it with her right hand. "Ilse Vann, third circle. I am down one hand and up one novice. The house pays its debts. It will owe you a surgeon, a season of tincture, and more answers than it has ever given a novice, and I will be in the room when it gives them, because the Circle does not like to say the word sowed in front of witnesses, and I have just heard what your wallpaper asked you."

"You heard about that too."

"I count things, boy." For the first time since the wire, something moved in her face that was not bookkeeping. "Concord owes you answers. Take them. But hear the arithmetic underneath: the Court sent five and spent one to deliver a greeting. That is not an attack. That is a calling card laid on a grave, and graves mean courtship with her ladyship. She knows your name's number, Soren. She has known it longer than you have."

He sat with that, and with the brandy, and with the warm weight of the watch against his chest, ticking where it had never ticked.

He thought of the wall of the missing, and the seer's vine-script, and a tall thing applauding in the dark of his own street, and a lady who signed her letters in perfume. The Concord owed him answers, and he meant to collect them, every one, with a bailiff's interest.

But first, he owed the Court a visit.

CHAPTER 9

Apothecary Blackwing

The stairs behind House Blackwing's herbarium went down farther than the house stood tall. Soren counted them out of habit, the way he counted everything: forty-one to a landing, a landing to the next, the gas jets shrinking and going green as the dark rose around them like water. Ilse walked ahead with the lamp. Her left sleeve was pinned at the wrist, the bandage beneath had seeped through twice since the raid, and she carried the light in her right hand without once reaching for a railing that was no longer there.

"Rules of the deeps," she said without turning. "Touch nothing that grows. Drink nothing you are offered. If you smell honey, walk the other way."

"What if it smells like honey and offers to carry my kit?" Dax asked from behind Soren, breathing hard.

"Then it is lying twice and you are only the third lie. Keep up."

"Why school a weapon at all?" Dax said. "Point it at something."

"Because at Ninth you will brew soon, Merrow, and brewing badly is how apothecary houses burn with everyone asleep inside them."

"I sleep very lightly."

"You will sleep lighter."

The last landing opened into the receiving hall of the Concord deeps: a vault of black waxwood ribs, a table down its spine long enough to lay out three bodies on. Seven chairs stood behind it, five were filled, and the ceiling lamps were hooded to a brown dusk, so the Leaves sat in half-dark the way their letters were written. At the center sat a gray man with kind eyes folded into gentle wrinkles. Primate Aldous Crane did not look up until Soren stopped at the chalk line on the floor, and then he looked the way a physician looks, all the way through.

"Soren Vale. Registered this morning at Ninth Essence. Predator, sworn and sealed." Crane folded his hands. "Ten days from corpse-cart to Codex. The Concord thanks you for coming down quietly. Some of our guests arrive fighting."

"I was carried," Soren said. "It seemed polite."

A brooch like a copper leaf caught the light at the far chair. Its wearer, a wide man with vinegar in his face, spoke without being addressed. "Ninth in ten days is not a boy's pace. It is a designed pace. Write it in the record and read it back to ourselves until we are properly

frightened."

"It is written, Leaf Ostler," Crane said mildly. "Everything is written. That is the Concord's disease and its cure." He inclined his head to Soren. "You will study in the scribing hall. You will brew on a licensed bench and nowhere else. You will keep tallyman Vann between yourself and your own enthusiasm. And you will bring this house one honesty a day. That last is not a rule. It is a favor I am asking."

"And if I run out?"

"Then you will be an entirely ordinary member of the Concord," Crane said, "and we will all be relieved."

Someone down the table laughed and disguised it as a cough.

* * *

The scribing hall held ninety desks under brass lamps, and the air had a taste to it: iron-gall ink, clove oil, hot chalk, and beneath all of it the sweet-rot smell of Hollow stock stoppered in jars along the north wall. Chalkboards covered the end wall with spirals of notation, loops nested in loops, like the growth rings of a tree that had never stood on land. Students bent to their desks and recited under their breath, and the recitation made a sound Soren felt behind his sternum, where the Lacuna drifted and listened.

"Vale. The fighter. Good." Preceptor Ansel was a small man with chalk in his eyebrows and a voice pitched for the back row. "Fight after you understand. Not before." He laid one finger on the nearest spiral. "A tincture is three things. The beast, the bench, and the words. The beast is Hollow stock, rendered and stilled. The bench is license, glass, and heat. The words are a gene-script, memorized and spoken while the brew turns. The script is an instruction. It tells your passenger what to make of the meal."

"And without the words?"

"Then the brew does not fail." Ansel tapped the board twice, and chalk dust went up like pollen. "It improvises."

"Improvises," Dax said.

"There is an older word. Amalgam. A generation ago it was spoken loudly, and what it built is still behind sealed wards. You will memorize your scripts and speak them exactly, or you will join the syllabus." Ansel looked at them the way schoolmasters look when they have buried students. "Begin."

The novice script was sixty-one words, written to be spoken at the speed of a slow pulse. Soren recited it with the board in front of him, and at the ninth word his forearm prickled like a limb remembering frost; at the thirtieth the prickling climbed to the shoulder; at the last word

the Lacuna rolled over behind his sternum, slow and enormous, a whale turning under ice.

"Sealed at Ninth," Ansel observed, "and it still turns its head when it hears its own alphabet. That will keep you humble when rank makes you stupid. Again."

Dax, who could not afford the fees and paid for most things by being useful, stood in the doorway and recited the script once from memory, grinning. Ansel pretended not to notice, which was how Dax got to keep noticing things for free.

"Who writes the scripts?" Soren asked.

"Apothecaries who hate mistakes more than they hate sleep. Every licensed script in this house is signed at its foot. Turn up any folio's colophon and you will find the scribe's mark." Ansel wiped his fingers on his apron. "Scripts are the only honest paper in Greyharbor, Vale. They confess their authors."

At the hall's far end, past the last row of desks, a glazed gallery had been cut into the rock: sealed wards, six of them, lit low. In the third, a young man sat at a desk like theirs, except his knuckles had gone to bark and his palms had grown into the desk's edge, and he was reciting his script wrong, patiently, wrong again, the way a man reads letters from someone who will not answer. In the fifth, a girl with one side of her face smooth as blown eggshell pressed her good cheek to the glass and watched them study.

"They recited badly?" Soren asked.

"They recited short," Ansel said. "Four words missing between them. That is all it takes. That is all it has ever taken." He shut the board's folding cover over the spirals. "Word count is life count. You of all people should appreciate a tally."

Soren appreciated it. He counted the wards again on his way out.

Six.

* * *

At dusk Ilse sent him up with a misfiled folio to return to the herbarium gallery, a two-story rack of dried specimens and ledgers one floor below the street. He took the servant's stair by mistake, a narrow turn the chalk maps of the deeps did not bother to mark, and the stair ended in a corridor instead of a room.

The corridor was wrong before he could say why. It smelled of pressed flowers, down here where nothing had ever grown, and the smell went through him like a hand through a coat pocket. Brass lamps burned at intervals with their hoods turned low. At the corridor's end stood double doors of black waxwood, and every seam of them was flooded with amber sealing wax, and pressed into the wax at every seam, in triplicate, was a seal: a ring around a seven-lobed sprig.

He knew it. He had seen it blotted onto seed packets in a tin on the kitchen sill, stamped into the ends of her letters, pressed into jam lids with a thimble while she hummed. His mother had signed with it the way other people signed their names.

His feet had carried him close before he decided anything. The wax was warm through his glove, warm like a living thing, and the seal drank the lamplight and gave none of it back, and behind his sternum the Lacuna leaned toward the doors the way a plant leans at a window.

Behind him Ilse's brass counter clicked once and went still. She had counted the corridor twice. It was on neither count.

"That passage is on no map I hold," she said quietly. "Whose seal is it, Vale?"

The lamps hissed. The wax held its warmth like a held breath.

His mother's mark.

CHAPTER 10

The Ledger of Flesh

The Fold under the render-yards opened out of a cold-storage wall, a seam of bruised light between hanging carcasses of frost. Ilse went through first with her lamp up. The joiner had fitted her walnut hand overnight, brass pins at the knuckles, and it carried the weight of her kit without complaint; she had already learned to crack its fingers like a man cracking a safe.

"Six tallymen," she said, "three days overdue. Sent down to mark essence-veins for the quarter survey. Names in the report, boots in my memory. We catalogue what we find and we touch nothing we cannot count."

"And if we can't count it?" Dax asked. He had the brewer's kit on his back and a miner's lamp hooked to his belt, and he had already charged Soren two crowns for the oil Soren would inevitably spill.

"Then we run," Ilse said, "and count while running."

The Fold folded them out under the Mycelium Fields. Soren had seen the Hollow's streets, mossed bone and roofless rooms, but the Fields were another order of country. Caps the size of cathedral vaults shouldered up out of the dark, their gills lit from beneath in slow pulses, and the light fell as a pale snow that drifted upward, not down. The ground gave like proofed dough. Somewhere far off, the wet clicked, a sound like many patient mouths.

His kill-sense opened as they walked, that pressure behind the breastbone that pointed at the heartbeat that would stop first. It pointed at nothing. He had learned the feel of that nothing in the deeps: here nothing would die first, because nothing here died. Things in the Fields

accumulated.

Ilse worked the route the way she worked everything, in counts. Two hundred paces between way-marks, lamp raised, thumb resting on the brass wheel of her counter. The essence-veins the lost cell had been sent to chart showed for Soren as a slow brightness under the ground, rivers of the stuff the Hollow made instead of blood, and he marked their bends on the survey sheet while Dax held the light and complained about the damp in strict alphabetical order. It was, for twenty minutes, almost boring. He was learning to distrust boredom in the Hollow the way sailors distrust a flat sea.

They found the harvest-cell's gear before they found the cell. Six lamp-racks, racked neatly. Six rope coils, coiled neatly. Six brass tally badges laid out in a row on a shelf of fungus, polished, aligned, as though someone had tidied them after.

"Nobody flees and stores their ropes," Soren said.

"Nobody flees at all," Ilse said, and clicked her counter once. "Two hundred and eleven paces. The lean-to should be there."

The lean-to was grown, not built: ribs of mossed bone bent and lashed with mycelial cord into a low shelter around a cold hearth of fungus. Inside, in the gill-light, lay nine shapes.

Soren had laid out four hundred bodies in the mortuary and he had a word for each way a body stops being a person. There was no word for this. The first shape kept a human plan, a man's shoulders and a man's jaw, but his ribs were lacquered with gill-structure that opened and closed in a slow rhyme, breathing for him. The second was a woman whose back had grown a shelf of bracket-fungus in folded tiers, like wings pressed flat and dried. The third and fourth had been large men; something had spent them as material, lengthening the arms, splitting the hands into root-fingers that gripped the ground. The rest had gone further, plan dissolving, anatomy remembered only as a rumor. Brass tally badges glinted on all nine.

Polished, he saw. He rubbed one with his thumb and it came up bright, and the bright line ran in an arc, as if the badges had been worn in file and laid down in order, left to right, the way Ilse laid out instruments before a report.

Half of every face was serene. That was the part Soren's hands understood and his stomach refused.

"Six went down," Ilse said. Her voice was the flat one she used for reports. "I count nine shapes."

"Spliced," Dax said quietly. He was gray around the mouth. "Human stock and Hollow stock in one vessel. That is the Heresy, that is exactly the Heresy, and the Heresy is a generation dead."

"It is a week old," Ilse said. She knelt without touching. "Look at the gills. Dew still on them. Blood still wet under the lacquer on that one's arm. The Heresy is not dead, gentlemen. It has been paying its debts elsewhere and moved to town."

They worked the way the Concord had taught them to work a field find, and because the find was flesh, Soren led. The ledger of flesh: he went shape to shape with tags and a stylus, the mortuary in his hands even out here, noting what had been human, what had been taken, what had been added, and where the seams ran. The seams did not run. That was the horror he could not put a number to. Mortuary flesh parted along its injuries; this flesh had agreed with itself.

He wrote gauge and span, seam and join, in his careful ledger hand, because the hand was a rail and the rail was all there was. At the fourth shape he had to set the stylus down and count his own pulse twice, because the fourth shape wore a Concord signet ring gone green on a root-finger, and he had begun, without noticing, to number the shapes the way you number guests at a table you are setting.

"Nine bodies," he said at last, and stopped, because his kill-sense had finally found purchase.

It pointed, faintly, five times.

"Five heartbeats," he said. "Nine shapes. Five of them are alive."

Dax took two steps backward before his spine caught up with his manners. Ilse did not move at all. "Say the count again."

"Five."

They gathered at the lean-to's mouth with lamps shielded, and Soren felt for each heartbeat the way he had felt for the drowned man's pulse on his first shift, two fingers, one count. The first lived behind the gill-ribs, slow as a bell in sand. The second ticked in the wrong place, low right, where a liver ought to be. The third and fourth ran together, a two-beat rhythm in the twin shapes, like partners keeping time. The fifth was a flutter, far in, under the bracket-wings, a bird-heart's rhythm in a body built for ballast.

Five alive. Nine shapes. Six badges.

"Which six went down?" Dax whispered. "Which three came from somewhere else? What were the three?"

"Catalogue first," Ilse said. "Questions after. That is the discipline that keeps the questions answerable."

So Soren catalogued, and his stylus scratched, and the Fields clicked far away, and the upward snow fell on the lean-to's ribs and did not melt. He tagged, he noted, he measured

gill-span and seam-width, and he did the work because the work was a rail to hold in the dark. The ledger of flesh filled page after page in his careful hand.

Somewhere in the fifth shape a drip fell, metronome-steady, into a pool that had no business being so regular. Dax counted it without meaning to, under his breath, one, two, three, and the count steadied him the way counts steadied Soren. "It is nothing," Dax said. "It is drainage." He said it twice, which in this house counted as a prayer.

He was writing the word badge for the sixth time when the nearest shape's mouth moved.

The jaw cracked open along a seam no jaw should have, a hinge of pale gristle, and what came out was not a moan, not a groan, none of the sounds the mortuary had taught him flesh makes when it is spent. What came out was numbers.

"Forty-one," it said. "Forty-two."

The voice was a man's voice, ordinary, worn, a little rough at the edges from smoke. It counted the way a workman counts, absent, even, a tally kept aloud to keep the hands honest. Soren's stylus stopped. Across the lean-to, Ilse had gone from living color to paper.

"Forty-three," the shape said. "Forty-four."

And Ilse's brass tally-counter clicked.

It clicked in her hand the way it clicked at every report, at every muster, at every body she had ever laid out, her double-count, her habit, her iron rule. Except she was not touching it. It sat on her belt, and it clicked forty-three, and it clicked forty-four, and the voice in the mouth grown mostly shut matched it beat for beat, the way a tune matches the instrument it was written for.

"Forty-five," said the shape.

The second twin spoke from the floor, lips Root-split, the same voice with the smile still in it, and the third, and under the bracket-wings the flutter-heart's shape moved its half serene face, and they were all of them counting, in chorus, patient as rain, in a voice Ilse Vann had buried with the first tide seven years ago.

Soren knew it too, then, from the way she stood. Tomas Vann. He had seen the name once, chalked under a photograph in her tally-room, a young man laughing with his collar up.

The counting paused. The whole lean-to paused with it, the gills, the pulses, the upward snow.

"Forty-six," said Tomas Vann's voice, gently, out of five mouths. "You are one behind, little sister."

CHAPTER 11

Dax's Bargain

What spilled from the spliced when the burn took them, Soren drank. He had been starving, the Fields had rung his hunger like a struck goblet, and the Circle ordered the findings rendered anyway, so he knelt in the incinerator room and did what the Lacuna made him and hated it efficiently, in counts, the way he hated everything he could not put down. The fever arrived two nights later, riding in on the tail of that stolen meal. Between its waves, he went down to the recruits' boiler room, because Dax had proctor's rounds to dodge and Soren owed him a cover.

The boiler room belonged to no roster. Its pipes had been condemned a decade ago and its warmth had been annexed by every recruit with a secret: letters, gin, one memorable ferret. Tonight it held a still assembled from a tea urn, a church window's worth of salvaged glass, and copper tubing bent with more hope than skill, and it held Dax Merrow, sleeves rolled, tongue between his teeth, feeding a jar of rendered Hollow stock into the turn with the tenderness of a man feeding his grandmother.

"Proctor's round in four minutes," Soren said.

"Four. Good." Dax did not look up. "Nine little bottles, Vale. Nine. If he finds one, I lose the bench, the fees, and the skin off my knuckles."

"What are they?"

"Courage for the harvest-cells, steadiness for the watch rota, sleep for the archivists. All of it harmless. All of it brewed on an unlicensed bench, which makes it a crime the way breathing through the wrong window is a crime." Dax wiped the condensation from a gauge with his shirt hem. "Sanctioned tinctures cost what my mother makes in a month. Unsanctioned cost me scruple, and I have budgeted for that."

Above them the corridor door shuffled, and keys sang, and Soren was already moving. He met Proctor Gedd at the head of the stair with a mortuary tray held out level, on it a lamp gone to black and a jar of something gray and pickled, and his face arranged to the precise temperature of bad news.

"Seepage from the herbarium stack," Soren said. "Condensate into the wick-store. I need your signature on a contamination docket before I can vent this floor, proctor, and if the venting goes in the log unsigned, it is your name the Circle reads at quarter review."

Gedd's face did the arithmetic of a man weighing a smell against paperwork. Paperwork won. He signed against the wall, fled the corridor, and Soren was back down the stairs before

the keys stopped singing.

"Contamination docket," Dax said, admiring.

"There is no docket. There is no wick-store. He was too afraid of quarter review to check." Soren set the tray on the boiler. "You were saying nine."

"Nine." Dax pulled one small bottle from the rack and turned it to the lamp. "It is not the crime I mind. It is the reason. Eleven crowns a quarter for our rooms on Coil Street, and rising since the Sporefall, because the landlord says the fog eats his slates. My mother takes in mending. Her hands are going; she drops the small needles now and laughs about it." He put the bottle back as gently as an egg. "Rent is not a number, Vale. It is a countdown."

"Who buys?"

"A collector."

"Collectors of what?"

"Steadiness, courage, sleep." Dax grinned, and the grin did not reach anywhere near his eyes. "You cover me, I cut you in. Ten percent."

"I do not want your ten percent."

"Everyone says that the first time."

* * *

The fever took him that night in the little room over the mortuary cart-shed, and it was not like the growth fevers the others had described, fire and climbing. It was cold. It was a tide going out through him, wave by wave, and each wave went out along a different shore.

The Lacuna stood wide open behind his sternum, gorge-lit, drinking, and the Fade came to collect in its patient order.

It had already taken smells. He had learned that after the last fever without noticing the lesson: he could no longer find her soap in memory, the oilcloth smell of the kitchen, the green bite of stems under her thumb-nail. Rooms he could keep. Dates he could keep. The smell of her had gone to the Hollow months before he knew there was a war for it.

Tonight the tide went out along her face.

He stood in the shallow dark of the fever and reached for it the way you reach for a stair in a house you have lived in all your life, and the stair was not there. He had the brow. He had the laugh-lines, the particular way one corner of her mouth went up before the rest decided to. He had flour once on her cheekbone in the yellow kitchen light. The parts were all in his hands and the center would not close over them, and he stood there holding pieces of her while the fever breathed.

He lit the lamp. He took charcoal and paper like a man taking tools to a wound, and he drew her, and the drawing was of a stranger. Kind mouth, maybe. Tired eyes, maybe. Maybe was all that was left, and maybe is not a face.

The watch was in his palm without his remembering taking it out, her stopped pocket-watch, brass gone soft at the edges from her pocket and then his. He opened it. The hands stood at a quarter to midnight where they had stood for seven years. He still had the watch. He could describe the watch to a jeweler across a table, the worn crest, the chain's kink at the second link. The watch was a face he could keep, and her face was not, and somewhere out under the city the Hollow now wore her at its leisure, because the Hollow was built of exactly this, taken by exactly this tide.

"Maerwen Vale," he said aloud, to the little room.

The name still held weight. The name still held warmth, a hearth-radiation, a gravity. The name was a door with nothing behind it that he could see.

He sat on the floor with his back against the bed until the fever's tide turned, and he did not sleep, and in the morning Dax found the drawing and looked at it and looked at him and put it face down with a gentleness that was worse than any comment.

"Fade took the kindest first," Soren said. "She warned me it would."

Dax said nothing clever. He went out and came back with bread and butter and a hard-boiled egg and put them in front of Soren and said, "Eat. The Fade eats you, you eat back. That is the whole of my philosophy and it has kept me beautifully alive."

* * *

Two nights later the buyer came.

Soren heard the soft boots on the stair, a man walking as if the stair were owed courtesy, and stepped behind the water tank with his heart going like a trapped bird. The boiler light laid stripes across the stranger: storm-gray coat, gloves, a collar that had never known fog. He counted the little bottles without touching them, nodded once, and paid Dax in crowns counted out onto the boiler's warm brick, nine of them, each set down with a click like Ilse's counter.

"For the inconvenience," the buyer said, and added a tenth object, not a coin.

It was a crystal phial the length of a thumb, sealed with a drop of black wax, and pressed into the wax was the imprint of a lantern. Even sealed, it breathed. Galls and honey, and under that something like struck flint, a scent Soren had smelled exactly once before, drifting down from a rooftop during curfew, folded into a calling card addressed to the Seventh.

Dax took it the way people take tips from their betters, pleased and careful, not looking at it too hard.

The buyer turned to go. In passing, gloved fingers rested a moment on Soren's shoulder, light as a toll paid, and the soft boots went up the stairs and away, and the boiler room was just a boiler room again.

Soren stood in the warm dark and did his sums, and the sums came out wrong in a way he did not have numbers for yet.

Court perfume. The Court was already paying Dax.

CHAPTER 12

The Botanist's Letter

The strip of wallpaper had ridden in the bottom of Soren's kit since the sixth floor: a hand's length of paper gone velvety with Hollow growth, its pattern of nested spirals faintly luminous, cut from the garden of teeth the night a seer had grown a message into it with his name in it. Ilse had wanted it filed. He had filed it in his boot instead, and it had traveled there through the raid, the deeps, the Fields, and two fevers, and now he laid it on a table in the Damp Archive between a chalk sluice and a lamp hooded to embers.

Getting it read had taken three days of asking, and the asking had taught him the Concord's shape: every door wanted a count of favors behind it, and every favor wanted a witness. In the end Ilse had walked him down herself, signed the reader's roll with her name and her rank, and dared the archive's warden with one look to find a regulation against it. Now she stood by the door with her arms crossed, walnut hand uppermost, pretending to read the fire notices.

"I need this read," he said.

The Damp Archive lived below the tally-room, and it was kept the way hospitals keep burns: shelves in running water channels so thin the paper never quite touched, chalk basins steaming at every aisle's end, the air mineral and cold. Paper bloomed in Greyharbor. The Concord spent half its budget keeping knowledge from becoming a garden.

Archivist Hollis came down the aisle at the smell of a problem. He was a small round man with cotton gloves and fingerprints permanently gray from forty years of ink, and he looked at the strip the way misers look at coins of an old reign.

He cotton-gloved the strip onto a frame with the tenderness of a nurse turning a patient. "Grown, you say. On the sixth floor. In a Fold." He read the fire notices over Ilse's shoulder without moving his eyes. "Then the paper is still alive, and you have carried a living script through two fevers and a field action. Do not do that again. And also, come here, and do not tell anyone I said come here."

"Where did you get quadrant notation," he said, "on wallpaper?"

"It was grown, not printed. There is a message in it. The Sporefall was planted. Ask the Concord who sowed." Soren kept his voice down among the shelves. "I want the rest of what it says."

"The rest is the dangerous part." Hollis drew a lens on a brass arm from his sleeve, clipped the strip flat, and bent until his nose nearly touched the paper. He was quiet for a long time. Water ticked in the channels. Then he began, softly, to laugh, a horrified upstairs laugh pressed flat by the archive's rules.

"Hollis."

"This is not a message written in script, Vale. This is the script itself, grown letter by letter for anyone patient enough to read the pattern. Do you know what you are looking at? The spirals are helix notation. The bands between are feed-rates. This ringed figure here is culture-scale." He straightened, and behind the lens his eyes were wet with the particular grief of scholars. "This is a production recipe. A recipe with a culture-scale measured in weather."

"Say it plainly."

"Somebody brewed the Sporefall," Hollis said. "The whole sky of it, one bloom, one night. The seer did not warn you. The seer gave you the invoice."

"Can the script be killed?" Soren asked. "The way a brew is stilled?"

"You can burn the paper," Hollis said. "You cannot unbrew the sky. That is the whole tragedy of gene-script, Vale. It is not a curse on the world. It is an instruction the world was hungry for."

Soren heard his own pulse in the water channels. Behind his sternum the Lacuna turned over slowly, listening.

* * *

They worked by ember-light with the door locked and Ilse's chair under the handle.

"Who else knows this notation?" Ilse asked.

"Nobody under forty," Hollis said. "We discontinued it when I was an apprentice. We call it the third recension. It was our licensed cipher for gene-scripts, the old Concord standard, and it was retired because the mathematics is honest and honest mathematics frightens the sort of men who fund us. These band figures, feed-rate over time, are its signature. You cannot fake them by eye. You learn them at a scribing desk with a preceptor beating time with a stick." He peeled the lens across the strip. "Forty years old, this hand. Give or take a year. Whoever wrote it learned the craft two generations before you were born, in a Concord hall, on a licensed

bench, and was good. Very good. The feed-rates are elegant. I have not seen elegant in a decade."

"The Sporefall was seven years ago," Soren said. "The script is forty. Someone carried it for thirty-three years."

"Somebody carried it," Hollis agreed, "and chose the anniversary of something to loose it on. Or the script waited, as scripts do. Paper is patient. So are the people who write it."

He chalked a spiral on the sluice's dry edge to show them: loop within loop, band within band. "Feed-rate. This is the beast being told how fast to eat. And here, the bloom-window." His chalk stopped. "One night. It is even specified to the hour, the way you would specify a kettle. Somebody planned the Sporefall down to the bell, and the bell they planned it on is a date I do not know. The notation does not say. It does not have to."

He glanced at the door, then at Ilse, then lowered his voice as though the shelves could be embarrassed. "There are volumes in the closed stacks on this notation. Confiscated. Heresy trials, a generation back. The Amalgamists wrote beautifully, that was the tragedy of them, and the Circle burned the scribes and shelved the scripts. If your wallpaper writer learned from our own stacks, then the Concord taught the sky to bloom."

"That is a serious charge to make against shelves," Ilse said.

"It is a serious archive," Hollis said, unoffended.

"Who can reach the closed stacks?" Ilse asked.

"Anyone with a Primate's countersignature and enough patience. The stacks are organized by trial and indexed by confiscation date. I could stand you on the shelf the Amalgam scripts live on, and you could count the gaps, and the gaps would tell you nothing, because I rebind everything, and rebinding hides its hands."

Soren watched the spirals scroll under the lens. Sixty-one-word scripts bit his forearm in the scribing hall; this one, grown across a district's worth of paper, had eaten half a city. He thought of Ansel's board, loops nested in loops, growth rings of a tree that never stood on land, and of the wards at the hall's end, the bark-knuckled boy reciting wrong. Word count is life count. Somewhere a preceptor had beaten time with a stick for the person who wrote the sky.

His hands were steady. He noted that with the distant professional interest of a mortuary man watching his own case proceed. Behind his sternum the Lacuna had gone very still, the stillness of something listening through a wall it had been born behind.

"Can you tell me the writer?" he asked.

"I can tell you what every licensed script can tell you." Hollis said it with archivist's ceremony, sliding the strip a final inch into the light. "A script confesses its author. At the foot

of the notation, where a scribe signs the colophon, there is a mark pressed into the growth. See it? The paper swells around it. It was written last, with the whole recipe behind it, the way a man breathes out after lifting something heavy."

The three of them leaned over the strip together, three faces over one small fire of paper, and Hollis read the mark aloud in the tone men use for catalogues.

"A ring. Closed. And inside the ring, a sprig with seven lobes. Seed-lobes, by the drawing. A botanical chop, a gardener's signature, pressed like a seal."

Soren had seen it blotted onto seed packets in a tin on a kitchen sill. He had seen it pressed into jam lids with a thimble, into the ends of letters with a wet thumb, warm wax at the seams of a corridor under House Blackwing that was on no map and answered no count.

"Maerwen," he said. The name came out of him the way the count had come out of the spliced, even and terrible. "Her name was Maerwen."

Hollis and Ilse both went still, the different stillnesses of a scholar and a soldier.

At the foot of the final spiral, swollen into the paper like a seal into wax, sat the scribe's mark.

His mother's mark.

CHAPTER 13

Whispers in the Slate Market

He could not demand answers from men who owned the doors, so he went where answers were sold by weight. The choice was not brave. It was arithmetic. The sky had been brewed on a licensed bench by a scribe forty years dead or hiding, a corridor under the Concord smelled of his mother, and the Primate's kindness had no floor he could stand on. Soren was Ninth Essence with a single organ to his name and a Fade that had begun taking faces. Whatever came for Greyharbor next, he could not meet it at Ninth.

"If you must be a fool," Ilse said, when he told her, "be a polite one. The Slate Market opens when the fish exchange closes. And ask for Marrow. Marrow never lies." She clicked her counter once. "He also never finishes the truth. Count his sentences before you sign one."

The Brine Stair went down behind the fish exchange through forty years of scales ground into the steps, and at the bottom, where the tide used to reach, the old auction hall opened up under a bell that had not rung since the Sporefall. Stalls crowded the waterline. Memory vials hung in graded racks, amber to black, with prices chalked by the year of the feeling. Next door a vendor sold false tinctures, corked hope in pretty glass, warranted genuine by a wax stamp of nobody at all. Down the row a Mummer leaned against a pillar wearing a borrowed face two sizes too young for it, and looked at Soren with eyes that were shopping. Soren showed it a face worth keeping: the mortuary's flattest professional calm, a man here on unpleasant necessary business. The Mummer's borrowed smile widened by a fraction, filing him.

The market had rules chalked above the bell. Show no face you cannot lose. All debts are literal. No names but the ones you sell.

Marrow's stall was not the largest but it was the best lit, a counter of black slate with a jeweler's scales on it, and behind the scales stood a gray man with a gray coat of many pockets and the cheerful patience of a man who has heard every opening offer ever invented.

"The tallyman's new ninth," Marrow said. "Or should I say the widow Vale's boy. You have your mother's walk. She bargained like a subsidy and paid like a fine. Sit. Everything costs. Sitting costs nothing tonight, in honor of your grief."

"You know why I am here."

"You want to know who moves Moltwater in my city. Galls and honey and flint under it, the Court's own toilet water, sold in my market only to gentlemen who buy it for other gentlemen." Marrow turned the scales' brass weight over with one finger. "That answer is expensive, love. But I will discount it against something you carry, because I have been

waiting years for you to walk in looking exactly like that. The sea. Whole and unspoiled. You were born on the water side of the harbor and I can hear it in you still."

"I do not follow."

"You carry a memory of the sea, boy. The real one. Storm mornings, the fleet going out, gull-clatter, your mother's hand around yours on the pier rail." Marrow smiled with real warmth, which was the worst thing about him. "It is the last unspoiled one in Greyharbor under the age of thirty. I have a client who collects exactly that. The trade is this: the sea, and in exchange, the answer you came for. Plus a bonus, because I like you."

The bonus was in his palm before Soren agreed to anything: a thumb of glass stoppered with wax, and inside it a liquid so dark it did not reflect the lamp so much as drink it. The vial was cold through his glove and heavier than glass had any right to be.

"First Essence," Marrow said. "Bottled before you were whelped. There are four phials of it in the world I cannot account for, and this is one, and I am giving it away, which should frighten you more than the price."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then you keep the sea, the answer, and your tier, and one night soon the fog will ask you what you are prepared to be, and you will have nothing in your pocket to show it." Marrow set the scales square. "I never lie, love. I am only ever early."

"Why give me the discount?"

"Because debts like company," Marrow said. "And because a ninth who climbs angry does the market more business than a ninth who climbs careful."

* * *

The tap took place on a stool behind the stall, in a stall of red curtains that smelled of wax and camphor.

Marrow's rig was a thimble of glass on a silver thread, a needle no thicker than a whisker, and a brass cylinder that turned as it filled. The needle went in at the temple and there was no pain, only a sensation of being read. The bell filled with light the color of harbor water. Soren watched his own sea go up the thread: the storm morning, the fleet out, the gulls fighting over a dropped roll, and her hand, cold and ringed and certain, around his on the pier rail.

Then it was in the cylinder and the cylinder was corked, and Marrow was wrapping it in wool like a sweetmeat.

"Do you want to keep the facts?" Marrow asked, professional to the last. "The word, the dates, the names of boats? The client buys the feeling, I can leave you the ledger entry of it."

"No," Soren said. And then, because Marrow never lied and he wanted to hear the shape of it: "What will it be like?"

"Like every coat you ever gave away," Marrow said. "You will remember that you owned it."

He was right. Afterward Soren knew the word sea the way he knew the word chisel. Facts stood in a row and reported for duty: born waterside, pier rail, gulls. The feeling that had made the facts into a morning was gone, sold, corked, and wrapped. He touched his own temple and found no hole.

* * *

He burned the vial in Marrow's back room, on a slate counter, with Marrow supervising from a safe distance and a fire bucket to hand.

"You will scream," Marrow said. "Mind the crockery. It is not mine but I have grown fond of it."

First Essence did not go down like the Fields' stolen meal. It went down like a mine shaft. Soren's knees went first, then his sight, and behind his sternum the Lacuna opened so wide he heard his own blood find new channels, and the fever came and went in the time it takes a kettle to sing. He did scream. The crockery survived. When he stood up, the room's pipe-smoke had turned to glass.

He could see through it. Not past it, through it, every coil and ghost of it lit from within like paper at a window, and beyond the smoke the room's other air was legible too, the damp furred along the wall seams, the heat bleeding off the stove in slow banners. Greyharbor's fog, the fog that had hung for seven years over every street he loved, abruptly stopped being a wall. It had never been a wall. It had only ever been waiting for eyes that could read it. The new hunger arrived on schedule, a wanting with no object, an appetite for whatever was hidden. He caught himself staring at the seams of Marrow's coat, counting its pockets.

"Smoke-sight," Marrow said, and for once the gray cheer was subdued, almost respectful. "Eighth Essence. New organ, new hunger, and you will feel the hunger tonight, love. It wants the obscured. You will catch yourself watching people's closed hands." He held out the fire bucket, unnecessarily. "Congratulations. You are now worth kidnapping."

"What I came for," Soren said. His voice came out sanded. "Moltwater."

Marrow opened his ledger on the counter, a book bound in gray, and wrote the receipt in a hand as neat as money. The book lay open as he wrote, and the standing entries ran down the page in monthly rows, and Soren had stopped being able to look away before he finished deciding to.

Moltwater, one phial. Pale Row. Twelve entries, one to a month, twelve months unbroken, and against every line the same initials in the same unhurried hand.

"You sell to the Concord?" Soren said.

"I sell to gentlemen." Marrow blotted the page, gray and cheerful. "He does not wear it. Nobody wears Moltwater to bed. That is a man buying a conversation, love. He has been buying the same one for a year."

P.C. Twelve entries. Pale Row. The Primate's lodge.

CHAPTER 14

The Chirurgeon of Ashlane

Ashlane asked for help the way Ashlane asked for everything, in silence. The note came up from a washerwoman through three hands to Ilse's tally-box: children going into the cellar under the chandler's on Tannery Row, and coming out quieter, and coming out luminous.

The Circle spent an afternoon on it. Leaf Ostler wanted it watched, in case the clinic was Amalgamist work worth documenting from a distance. Leaf Bracken wanted it raided with a full cell and a witness from the militia. Primate Crane, kind eyes down, said that the poor of Ashlane were owed the same protection as the ledger's entries and no more delay than caution allowed, and managed to mean both halves. It was Ilse who cut it short.

"I have counted what rogue grafting does," she said. "I heard it count back. We go tonight, and we go small."

Leaf Ostler's order had already benched Dax, pending review of the Fields report, so it was the two of them who went down through Ashlane's fog an hour after curfew bell, past tannery vats exhaling their last chemical breath, to the chandler's dark window and the cellar door that smelled, wrong for a chandler, of lavender wax and under it copper.

The washerwoman's note had said luminous, and Ashlane had believed it the way Ashlane believed everything quiet, privately. Lights in children, after the Sporefall, were not a miracle in this district. They were a landlord.

The cellar was warm, which was the first obscenity. Whitewashed brick, rows of pallets, a stove, a kettle, orderly jars with labels in a fair round hand. Six patients were in residence. A haulier sat up on his pallet, proud as a groom, showing the gill-crease in his throat that let him breathe the fog without coughing. A woman held her own wrists and watched light travel under the skin of her forearms in slow dim pulses, and she looked at the light the way people look at a debt collector. A lad of fifteen sat the far pallet with his knuckles gone to bark,

reciting under his breath, patient and wrong, the way the wards in the deeps recited, and the sight of it went into Soren like a hook. The boy was not a ward. The boy was a practice piece. Nobody screamed. That was the second obscenity: this was a ward, and it was tended, and somewhere in Greyharbor the Concord's licensed benches had empty chairs.

"You are Concord," said the man from the inner room.

He came out wiping his hands on a mud-green apron, a big soft-bodied man with an undertaker's gentleness and a case of instruments that Soren's eye catalogued before his stomach could object: chitin scalpels, glass cannulas, bone-saws ground from Hollow teeth.

"Chirurgeon Gorst," he said. "You are up past your licenses, tallyman, and you have brought me a gravid. I can smell the bench on him. Ninth, sealed, Predator, and not yet sworn to anything useful." He smiled with real warmth. "The Concord seals its benches and lets the poor die licensed. I charge less than heaven and I answer letters."

"You are splicing civilians," Ilse said.

"I am grafting civilians. Splicing is what happens when the words go short." Gorst set down his hands. "Every graft in this room takes, tallyman. Ask them. The haulier works double shifts in fog now. Mrs. Anser's arms will carry her to work when her lungs quit, next winter, the way they are going. I refine the craft as I go."

"As you are paid to refine it," Soren said.

Gorst's smile stayed on and stopped being warm.

Then Soren's kill-sense, which had been open since the stair, pointed for the first time all night, and it pointed through the inner doorway, and his stomach dropped through the cellar floor. There was a small bed behind the curtain, and in it a girl of seven or eight with a doll and a blanket, and under her sternum something was blooming, a lantern-organ grafted in half-grown, pulsing light through her nightgown in rhythm with a heart that was losing the argument. The graft was drinking her. It would finish within the day.

He could see the craft in it now, with the organ-man's eye he had never asked for: the pulse of the thing was mite-rhythm, swarm-time, a colony where a gland should be, fed and coaxed and half-taught. The Concord's own novice fevers were gentler than this by orders of mercy.

"Tansy," Gorst said, and for the first time his voice had weight. "Foundling. Board paid by the parish. The graft ran ahead of my notes. It cannot be undone. Grown things can only be ended."

The girl looked past all of them at Soren, because children always found the dangerous one in the room.

"Make the light stop," she said. "It hums."

He had laid out four hundred bodies and he knew every way a body stops being a person, and none of the ways had ever been his to choose. Ilse did not move and did not look away, because she was Ilse. Gorst watched him with the terrible interest of a colleague.

Soren took off his right glove. He crossed the room. He was aware of the kettle, and the doll's enamel face, and the count, his own count, the one he kept to keep his hands honest: her pulse at the throat, quick and small; the graft's glow between his fingers, humming against his palm like a struck bell that would not finish. He did the work the way the mortuary had taught him, in one motion, with economy, with his hand over hers so that the last thing the count held was company.

Ilse's tally-counter clicked once. She counted the dead, always, and this time so did he.

Gorst was already through the coal hatch.

* * *

The fog above Ashlane was a wall to everyone alive. To Soren it was glass.

He came out of the hatch with smoke-sight wide and saw the cellar district lit from within: coal smoke in the yards, steam off the vats, and one warm man-shape galloping between the drying racks with his apron flapping. He did not run. He walked the straight line the fog had stopped being able to hide and arrived at the tannery gate two seconds before Gorst did, and what followed was not a duel. Gorst's left hand became something with too many options; Soren's kill-sense told him which of the options would die first, and Predator had been waiting all autumn for a man whose body believed its own advertisements. By the time Ilse arrived with the lamp, the Chirurgeon of Ashlane was face down in the mud with his wrist bent at the exact angle of a confession.

They interrogated him in the cellar, among his patients, because Ilse wanted witnesses.

"Count with me, chirurgeon," she said, walnut hand flat on his chest. "You will find I never stop."

He counted. He was glad to, in the end, the way spent men are glad of any rail. Payment had come monthly for eight months in phials of perfume he was ordered to wear to certain meetings in Ashlane chapel, a patron in gray gloves whose face he never saw, and instructions in a fair round hand.

"I was told to practice," Gorst said, gray-lipped, on the pallet where Tansy's doll sat looking at him. "Refine the graft. Make it take quickly. Make it take in the young. The tide will need hosts that walk."

He said the last like a prescription. Soren heard the boiler room, the crowns on warm brick, gloved fingers resting on his shoulder light as a toll.

"Whose hand wrote your instructions?" Ilse asked.

"A patron's. The same hand wrote my delivery notes and my wages and my silences." Gorst looked at the ceiling of the cellar as though reading a fair round hand on it. "I was hired for craft, tallyman, not for politics. I practiced. I was paid in perfume and left alone, and in Greyharbor that is the whole of what mercy looks like from below."

Soren filed the hand the way he filed everything now: seven names, seven folios he had not yet seen, a corridor that answered him by touch. The counts were converging. He did not like the shape of the shape they were making.

The chandler's tin box stood open on the bench while Ilse bound the writs in evidence cord: reagents, a Court-stamped writ with a lantern pressed in black wax, and a folded paper of names in a fine looping hand.

Seven names.

The first six the damp of the cellar had made into ghosts, letters gone to lace, recoverable by scholarship and not by sight. The seventh sat black and clean and recent, ink still proud of the paper, as if the list had been written in a hurry from the bottom up.

Soren Vale.

CHAPTER 15

Court of Lanterns

Marrow sold him the masque the way Marrow sold everything, at a fair price and a foul angle. The Court held its Molt-masque at dark of moon in the Grand Canopy, guests admitted by scent, singly, no retinues, and the phial Dax's buyer had left on the boiler brick would open the way for exactly one mortal nose.

"The Court speaks in perfume and debt," Marrow said, wrapping the phial back in its wool as though it were fragile and Soren was not. "Somewhere up there the debts are written down, love. Ledgers. The Court adores a ledger. Now buy a mask you can afford to lose."

"If the Court smells a Concord gravid among them," Ilse said that night, "they will not escort him out."

"They will not smell one," Soren said. "They will smell one of their own, on me, worn as a guest wears a house's colors. And whatever is written in those ledgers, my name is in it now. Ashlane taught me that. I would rather read my page than wait to be read."

He went up alone, because scent-guests came singly and because he counted what he would owe anyone who covered him, and he was tired of spending other people.

"Wear the phial at the throat," Marrow had said, closing the deal with a stamp of wax he did not explain. "And mind whose house scent you are wearing. Moltwater is the Molted Court's own blend. Wren's blend, if we are naming names, and at a masque names are the one currency never spent." He had smiled at whatever his customer's face did with that. "You will be announced as a guest of her house whether she likes it or not. Try to survive the introduction."

The Fold over the Opera Stairs opened in the theater district's oldest ghost light, and folded him out onto a ledge of living wood above the Grand Canopy, and the Canopy did what the Hollow always did to him: it made the city above feel like the sketch and this the finished engraving. Lantern-mites hung in tame galaxies over the walkways, and their light did not flicker so much as breathe. Gall-balconies ringed a hall of vaulted branches. Chitin carriages drew up along a spine of grown road, their harness bells pitched for the aching ear, and when a black carriage rolled past with its windows waxed opaque, the whole gangway bowed to the wax without being asked, a field of shoulders dipping like wheat. Music came from a reed-organ grown into the wall, breathing chords with the patience of a tide. Courtiers poured up the gangways in masks and borrowed faces, and the borrowed faces were the thing that stopped his feet: he watched a Mummer hand a smile across like a hat, and a lady put it on

over her own expression the way one wears another's coat.

His kill-sense opened out of habit and pointed at nothing, and this nothing was different from the Fields' nothing. Nothing in the Canopy would die first because the Court did not die. It moulted. He felt that in his sternum like standing in a room with no floor and being told it was a dance.

He went down the gangway wearing a slate mask with a chipped brow, and the Moltwater phial cracked open under his collar, and the Court admitted him the way a body admits its own blood. Nobody looked at him twice. Twice was what he got.

The masque orbited an empty dais. That was the trick of it, the thing that made his skin crawl: every dancer, every servant, every lantern-bearing child kept one shoulder angled toward the dais and never, ever turned a full back to it, and the dais held nothing but a standing lantern that no one looked at directly. The Lantern King's court orbited his silence like water finds a drain. Once, passing the dais, an old courtier bowed to the emptiness and breathed into another courtier's cupped palm a mouthful of scent, and the other bowed lower, a debt paid, and the ledger of it lived in both their bodies.

He kept to the edges and did his trade's work on the hall: counted the exits, counted the guards, counted the carriages still drawing up. The masks made every face a rumor. A lady with a heron's beak drank one sip from a vial of memory and wept borrowed tears down a borrowed cheek, and the courtier beside her accepted the weeping with a bow, a debt settled, and moved on hungry for the next.

The Ledger Gallery stood off the hall through an arch of fused antlers: standing cases of pale hide bindings, rack after rack, curators of none. The Court wrote everything. That was the indecency of it, Soren thought, working the first case's lantern-wax seal with a mortician's blade. The Court counted souls as stock and then had the patience to keep books about it.

He found the genome-ledger on the third rack, its spine lettered in the fair round hand he had seen in Ashlane, and inside, columns of lineages, rents paid in memories and in children, notes on graft-rates. A lineage of harbor ferriers rented out by the quarter-century and renewed by lot. A breeding of Choir-voices with the venues listed like concert programs. Margins annotated in two hands, one patient, one young and furious, and one column headed with a pressed sprig and the word SEEDS. Seven rows. The seventh row was the newest ink in the book.

He cased it like a folio and turned to leave, and the gallery's lamp-light leaned toward him, and a voice like poured wine said, "At last."

She stood between the racks in layered green-gray silk that moved like moth wings, masked in birch-white, and behind her the two gallery sentries were already walking away,

dismissed by a breath.

"You smell of mortuary soap and mortal brine," Lady Wren said, "and beneath that, seed. Seventh of seven, come up out of the fog to rob my library. Do you know what I admire about the Concord's tailoring? The seams."

He put the blade's tip between them, an old habit of his trade, and she looked at it the way one looks at a child's drawing on a court wall.

"You are going to offer me something," Soren said. "Thieves do not get waited for. Patrons get waited for."

"Apprentice yourself to me." She took his mask off with two fingers, the way one takes a lid off a jar, and studied his face without surprise, without appetite, with a horrible kindness. "I will teach you her alphabet. The one the Concord burns books to forget. I knew Maerwen when she was young and wrong about everything except the important thing."

"What thing?"

"That a starving thing can be fed differently." Wren let the mask drop to his chest, still in his fingers. "Your Concord writes its hypotheses on her work and seals her corridors. My Court writes its appetite on everything it touches. And you, little seed, are being counted by both, and I am the only party at this masque offering you a salary."

"The Concord pays in purpose," Soren said.

"The Concord pays in purpose and collects in everything else. Ask its fourth-year recruits what their scripts cost them. Ask Ilse Vann what her hand bought, and who signed the order that sent her somewhere a hand was the price." The birch mask tilted. "I made this offer once before, to a botanist with your jaw and better boots. She chose the leash and called it duty. Go and look at the shelf her duty sleeps on."

She glanced at the case he had emptied, unhurried, and gestured at it with two fingers, a host waving a guest's oversight through.

"Take the genome-ledger you have already taken. Debts disclosed are debts I no longer owe, and that page has been owed to daylight for a long time. Deliver it where it will do the most damage. You have a talent for exits; I have watched you practice them."

"What do you want for it?"

"For now, only this. Ask me about your mother. You came all this way. It would be a waste of a good nose not to."

The gallery's lanterns leaned in. Somewhere beyond the antler arch the reed-organ changed its tide. Soren counted his pulse twice and made himself say it.

He thought of the drawing lying face down on the floor by his bed, the stranger with the kind mouth. He had come to the Canopy to read his own page in the Court's books. It had not once occurred to him that the books might hold her current address.

"Is she alive?"

Lady Wren leaned close, kind as a knife going in.

"Your mother is not dead, little seed. She is inventory."

CHAPTER 16

The Mother Hypothesis

He walked into the Circle's session at the ninth bell without knocking, because knocking was how one asked to be counted.

Five Leaves behind the waxwood table, the Primate at the center, the lamps hooded to their brown dusk, and Ilse at the wall with her counter silent and her weight even. Soren laid his evidence down the length of the table like a mortuary tray: the genome-ledger from the Grand Canopy, its SEEDS column face up; the Chirurgeon's list, seven names, the seventh fresh; Hollis's sworn finding on the wallpaper script, forty years old, Concord notation; and a page copied from Marrow's ledger, twelve monthly entries of Moltwater to Pale Row.

"Greyharbor's sky was brewed," he said. "On a licensed script. The mark at the foot of that script belongs to Maerwen Vale, who is on your missing-persons wall, whose corridor is sealed behind your herbarium, and whose son you are counting as an asset. The Court has been paying a rogue chirurgeon to practice grafts on children, and its perfume has been standing on this table's credit for a year. I am done asking politely. Open the corridor."

The dusk sat with him for a moment. Leaf Bracken's fan had stopped. Leaf Ostler leaned forward into the lamplight with the face of a man pleased to finally be frightened on the record.

"The corridor is sealed by the order of a Circle gone to dust," Ostler said. "Sealed with the full rite. Sealed for reasons this table inherited and does not question, which is what a table is for. The boy is fevered. Ninth Essence breeds grandiosity, it is in the literature."

"He is Eighth," Ilse said. "He is also the only person in this house whose hand the seal answers, and you have known that since the night he found it, because I filed it and you read what you file." She stepped from the wall, and her voice went to the register she used on the Fields, flat and countable. "I count three sealed doors, one dead brother counting in the dark, a boy's name on a Court list, and a ledger with your Primate's initials buying the Court's voice by

the month. Open it, or stand here while I count you the ways it has already been opened."

"Eighth in a fortnight," Ostler said. "Faster and faster. Gentlemen, the boy is a ladder someone else is climbing. Every argument he makes, hear it in that register."

"I do," Ilse said. "I also hear the register of a house that let a dead woman's son find her work by blundering into a corridor its own maps were ashamed of."

"Leaf Vann overreaches," Ostler began.

"Soren Vale overreaches," Crane said quietly.

The Primate had not touched any of the evidence. His kind eyes had rested on the genome-ledger's open column the way physicians rest on a wound they have been dreading. He folded his hands and let the dusk have a long moment.

"Mr. Vale. You believe this table buried your mother's work and let her vanish into the ledger of it." His voice was gentle and it did not bend. "You may be right. The house will go down together to the corridor, because the truth of a seal should be witnessed by those who keep it. But hear the whole of me, boy. If that door holds what you think it holds, the Concord does not survive it opening the way you have opened it. Nothing does. That is not an argument. It is a forecast."

* * *

They went down in a body, seven Leaves and their Primate and the tallyman and the boy, past the scribing hall's shuttered boards, past the wards where the bark-knuckled boy recited wrong into the dark, to the servant's stair and the corridor of pressed flowers.

The lamps leaned in as Soren approached. The amber seals had kept their warmth all autumn, waiting with the patience of wax. He set his bare right hand against the largest of them, the one at the meeting of the doors, and the Lacuna opened behind his sternum, and the seal drank.

It drank his light the way the Canopy's lantern-fields drank, without malice, without hurry, a rooted thing receiving weather it had been planted for. The amber went from honey to water. Something in the doors turned over, ancient and oiled, a mechanism answered rather than forced, and the seals parted along a seam that had existed since before he was born, and the corridor breathed out pressed flowers and cold stone and, faintly, the ghost of a kitchen.

The Leaves made sounds behind him. He did not turn to catalogue them.

The corridor held a herbarium. Pressed specimens under glass, forty years of dust lying on forty years of order, chalkboards of quadrant notation in his mother's quick slanting hand. Seven folios stood in cradles down the left wall, numbered with Roman strokes, I through VII, spines stamped with the ringed sprig. Against the right wall, behind glass, waited cribs of

seed-glass like reliquaries, each holding a suspension that still moved, slow, patient, alive. Folio VII lay open on a lectern at the corridor's end, and on its first page, in her hand, a title.

The Mother Hypothesis.

Crane came to stand beside him, and for a while the Primate read the chalkboards with his hands behind his back, the way men stand in the houses of the dead. "She was the finest scribe of her generation," he said at last, to the boards and not to Soren. "I signed her commission. I countersigned her seclusion. Both signatures were given with the same conscience, and that is the most frightening sentence I know."

He read the way he counted, and the Circle read over his shoulders, and the corridor held its breath. The hypothesis ran to pages, but its spine was one claim: the Hollow was not a predator. The Hollow was a mother, starving, and a starving mother will eat the household; the cure was not fire, was not feeding, was re-seeding. Seven lineages, designed, grown not chosen, so that what was given to the Hollow would be given by consent. Gravid blood carrying human memory into the canopy the way seed carries a garden into a field gone fallow.

And in the margins, in a second hand, fair and looping and patient, the argument ran the other way. The same seven lineages, read as harvest instead of sowing. Seed-stock, selected and rationed. Ascension, managed. The two readings shared every letter of the data and disagreed about what a person was for.

Folio VII's register page carried the lineages' names and states, and the last entry was the newest ink in the room: Vale, S. Grown, not chosen.

Six of the seven glass cribs stood empty behind their panes, cultures spent or transferred long ago, and their labels were written in a schoolmaster's neatness: cultivated, walked, counted. The seventh label was newer than the rest, and its final line was not a cultivation date at all. It was a delivery date, and it matched, to the week, the night a stopped pocket-watch had ticked once in a mortuary.

"Two readings," Soren said. His voice came out sanded and steady. "Heal it or feed it. She wrote the first. Someone has been editing the second for forty years, and the editing hand bought a year of Court perfume from Marrow, and the Court's list has my name on it, and this table knew."

"The table knew nothing," Crane said, but his hands, folded, had gone bone-white at the knuckle, and no one in the corridor believed him, least of all the table.

They voted at dusk. The corridor would be re-sealed, the folios impounded, the matter held for the whole Circle of Leaves, a phrase which that afternoon acquired the exact smell of a coffin lid. Ostler argued for burning the cribs. Bracken argued for moving them to the deeps.

Crane argued, in the kind granite voice that had carried every vote for twenty years, for patience, and signed the sealing order first, with the complaint of a man signing a mercy.

By evening, pages of the genome-ledger had been copied in three different hands and were moving through the houses like weather. Nobody claimed the copying. Everybody read the copies. Two of the houses wanted Ostler censured over the Fields report. Three wanted Crane's ledger page read aloud at muster. Nobody wanted the thing the pages actually said, which was that every faction in Greyharbor had been bidding on the same boy.

Soren stood in the herbarium corridor while the wax went back over the seal, warm and amber and reeking of pressed flowers, and watched a Circle of Leaves wall up his mother's voice for the second time in forty years.

He had been counted all autumn. By tiers, by lists, by ledgers, by votes, by perfume. Eighth Essence, grown not chosen, and the Court and the Concord both wanted the Seventh, and both counted him the way Marrow's scales weighed memory: as price.

He stopped trusting institutions that night. Let them keep their books. Anyone who counted him as an asset could count without him.

CHAPTER 17

Schism

The wards of House Blackwing began to burn an hour before dawn, and they burned in the order they had been written.

Soren Vale came awake in the novices' dormitory with light crawling up the wall: a soft green flame following the brushed lines of script that had guarded that room for forty years, eating each word backward from its ending. The flame made no heat and less sound. It did not destroy so much as unwrite. He watched a ward that should have boiled the blood of anything Hollow cross the doorframe and go out letter by letter, and he understood the only way script burned like this. Someone inside the house had revoked the counterglyphs. The fire had been invited.

In the corridor the whole household stood with lamps held high, watching their protections die politely.

People watched their protections die the way relatives watch a bier. Nobody spoke above a murmur. An apprentice wept without drama, two fingers pressed to her mouth, and Soren knew the posture from the mortuary: the stance of people waiting to be told what they are allowed to feel.

"The ledger," Ilse Vann said at his shoulder. Her iron-gray braid was half-pinned, put up in haste, and her left sleeve was folded and looped where a hand used to be. She counted the onlookers with one flick of her eyes, the way she counted everything. "Two hundred and eleven souls in this house last night. By breakfast there will be two factions and one fire."

"You're cheerful," Soren said.

"I'm awake. It passes for cheerful."

The morning's second insult was nailed to the refectory door. Twelve pages, copied fair and fast, the ink still smelling of the scribing desks: his mother's sealed corridor, itemized. Her gene-scripts, transcribed. Seven lineages, named by number. The seventh circled twice in a steady hand.

"Nailed up at the turn of the watch," Ilse said. "Before anyone could be shamed into privacy."

Dax Merrow came late to the refectory, which was unlike him, and did not meet Soren's eyes, which was more unlike him. His right thumb moved over the inside of his left wrist, back and forth, the way a man worries a scab. When Soren glanced at the wrist, Dax turned it over and gave his quick grin to the middle distance. "Wild, eh? Who'd even have a Court ledger?"

The answer, which Soren did not say aloud, was: I did. He had stolen it out of the Grand Canopy with lampblack on his face and handed it to the Circle of Leaves, and one of the Leaves had evidently decided the house deserved to know what grew in its cellar.

* * *

They convened in the brewing hall, because it was the largest room with benches bolted down, and because both sides wanted the stills.

The Purists stood beneath the great ward-script with Primate Aldous Crane among them, wax-white leaf badges at every collar. The Amalgamists stood by the stills under Preceptor Roswald Vane, who had rolled back both sleeves to show his forearms: the left was plated in pale chitin, grown in careful squares like a faithful copy of armor. Behind him were the ones the Concord called the grafted. A woman with a film of gill-slit at her throat. A boy whose eyes blinked sideways once in a while, nictitating, patient.

"The wards are burning," Vane said, "because we have spent forty years writing locks in a language our enemy speaks better than we do. The Hollow reads our scripts the way a farmer reads weather. It is not a monster at the gate, ladies and gentlemen. It is a kinsman at the table, and it is starving, and we are pretending not to hear its stomach." He spread his plated arm. "I grafted this to learn it. I have never once been lied to by my own arm."

"Kindly do not say it that way," said the woman with the gills, and someone laughed, badly, because the room wanted so much to laugh.

Vane let the laugh gutter out before he turned to the benches where Soren sat with Ilse and Dax, and he put on the gentle voice, which was how he did his worst work. "And here is the man of the hour. Your mother sowed seven fields, boy. I have read the pages; we all have. The answer of the Circle is to plough them under and salt the earth and call the salting mercy. I am offering you harvest instead. A farmer's son should hear that as a kindness."

"I am a mortuary man," Soren said. "We do not harvest. We dispose. Different trade, and the difference is the whole difference."

Crane's voice was quiet, which in him was worse than shouting. "We are not them. That is the whole of my argument, and it is granite, and granite does not care that it is unfashionable. The night we splice ourselves to be like them is the night we deserve to lose." His kind eyes found Soren across the benches. "Soren. Stand with the Concord. Be counted."

And Vane, smiling: "Counted. Yes. Do you notice how it is always counting with these people? The Seeds were designed, boy. Designed things have purposes. The Circle will seal your mother's work and call it mercy. We will finish it and call it war. Choose the banner with your blood in it."

"You will have your quay shifts sanctioned by tonight," Crane said quietly, before the murmur could spread. "And my blessing, such as it is. Granite does not chase anyone, Vale. But it remembers."

Every face turned to him. He felt the room like a held breath, felt his Lacuna sit up behind his sternum and taste the air the way a tongue finds salt. Fear, and under the fear something worse: hope. Two hundred people hoping he would take their decision off their hands and carry it where it could not be argued with.

"I've been counted my whole life," Soren said. "Mortuary roster first, then the wall of the missing, and now by two banners in one morning. So here is my count, and it comes to three. Vann. Merrow. Me. We take the quay shifts, we run sanctioned harvests, we brew what the bench allows. When either of you wants the city defended more than you want to be right, you know where the dead are laid out. We'll be the ones keeping the books straight."

Silence. Then Vane inclined his head like a fencer conceding a touch. "A fourth faction of one cell. Greyharbor will miss you when it burns."

"The city will miss your forearms," Soren said. "They were very educational."

By noon the Circle of Leaves had split down its long table like a dropped loaf. Three Leaves walked out with Vane and took half the field rosters with them, names read aloud and struck through in ink before the door had shut. All that day and night the wards burned on both sides, each faction revoking its own contributions, the house unwriting itself in green fire, until the old keepers went through with salt and chalk and made the place honest again: four walls, some doors, no promises.

Soren stood in the courtyard at midnight with Ilse and Dax and watched a ward his mother had probably walked beneath come apart letter by letter.

"We held the line," Dax said, too lightly.

"We held a hall," Ilse said. She clicked her brass counter twice, once for each thing she intended to remember. "The line is the harbor."

* * *

The bell that woke them at dawn was the wrong bell. Not the curfew bell, not the fire bell. The all's-well bell at the customs house, rung ragged, rung by someone who did not believe it.

The word came up from the mudlarks and then from a militia runner, breathless, disbelieving of his own mouth: Ropewalk had not fallen in the night. Ropewalk had not burned, had not flooded, had not been taken. Ropewalk was gone.

A woman's single shoe stood on the bridge parapet, placed neatly, laces tucked in, the way you leave something you mean to come back for. A militia sergeant knelt at the cordon rope

being quietly sick. The customs bell was still ringing its all's-well, and the sound went out over the water and came back with nothing under it.

Soren stood at the cordon on Chandler's Bridge with smoke-sight banked low and looked at where nine streets and a ropery and two thousand souls should have been. The fog there was not fog. It was a wall with a grain to it, and the grain ran vertical, and his sight went through it the way a hand goes through smoke. Behind the grain: mossed bone in the shape of streets. Lamplight, if lamplight grew on trees, hanging in rows where windows used to be. Canopy, miles of it, dark and gentle as a held breath. The district had not been destroyed. It had been taken, whole, into the body of the Hollow, like a coin into a purse, and the purse had closed.

And somewhere in there, muffled to a thread, faint as a voice under water, a ropery bell was ringing. Someone in the taken streets was ringing the alarm, and the alarm was ringing inside the thing that had eaten it.

Ilse clicked her counter. Once, twice. "Nine streets," she said. "Say it, so it stays said."

"Nine streets," Soren said, and his voice came out level, which cost him something. "The Folds were doors before. It knocked, it reached, it stole through keyholes." He watched the vertical grain of the world's new wall flex and settle, flex and settle, patient as breathing. "This morning it stopped knocking. It has begun to eat the plate we serve it on."

CHAPTER 18

The Hungry Canopy

The truce was signed on the back of a requisition form, which everyone agreed was fitting.

Four days after Ropewalk went into the purse, the harbor watch and what remained of the Concord met under the customs-house clock with militia clerks between them and signed terms while the fog leaned on the windows. No Concord blade inside the militia lines without a watcher. No militia patrol past the cordon without a tallyman. Rations shared at the checkpoint on Chandler's Bridge, cooked once, eaten twice, because Captain Serle of the harbor watch had a horror of waste and Ilse Vann had a horror of error and the two of them got along like twin auditors.

"Your people breed monsters," Serle said to Soren, across the chalk lines of the checkpoint, "and my people die of it. But you keep honest books, and I have not been able to say that of the Concord before. So: the truce holds until one of us makes it not hold. Sit down. Tell me what you need."

"Boats that don't creak," Soren said. "Lamps with shutters. And your worst swimmers, the ones you'd otherwise flog. I'll make them rich."

"Rich in what?"

"Alive."

Behind Serle, the morning queue came up from the Ropewalk edge: people who had slept a street away from the purse and woken outside it. A fish-porter with his hand still closed around a door key. Two children asleep on a barrow, holding between them a birdcage, empty, its little door swinging. Nobody in the queue said Ropewalk. They said the fog took the streets, or the tide came up wrong, or nothing at all, and Serle fed them from the shared pot, because arithmetic is arithmetic whoever does the sums.

The Hollow's expansion had a tide to it now, measured nightly by lantern-buoys and daring boys with chalk. The canopy had come down from the Ropewalk scar and spread along the harbor like grease along a pan, and where its shadow crossed, things bred: hush-hounds in the timber-yards, lantern-mites in the flooded basements, gallows-walkers striding the crane-lines at dusk, elegant and horrible, harvesting the drowned.

Soren ran the harvest-cells off a slate propped on a hogshead, and the slate looked, exactly, like the mortuary intake board he had kept for six years, because habits are the last thing the Fade takes and he intended to keep his.

"Cell One, the ropery cellar. Mites, three swarms, shallow water. Cell Two, the slipway, hounds, night work, quiet voices. Cell Three," and here he tapped the board, "with me. The crane-lines. There's a walker feeding on the pilings and it has eaten eleven sailors that I have counted, and I have counted twice."

He chose cell leaders the way a mortician chooses order of work, because his Organ let him. The kill-sense sat in him like a cold card-player's eye: any room, any crowd, and he knew which heartbeat would stop first. It was a terrible gift for parties and an excellent one for triage. The men whose hearts were not scheduled, he made leaders. The ones whose hearts were, he kept beside him, where he could spend himself before the Hollow could spend them. He never told them. He told Ilse, once, at two in the morning, and she had counted to four and said: "Then you will sleep less than any of us. Good. You owe the most."

Serle watched him post the board for a week before she said anything. "You run this like a receiving ward."

"I run it like a receiving ward because it is one," Soren said. "The wounded are only later in arriving, and the Hollow is faster than canal fever, and it never signs the book."

* * *

The crane-line harvest went wrong in the ordinary way, which is to say it went right until it very suddenly didn't.

The gallows-walker came off the crane-top with its limbs folding like a scaffolding deciding to be an animal, and it was fast in the way of things that have never once been prey. Soren let it. Predator Codex ran in him now as a grammar: read, feint, spend. He spent. The kill-sense put its death in his hands half a heartbeat before he arrived, and his hands, mortuary hands, careful hands, did what they were grown for. The walker came down into the black water in three pieces and its spilled shadow curled up off the surface like steam.

"Drink," he told his cells, hoarse. "The wounded first. Leaders last. I'm last."

He drank last and least, out of six years' habit and one year's principle, but the night was fat with essence, the whole harbor like a dropped purse, and what he took went down and down and found that there was further down.

The fever took him on the cots at the checkpoint, four days in, and it was the worst yet. He burned. His bones felt rewritten in someone else's handwriting. He dreamed in seams: every doorway in Greyharbor opening into every other, the whole city folded up like linen in a drawer, and something behind his sternum learning, patiently, the trick of the folds.

Ilse sat with him through it because her rule was that no gravid of hers went into the fire alone. She did not hold his hand, there being half of one and him being past knowing. She

counted. "Eighty-four," she said, at some black hour. "Eighty-five. I knew a woman who climbed three tiers in a autumn and lived to be old and insufferable. She said the trick is to be too stubborn to be interesting." Click, went the counter. "You will have to work at being dull, Vale."

The burning was nothing beside the dreams. He lay in the drawer of the city, between folded streets, and something enormous and patient turned the pages of him, and stopped, and stopped again, at the thin ones, the ones a boy keeps under the floor of himself: a stove's warmth, soap, a laugh through the nose.

What the fever took, he discovered on the eighth day, when he reached, as he did every morning, for the small hoard he kept of his mother. Face: gone since the Slate Market debt. That hole he knew the shape of. But the voice, the voice had been his, held close, unspent.

He stood in the checkpoint kitchen with a tin cup going cold and tried to hear her say his name, and there was a room in his memory where the sound should be, furnished, warmed, lived in, and silent.

"Ilse," he said. "The fever last week. The Fade collects a tithe, doesn't it. Off every tier."

"It does."

"It took her voice. I have her letters. I have the watch. I know she laughed through her nose when I was being clever, because I wrote that down once, thank every salt. But I can't hear her." He turned the cup. "I've lost her face and now her voice. I'm running out of mother."

Ilse looked at him a long moment. Then she took her counter out and clicked it, once, gently, as if for the memory itself. "Then we will be your hearing, boy. Say her letters aloud to me on Sundays and I will hold them twice."

* * *

He tested the new Organ in the cellar under the customs house, where two Folds had been charted eight strides apart, one into the ropery dark, one into a flooded stair.

No door. No script. No tincture. He put his palm against the empty air and pushed, the way you push against a scab, and the seam split. Going through a Fold-step felt like being a page turned by someone else: one pressure, one flick of darkness, and the second cellar was around him, water-nipped and real, eight strides from where his heart still stood.

He did it four times, then sat down on a wet step and laughed until it turned into something else.

"Again," Ilse said, from the far cellar, having counted his absence. "Twice more. I want the number."

He gave her the number. Then, because the harbor never let a man keep a good hour, they climbed to the dockline before dawn to walk the pickets, and the fog was high, and the canopy had grown so low over the water that its fronds dragged the mastheads, shedding spores that glowed faintly as they drowned.

The whole picket line heard it first as a sound like the rigging in weather. Then it resolved.

It was the canopy, whispering along the dockline, a slow tide of it passing from mouth to mouth of the galls overhead, and it was not random. It had shape. It had a name in it, over and over, patient as rain.

Soren. Soren Vale.

Seven years of nightmare, and the thing above the docks had chosen a voice, and the voice it wore, soft, amused, saying his name the way a woman says it to a boy who has just been clever, was the voice the Fade had taken from him nine days before.

Down the picket line a militiaman took salt from his pocket and threw it over his shoulder, an old tide-superstition from before anyone had needed a new one. The sergeant of the watch whispered the noon prayer at midnight. Ilse clicked her counter twice and put it away, which was her version of both.

He stood on the dockline with his hands very still and counted his own heart, twice, and could not make the count come out even.

CHAPTER 19

Siege of Blackwing

The Court of Lanterns came for House Blackwing at dusk, and it came like a navy.

Soren saw the first carriages from the tar-house roof: chitin hulls the size of skiffs, drawn on six jointed legs, moving through the harbor fog without any sound that fog was allowed to keep. Behind them, rank on rank, came the thralls in their pearl-gray lacquered coats, and above the whole advance the lantern-mites flew in ribbons, and where the ribbons touched the house's ward-lamps the lamps went out one by one, eaten.

The alarm bells began, then stopped beginning. A pack of hush-hounds had come up the canal and crouched along the wall with their mouths open, and the sound of the bells was pouring into those mouths. Soren felt it go. He had lived three tiers now inside a body built for this and it still raised the hair on his arms: a city losing its own voice.

"Positions," Ilse called, and her counter clicked like a crocodile. "Count your blades, count your powder, count your exits. Twice."

The house was half empty because the house had cut itself in half eleven days before, and every Purist and Amalgamist who had marched out with a torn roster was one fewer body at these windows now. Soren ran the defense the only way he knew, off the intake board in his head. Kill-sense swept the courtyard and the quay and gave him the schedule of the night, and he spent the defending dead one hour ahead of dying.

The thralls came up the west wall in silence, because the hush-hounds had swallowed the shouting, and the defense had to be fought in hand-signs and whistle-codes. Soren called targets from the gallery by touching shoulders in order. The tall one with the lit gut, next. The pair on the granary roof, not yet. His Organ laid the night out like a duty roster, and he worked down it, and the working was calm, and the calm frightened him more than the thralls did.

The strangeness came at the third hour. The Court had numbers to crack the house flat and knew it, and did not crack it. The thralls pressed hard at the west dormers, at the granary wall, at the cellar mouths, and never at the archive, never at the vaults where the Seeds slept under his mother's seal. They fought, Soren thought, the way a crowd fights toward a ticket window.

"Count their presses," Ilse said beside him, reloading with her teeth and her one hand. "Nobody fights this badly on purpose unless they are not fighting to win."

"Then what are they fighting for?"

"Something under us, and I want very much to be wrong."

* * *

He found the answer at the sally-gate.

There was an old Fold-door in the granary wall, charted, chained, and warded, a postern the house's founders had cut through the world's skin for sorties into the Hollow. Soren came around the granary's blind side on a rumor of wrong weather and found the chain coiled on the cobbles and the Fold standing open, a seam of night in the wall with the fog bending into it like water into a drain.

Dax Merrow stood beside it with the gate-timber in both hands.

"Dax." Soren kept his voice level, kept his hands level, because the boy was a hairline from shattering and a crowd of thralls was already coming through the seam, soft-booted, patient, pouring into the under-croft. "Step away from the door."

"I owe them," Dax said. The words came out of him like teeth being pulled, one at a time. "A year of brews, Soren. Off my own bench, after hours, sold to a buyer who paid in perfume, and perfume is their paper, perfume is their coin, and every vial was a signature and every signature was a promise that some day they'd come to collect, and today they came." His thumb worked at his left wrist, where a mark showed now under the torn sleeve: a ring of pale script, written in the skin itself, sweet-smelling. "My mother's rent is paid in it. My mother's RENT, Soren. And the terms are one door, open, held. And if I don't hold it, they take her. Not her life. They don't want lives. They want her under the canopy, drinking, the way the seed-stock drinks."

"You opened a door into your own house."

"You think I don't know what I've done?" And Dax turned to look at the under-croft, where the thralls were working, and stopped looking, and looked anyway.

They were not killing. That was the thing. The wounded who had been dragged down from the west dormers lay netted in gauze that glowed from inside, and they were alive, all of them, breathing shallow and slow, and their faces, one by one, were becoming beautiful. Peaceful. The nets drank. The thralls hauled the nets on long poles, gentle as men moving beehives, toward the open Fold, and one thrall's chest-lantern was lit and in its glow Soren could see faces swimming, faces it had taken somewhere, smiling out at nothing.

Dax made a sound Soren had never heard from him, from anyone.

Then he ran, and Soren thought for one white moment that he was running for the Fold, for escape, and was already composing the arithmetic of his hatred. But Dax ran the other way. Dax ran for the still-room, where a year of unsanctioned tinctures and two hundred quarts of burning spirit stood racked and caged, and he came out the far door dragging the fire-cart with

the lamps swinging, and he drove it up the ramp into the belly of the Court's boarding-line.

The boarding-lines were the Court's true assault: living spars of chitin, bent and grown from the carriage hulls to the dormer sills, bridges for the pearl-coats to cross dry and quick. Dax put the fire-cart under the thick of the nearest spar, pulled the lamp off its hook, and looked back along the ramp at Soren, and grinned, the real grin, the quick one, the one from before all of it.

"Tell her it's paid," he said, and threw the lamp.

The spirit went up the living spar like a shout down a rope. Chitin burns, it turns out, from the inside, where the animal still is; the line lit end to end and the fog went rose-colored and the pearl-coats on it dropped or burned or fell, and the second spar caught from the first, and the withdrawal horn was sounding before Dax even staggered.

He was burning. He stayed by the gate-timber anyway, holding the sally-gate's hinge-block wedged so the Fold could not be shut and the fire could keep working through the Court's lines, and he was burning when Soren got to him, and he pressed something into Soren's scorched hand and closed Soren's fingers over it with both of his own, and said, "Count it all, Soren. Count it all," in a voice mostly smoke.

Then he went back into the fire to cut the last spar free of the house, and the spar came down, and he did not.

Serle's watch came up at first light with tar-masks and hoses and found nothing left to fight, and stood among the burnt nets with their caps off. Ilse went down the under-croft with her counter clicking, low and even, over and over, and Soren did not ask what she was counting, because some counts are private, and hers had a brother in it already.

* * *

The Court sounded recall at dawn, in good order, with the house breached and bleeding and plainly theirs if they had wanted it. The carriages withdrew into the fog at parade step. The hush-hounds trotted after, fat with the city's stolen morning bells.

Soren sat in the burnt under-croft among the empty nets with Ilse, who had lost two fingers' worth of voice to a near miss and was being ferociously calm. In his palm lay a wedding ring, worn thin, warm from the boy's hand, and a page folded to the size of a coin. Dax's own ledger hand, neat under the bravado: all items, one year, MARKED PAID IN FULL.

On the charred breast of a dead thrall, Soren found a brand he half knew. He had seen it in the stolen Court ledger, a glyph his sleepless nights had only half translated, the phrase built around it like a scar around a nail. He found the page. The translation he had was crude and

now it did not need to be better: ROOTGATE, and beneath it, in Court script: keel-anchor. Do not wake the keeper.

He laid the ledger beside the ring and made himself say the count out loud, because saying it made it true and true was the only thing left to hold.

"They never touched the vaults. They pressed for the deeps under the house. They recalled at the moment they'd won." Ilse's counter clicked once, twice, the way she counted anything she meant to carry. "They were never trying to take Blackwing," Soren said. "They were buying time. All night, for something at the Rootgate."

CHAPTER 20

Lady Wren's Garden

The invitation came the evening after the siege, which was either an insult or an apology, and with Lady Wren the two were the same currency.

It arrived at the checkpoint under militia seal, because everything crossed the truce lines under militia seal now: a gall the size of a plum, grown on a twig of black wood, and when Soren took it in his palm it opened like a lantern and spoke in a voice made of perfume, which was a thing he had hoped never to hear again.

"The garden on the drowned bell-tower, midnight. No debts are called in my garden, little seed. Come alone. Wear something you can burn."

"You will not go alone," Ilse said.

"She'll expect me alone."

"Then she has already won the first exchange, and I want you to hear that from me before you go, so that after, when you are counting, you count it too." Ilse clicked the counter, once for the order, once for the fear she was not going to admit to. "Midnight. Two hours. At one minute past two hours I come in after you, and I will burn her garden, and it will start a war, and that will be your fault for being late."

"You'd never make it through her door."

"No," Ilse agreed, placid as a stone. "But she would know I tried, and knowing it will cost her something. Everything costs them something. That is the whole of their religion."

Soren said nothing. He went and got his coat, and into the left pocket he put the stopped watch, and into the right the ring that had come out of a dead boy's hand. At the checkpoint door he stopped and told Ilse where his books were kept. Cellar, third flagstone, under the tarpaulin. Ilse said that was morbid. Then she wrote it down.

* * *

The drowned bell-tower stood off the harbor's mouth, a stump at low tide, a rumor at high, and its Fold was not hidden at all. Wren had hung it with lantern-galls, dozens of them, so that the entrance looked like a doorway into a wedding. Soren went through with smoke-sight banked and his hands empty and found a garden where a bell-room should have been.

The bell was still there, or had been grown into. It hung in its frame the way a heart hangs in a chest, webbed over with pale wood, and when the wind came off the harbor the whole tower hummed through it, one note, enormous and patient, more felt than heard.

Terraces spiraled up the inside of the tower's ghost, all of it grown: galls in tiers like fruit, pale vines with leaves of thin chitin, glasswing moths drifting between the lanterns, drinking, he supposed, whatever dreams the moths found there. Wren sat at a table of bone-smooth wood pouring something amber into two glasses, and she was beautiful the way a knife is beautiful, which is to say the matter was settled and only the use remained.

"You kept my card," she said, nodding at his pocket, where the calling-card from the anniversary night still lived because he kept his enemies' debts the way Ilse kept counts.

"I keep evidence."

"You keep grief in an organized way. It's your mother in you. Sit."

He sat, because the chair was there and the truce was real and the amber, when he finally drank, tasted of quinine and pears and made the Lacuna behind his sternum lie back down like a growling dog. Poisoned, no. Drugged, she would consider rude.

"You saw my court's work last night," Wren said. "The nets. You are doing arithmetic about it, and I am going to save you the labor, because I am honest, and being honest is the most frightening thing about me. The Hollow is starving, Soren. It has been starving since before you were born."

"Greyharbor begs to differ."

"Greyharbor is a meal. Meals do not testify about the diner's health." She turned her glass. "Consider the diet. The Hollow eats memory, and only memory, and it must eat or die, the same as you. Once, in the world it came from, there were cities beyond counting, centuries deep, whole civilizations of remembering. Then that world closed, the way a book closes. Your Sporefall was not an attack. It was a lifeboat. The Warden was drowning, and it poured a measure of itself across the skin of the world into the richest tide-pool it could see, and the tide-pool was Greyharbor, and we have been feeding ever since."

"Seven years of feasting."

"Seven years of famine with garnish." Her voice stayed level, pleasant, terrible. "Do the sums. The dead take their memories with them into us, but the dead of a small city are a small harvest. The living forget slowly, and hoard what they don't forget, and fear has made them thrifty. Every year there is less in Greyharbor to eat. Every year the canopy goes hungrier. Ropewalk was not a victory, whatever my colleagues' carriages said about it. Ropewalk was a man eating his own boot."

"And the King?" Soren said. "The one nobody sees. Where does the Lantern King eat?"

Wren was quiet for a moment, and in the quiet the tower hummed its one note. "My king does not eat. My king is, if anything, eaten. No. I will not say that tonight, on a full stomach of your distrust. He was the first of us and he will be the last, and his silence is not absence, whatever the Grand Canopy pretends. Ask me again when you have met him. Or when he has met you."

"So the nets."

"So the nets. My court's plan, the King's plan, is the garden. Bring humanity under the canopy, whole and managed and bred for yield. Not slaughtered, no. Potted. Every soul a permanent, renewable little spring of memory, dreaming its little life over and over under our leaves, forever." She smiled, and it was the worst thing in the garden. "We do not want your city broken, Soren. We want it planted."

"One more item for the audit, then," Soren said. "You told me once my mother is inventory. I have had weeks to wonder what that word does in your ledgers."

"Held," Wren said. "Not spent. In a starving house, little seed, inventory is the most guarded thing there is. Ask me the rest of that question in a different season, when you can afford the answer."

The fog moved in him, anger, old and cold. He put it on the scale where he put everything. "Ilse's people netted in your under-croft were not volunteering for the orchard."

"No. And that is why my court is noble and my court is damned, and I have stopped trying to resolve it. But hear the last sum, because you will not sleep without it." Wren set down her glass, and for the first time since he had known her she looked, briefly, like someone else's clerk. "There is a faction in your Concord that finds the garden plan reasonable. On a schedule. Gently. With the poor going first, because the poor, the arithmetic says, will be missed least."

"You're lying."

"I never lie; it ruins the flavor. A Primate of your Veridian Concord has been in negotiation with my court for a controlled ascension. Corrals, quotas, a tithe of souls a season, and in exchange, the canopy holds still and the city keeps breathing. The terms are drafted. The perfumes have been flowing to him for a year." She watched him arrive at it, watched him

arrive one year back, to a ledger page in a market cellar, and she nodded slowly, as one does to a student.

"And a word of trade, since you are a buyer of truths now. You do not starve a canopy by pruning its branches. File that where you file things you do not yet understand."

"You'll tell me his name."

"I will not." She rose, and the galls dimmed around her as if dimming were polite. "Names are how your kind hunts, and I have need of both your hunters. You will want it to be a monster, little seed. It is worse. It is a man doing arithmetic, and his convictions are granite, and granite cracks along its own grain. That is the last honest thing I will give you tonight, and it is the one that will cost you the most sleep."

CHAPTER 21

The Seventh Seed Blooms

It began with the doors, two days after the garden.

Every door in the mortuary started to hum when Soren passed it, a low glass note like a wet finger on a rim. Then the doorways of the checkpoint. Then, embarrassingly, the doorway of Ilse's office, which had a beaded curtain, and which announced him at all hours like a shop bell. He put chalk in his pockets the way other men put tobacco and found himself standing in frames, head tilted, listening to the shape of the air.

"The books are very sure," Ilse said, watching him do it in the cellar. She had the page open in front of her, the Concord's own primer, printed in five inks. "No gravid opens a Fold. The Lacuna feeds, it grows Organs, it climbs the tiers, but the doors are the Hollow's. Even First Essence walks through doors someone else made. It is the one courtesy the enemy extends us, and you appear to be declining it."

"I haven't done it yet."

"You are standing in a doorframe at midnight counting its pulse. You have done it. You simply have not confessed."

The maturing had no tier to it; that was what was wrong with it. He was Seventh Essence and had been since the crane-line harvest, and the tiers came by ladder, one rung of hunger and one new Organ at a time, paid for in essence and fever. This was not a rung. This was the ladder itself flexing under him, the Lacuna behind his sternum gone from a seed to a thing with intentions, and its intention, every time he stood in a frame, was out.

He confessed on the fourth night, in the flooded stair cellar under the customs house, with Ilse counting and two charted Folds eight strides apart and a fire-axe leaned against the wall, because Ilse believed in arithmetic and in axes.

He put his palm flat to the empty brick between the two doorways and pushed, the way he had pushed once before, and this time there was no borrowed seam, no charted scar, no door at all. The world split. It parted the way old scar tissue parts, grudgingly, with a sensation like a held breath let go, and the dark beyond the split was the ropery cellar, eight strides and one world away, and his hand had made it.

"Well," said Ilse, who had gone very still. "Click twice if you can still hear me."

"Once for yes, twice for no," Soren said. "I invented that system. I know how to use it."

"Then yes, once," she said, "and once again, from me, for every textbook in this city that is now firewood," and she clicked her counter, and her face, for one unguarded second, was the face of a woman watching a new star get named after nobody she liked.

* * *

The overreach came at the Ropewalk cordon, five nights later, and it came because he was showing off, which Ilse predicted, in writing, beforehand.

They were moving a harvest cell through the fog wall, the old way, walking them out to the scar and through the Fold there, and the cell was green and the water crossing was deep and cold, and Soren thought: eight strides saved is eight strides safer. He opened his seam mid-shoal, took his cell's four hands in four of the cell's other four hands, and stepped.

The scar under Ropewalk was not like other Folds. It was not a door into the Hollow. It was a wound where the Hollow had come out, and a wound, he understood one heartbeat too late, runs both directions, and the thing at the bottom of that wound was not local.

He came out of the step alone. The cell stayed home; the Fold declined them; only he was taken, and where he was taken was deep.

The deep Hollow has no canopy, or the canopy is all there is. He stood on a root-road the width of a quay, grown of mossed bone and pale wood, and it ran out ahead of him until running out was the wrong idea for it. The road bent with the curvature of somewhere. On every side, to the edge of sight and past it, were faces.

They were set into the world the way plaques are set into walls. Thousands. Tens of thousands. Old men with harbor beards. Girls in mourning bonnets. A sailor he had prepped on his very first night shift, drowned and decent, recognizable because Soren's memory, unlike everything else in him, still kept its books. The whole harvest-team from the Mycelium Fields, all nine, ranked like a class portrait. A small face he knew from Ashlane, unspliced, whole,

exactly as a child is before the world gets its hands in, and Soren's legs nearly went at that one.

And they were singing.

Each face its own song, low, and all the songs braided into one slow tide of sound that was not music the way rain is not weather but contains it. The sailor sang fishing. The team sang out numbers, a tally, the last work of their lives. The child sang a skipping rhyme, over and over, unhurried, certain of the rope.

They were the eaten. Not the dead, which Soren could have borne. The eaten: every memory the Fade had ever taken off this city and grown into the walls of its new owner's house. The Hollow was not built on their bones. It was built on their Tuesdays.

The Lacuna behind his sternum leaned toward the singing like a sunflower at noon, and Soren felt, with a clarity he would have paid to lose, how easy it would be to open his mouth and add his verse. The hunger for thresholds was in him now, and he was standing on the largest threshold in the world, and it was harmonized, and it had room.

He gripped the watch in his pocket and the ring beside it, one hard shape each, and counted the faces he could name, because counting was the rail he had left. One. Two. Nine. Eleven.

He got to forty-one.

The song stopped.

Mid-verse. The child's rope never hit the ground. Tens of thousands of throats, if they had throats, closed on the same breath, and the silence that followed was not empty, it was attentive, it was a silence with an ear in it, and then every face on the horizon of forgotten people turned to him at once, the way a courtroom turns, the way a pack turns, ten thousand pairs of eyes that did not need eyes arriving at him together.

He did not remember opening the seam home. His hands did it, the way a sleeper's hand finds an itch. The last thing he carried back was the very beginning of a second song, one new verse, sung by all of them in unison, in a voice that had forty-one names in it.

His name.

* * *

He came out on the mudflat under the cordon with Ilse's fist in his collar, hauling him out of a half-open seam like a gaffer landing an eel, and the world was dawn-colored and ordinary and smelled of tar.

"Talk," she said. "In counts."

"Deep Hollow. The Warden. I saw it. Or the edge of it. Ilse, they were all in the walls. Everyone we've lost, everyone the Fade ever took. Singing."

She went down on her heels in the mud in front of him, gripping his jaw with her whole hand, a field test, eyes, pupils, the lift of the lid. "And you are back. Good. What did it take off you? There is always a fare."

He checked, the way you probe a socket with your tongue. His childhood was all there: the stove's warmth, the soap-smell of the mortuary, his mother's letters. He walked the street of it in his head, the crooked one, the one with the kerbstone he had tripped on at six years old, outside the house with the blue door, on the street called

The street called.

"There's a hole," he said slowly. "Small one. I grew up somewhere, and I can walk every yard of it, and Ilse, it has no name. The street has no name. That's the fare? It took a street name?"

"Names come last," Ilse said quietly. "Scents first, then faces, then names. It is the order of the Fade, and it is also the order of how much a thing is loved." She stood, and pulled him up, and did not let go of his sleeve. "Something with ten thousand faces looked at my boy last night and paid for the view. Whatever it is growing toward, Vale, it has started wanting you by name."

CHAPTER 22

The Warden's Voice

He did not sleep in beds anymore; he slept near seams. The Circle's healers would have called that a symptom. Soren called it hygiene: if the deep thing wanted him, it could come to the front door he chose, and he would be awake for it.

On the third night after the mudflat, in the cellar of the mortuary, with a charted Fold breathing on the far wall and the ring and the watch both under his hand, the Warden did exactly that. It came as a dream, and the dream was Greyharbor.

Ilse had posted her conditions at the top of the stairs, where conditions belong. Two hours, like the garden. If he did not walk out of the dream by two, she would wake him with harbor water and the good salts, and if he woke screaming she wanted it in counts, not colors. He had agreed to all of it. Then he had gone down and made the charted Fold comfortable, the way you make up a guest bed for a guest you do not trust.

He walked up Cinder Lane in it, crooked kerbstone, blue door, no street name. Grown over. Mossed bone underfoot instead of cobbles, glasswing moths instead of gulls, and every doorway on the street hung open like a slack mouth, and through each doorway was not a room but more street, folded, the whole city tucked into itself like linen. Above it all was the canopy, near enough now to touch the chimneys, and the light that came down through it was green and kind and wrong.

"You keep your books well," said the Warden, from behind him, in no voice and then in one.

He turned, and his mother was standing under the gall-lantern at the end of the lane.

The face arrived before the horror did. That was the cruelty of it: first came the simple animal relief of seeing, after these weeks of a hole in his own head, the exact set of her brows, the freckles he had once counted across the bridge of her nose for something to do while she signed a burial ledger, the way her mouth went on one side before it laughed through the nose. Every detail matched, because every detail had been taken from him and spent here. She was dressed as she had dressed for evening shifts, in the green coat with the ink on the cuff. Her shadow did not match her. Her shadow was the size of a city.

"You are not her," Soren said. His voice held. He was almost proud of it.

"I am what she is now," the borrowed voice said, mild. "Which is to say: I am her Tuesdays. Her laugh. The way she signed her name with the tail too long. Her face, which your Fade took off you and banked, and I have worn it since the Fever, little seed, before we

ever met. You heard it whisper on your docks and knew it, and thought you were going mad. You were not. You were being spoken to by your own property."

His hand had gone to the watch without asking him. The Warden's borrowed eyes followed it, and the face it wore did something complicated and gentle. "It is still stopped," the Warden said. "Her watch, stopped since the night we took her. Did you never wonder, little seed, why a stopped watch ticks once, at the worst hour, in every dream you have ever had? You did wonder. You counted it. That is partly why we chose you."

It came closer, wearing her walk. Soren stood still and counted: one lantern, two moths, three doorways, four counts of his heart, and the arithmetic held the floor while the rest of him screamed.

"What do you want?"

"Succession." It said the word the way a courtier says tea. "There is a chair at the bottom of everything I am, and the one who sits in it is old, and tired, and starving, and has watched every world it ever loved close like a book. I offer you the chair. Be the mind of the canopy. You count things; you would not believe what there is to count. Keep Greyharbor as the garden it is. Feed it gently, on the willingly forgetting, the old, the finished. No nets. You have my word, and my word is made of the promises of ten million people, and it is the only honest mass in either world."

"And my city keeps its own mind. Its own, what, its own everything."

"They keep their lives. Inside, and tended, and immortal in the way of orchards." Maerwen's face tilted. "You have seen my alternative, Soren Vale. You have stood in my under-crofts. The nets are not the King's cruelty. The nets are what happens when my patience runs out, and my patience is running out at the speed of a starving thing."

"And me," Soren said. "The part of me that is Soren Vale. The part that keeps the books. What becomes of it?"

"It keeps the books," the Warden said. "That is the honest horror of the chair, Soren Vale, and I will not hide it from you because hiding is not in my nature. Nothing is lost. Not one Tuesday of anyone, ever again. The man does not die. He is outvoted, forever, by everything he is asked to save."

"There's a third reading."

"There is always a third reading. Your mother wrote one, in fact. I have it here." It touched its borrowed temple. "She wanted to heal me. You will want to ask how that ends. I will not spoil her ending. It is the only thing I own that I have never eaten."

Soren's hand had found the ring in his pocket without his permission. Dax's mother's ring, warm from a dead boy's hand, and the Warden's borrowed eyes went to the pocket, and something crossed the face it wore that on a human face would have been called respect.

"You sold the sea," it said.

Weeks ago. A cellar of vials, a gray-cheerful fence, a price he had paid because he was drowning and it was the only coin he had. "I did."

"We bought it at second hand. Memories are currency, and all currency comes home to the bank." Maerwen's mouth smiled with the exact off-center tilt. "Would you like to hear it? I keep it well. It has been sung to, all this time, by people who drowned in it."

And it gave him the sea. Not the memory of it: the sea itself, restored, poured into the dream from wherever his Tuesdays of salt had been banking all this time. Gull-cry. The slap of halyards. His own young boots on wet stone, and the smell, the smell that the Fade had left a hole the shape of. It went into him like water into a man on fire, and he made a sound he did not authorize, and the Warden stood politely in Maerwen's shape and watched him cry with his own sold sea.

"Why," he said, when he could speak. "Why give any of it back?"

"Because it is yours, and we keep honest books, and because a man who has tasted what he sold makes a better bargain than a man starving for it. That is not mercy, Soren Vale. That is strategy wearing mercy's coat. We learned the trick of coats from your kind."

"I hate you," he said, when he could.

"Yes. It is one of the nicer things I have been given lately." The dream dimmed around them, the lane folding itself away like a fan. "You will not take the chair tonight. You are young, and grief is still doing your arithmetic. But hear the terms of the war you have chosen, because I am honest in the mass, if never in the part. You would starve me rather than feed me. So understand what you are starving, and when you have understood it, come to the bottom of everything and sit down."

"Show me what you are," Soren said. "Not the face. The books. Show me the ledger, since you're so proud of keeping honest ones."

The Warden considered him with his mother's eyes.

"This is not an argument," it said, and the last of the lane went dark behind them. "This is a receipt. You asked for the books. Every honest ledger has a first entry, and ours is dated seven years back, on the night your city calls the Sporefall. It is entered from my side of the page."

Then it gave him the ledger. The dream peeled open like a hand uncurling, and he was standing beneath the canopy at the bottom of the world, seven years deep, looking up through

the membrane of somewhere at a city seen from the underside of the night: Greyharbor, far off and small, burning with its lamps, every window a grain of light.

And above it, between the city and the skin of the sky, a cloud was turning. Luminous. Patient. Beginning, with the whole slow weight of a starving god behind it, to fall.

CHAPTER 23

Gathering of Codices

The war-council met in the harbor watch's drill-hall because it was the only room in Greyharbor big enough for both armies' pride. Blades were peace-bonded at the door with militia wire, and Ilse Vann stood at the wire with her counter and counted the bondings, both ways, out loud, which took eleven minutes and set the tone of the evening exactly as she intended.

Primate Aldous Crane presided from a militia chair that sat lower than the Concord's own, a choice of his, Soren was fairly sure, made for the look of it. Around the long tables: four Leaves of the rump Circle, Captain Serle with her officer-cadre, the harvest-cell leaders with their slates, and two sanctioned Chirurgeons who between them had most of the city's remaining calm.

Soren reported first, because Ilse volunteered him and volunteering was her way of checking his spine.

He gave them the garden. The galls, the terraces, the amber glass. He gave them the sums as Wren had dealt them: a starving biosphere, the Sporefall as a lifeboat, the plan to bring humanity under the canopy as seed-stock, potted and permanent. He gave them the last of it flat and unlovely: a Concord Primate had been in negotiation with the Court for a controlled ascension, a tithe of souls on a schedule, the poor first. He did not name Crane, because he had no name to give.

The hall did what halls do. Serle's officers went quiet in the way of people recalculating their own lists. A Leaf named Hollis demanded to know, red-faced, how Soren had come by enemy intelligence, and whether enemy hospitality came with obligations, and Soren let him finish.

"It came with a bill, Councillor, like everything. I paid it in sitting still while she insulted my city with perfect honesty. If you'd rather I'd taken notes badly and escaped with less, I'll do that next time."

"He reports true," Ilse said into the murmur. She did not raise her voice; she never had to. "I have cross-checked the arithmetic against three years of harvest-yields and the Ropewalk intake. The Hollow eats memory; the yields fall every year; the fall steepens. A starving thing gets either brave or reckless, and this one has a court full of aristocrats, so it will get brave. Her sums are true. As for the Primate in her story, I have been counting the Concord's perfume-buys through the Slate Market brokers since spring, and I have the count, and I will give it to this council when this council is ready to hear it, and not one day before, because numbers released early are spent early."

Soren felt the hall look at Crane without turning. Crane looked back at the table with kind eyes and granite stillness, and did not sweat, and did not blink, and Soren, who could read a room's dying heartbeats, noted that the Primate's heart was not the first in the hall scheduled to stop and was not the second.

Then he laid the rest on the table: the stolen Court ledger, open to the crude half-translation. ROOTGATE. Keel-anchor. Do not wake the keeper. Beside it, the charred brand cut from a thrall's breastplate, matching. Beside that, Ilse's siege arithmetic, chalked on a slate: presses toward the granary, toward the cellar mouths, toward the under-croft stairs that ran down into the old drowned streets under the harbor; never one soldier's weight of pressure on the vaults; recall sounded at the hour of victory.

"The siege was a clock," Soren said. "They kept us looking at the house while something was done under the harbor. The ledger calls it the Rootgate. It is what the Warden's body roots through: the anchor. The taproot of the whole canopy, under the water, in the deep root-roads that grown things run down there. And this morning the choir-buoys all report the same thing. The canopy is drawing down. Pulling in from the edges. Toward the water."

"Toward the tide," Serle said, "that comes the day after tomorrow. Spring tide. The highest water in three years."

"The ascension tide," said Ilse, and clicked her counter once, and the name sat down in the room and stayed.

* * *

The plan, when it was finally spoken plainly, took four words: burn the Rootgate down.

The sappers took over, the two Chirurgeons and Serle's chief gunner, and the arithmetic grew teeth. Fire-tinctures enough to boil a canal, brewed under guard through the coming day. Divers from the fishing fleet to run the drowned streets under the bell-tower shoal. A fighting column to hold the root-roads open behind the burn-line, because the deep Hollow would come for its own taproot, and come in numbers, and come singing.

"The roads themselves are the difficulty," Crane said, into the pause, and his voice was gentle, a schoolmaster's. "The root-roads are grown of the Warden's oldest flesh. Everything that walks them is read. My tallymen who have entered have come back broken or not at all; the roads know a stranger and digest a stranger. They are keyed, of a kind. Old script, old seal. Botanical work, forty years old." He looked up, and along the table, and the whole room looked with him, and every eye arrived where it had been arriving for an hour. "They are keyed to a Seed."

"I move it formally," Serle said, "before anyone can dress this up as anything nobler than it is. The Seventh Seed walks point. All in favor, and none of you look at me like that, he volunteered in the garden already, by all accounts."

The vote was not close. It never is, when the choice has already been made by the shape of the world, and everyone simply attends the counting. Soren raised his own hand first, which Ilse said afterward was the first time in her life she had seen a man vote for his own funeral and manage to look like he was balancing a ledger.

Assignments went up on Serle's slate in her brutal clerical hand. Gunner's division to the fire-barges. Chirurgeons to the diving-line. Ilse took the rearguard before it was offered, and when Soren opened his mouth she informed him, politely, that he had two hands and she one, and that the rearguard's work was counting, and that she had counted everything twice for thirty years and did not intend to start missing now.

There was an empty chair at the third table with a slate on it, cell rosters in a neat hand with the bravado showing underneath. Nobody had moved it. Nobody would. Soren put his fingers once around the ring in his pocket, on his way past, the way you touch a doorpost leaving a house.

They stood for the blessing at the end. Crane did not make it long. He came around the table to Soren, and took his face in both old hands, and his eyes were wet, and it was the terrible thing about the man, that the tears were real. Every coin in him was real. "Whatever you find down there, Soren Vale," he said, "you are Greyharbor's, and Greyharbor's God, and mine, go with you. I would walk it in your place if the roads would have me. Remember that of me, whatever else is remembered."

"I'll remember it," Soren said, and meant it, and hated meaning it.

* * *

He came back past the drill-hall near midnight for his satchel, because he had forgotten the ledger, and the ledger had become the only set of books he trusted from other people.

The hall was dark except for one lamp at the clerk's desk, and Crane was alone at it, sealing a letter. Wax, black, from a stick Soren did not recognize. The Primate pressed his seal-matrix into it with care, the whole weight of his shoulder, the way a man who has decided something finally does it, and Soren, in the dark of the doorway, caught the scent that came off the melted wax.

Perfume. A specific perfume. One he had smelled once across a masque gallery, and once in a cellar of vials, and once on the wrist of a dead boy who had paid a year of debts in it.

A runner waited in the yard, river-boots, oilskins, no livery Crane's office had any business keeping. Crane put the letter into the runner's hand with his own, said something too low to carry, and watched from the step as the man went down toward the water.

Soren stood in the dark and counted it, the way he counted everything now: one letter, black wax, one scent, one runner, one tide due the day after tomorrow. Then he counted Crane's tears, which had also been real.

The Primate closed the door softly behind his kindness, and the letter went down to the harbor through the fog, toward the Court of Lanterns.

CHAPTER 24

The Rootgate March

They went down at slack water, through a Fold pinned open behind the fish exchange with iron rings and hymn-chalk, and Soren counted them through the way he counted everything: out loud, in pairs, twice.

Forty-one souls. Nine burn-teams with saltfire satchels waxed tight against their spines. Six codex-walkers under Predator and Chirurgeon codes, their coat-collars chalked with their licences. Ilse Vann at his shoulder, iron-gray braid coiled close to her skull, ruined left hand tucked into her belt like a tool she had finished with, brass tally-counter clicking in her right fist as she counted the same forty-one from the far end of the line.

"Forty-one," she said.

"Forty-one," Soren said. "You're a beat behind me."

"I'm a beat certain. There is a difference, and one day it will keep you alive."

The Fold let them through and shut like water over a dropped coin, and the root-roads took them.

The roads ran beneath the harbor like the ribs of a drowned cathedral. Root vaults arched away overhead into a dark that ate lantern-light a few feet past its edge, and between the ribs hung mossed bone, furred gray-green, older than the city above it and patient in the way of things that had never needed to hurry. Somewhere far overhead the quarantine bells struck the half hour, and the sound came down through forty feet of stone and root thinned to almost nothing, a bell ringing inside a wool coat. Brackish rain fell where the harbor leaked through. It tasted of ship's bottom and rust.

"Saltfire," said Brack, burn-master of the third team, a cannonball of a man with singed eyebrows and a voice that ground like a millstone. "Burns wet. Burns in the dark. Burns root down to an ash that won't sprout. And don't ask me what's in it. The recipe is a Concord grave, and I am the last man alive who can recite it, so if I die down here, mourn me properly."

"We'll bury you twice," Soren said. "Count on it."

Brack laughed like gravel going down a chute, and the column moved.

The gallows-walkers found them at the third mile, or the walkers' gallows did: cocoons hanging from the vault ribs like pale fruit, swaying in a draft that had no business existing underground. Soren felt them wake through the kill-sense, a cold unfolding behind his sternum, and the sense rang like a struck glass: six heartbeats in the dark above, and every one

of them already dying.

"Vault," he said, and the column stopped breathing.

They came down on leg-joints like scythes, gallows-walkers, carrion giants, dry chitin and moss with faces pressed into the undersides of their heads like faces pushed into wax. The first took a burn-team man off the road and up into the dark before his satchel straps had finished sliding from his shoulders. His scream went up with him and came down shorter.

Soren did not fight like a soldier. He arranged, the way he arranged bodies on a slab: find the line, respect the grain, make one motion that would have taken three. The kill-sense showed him which heartbeat would stop first and his body simply went there, Fold-step carrying him between one blink and the next, chalk-grey limbs parting under the long knife he kept for exactly this weather. Brack's teams poured saltfire at the roots of the largest walker and the reagent burned green-white and hungry, hissing where the brackish rain hit it. A Chirurgeon walker named Corwin held a crushed arm together with bare hands and a hissed gene-fragment, sealing the wound like wax on a letter.

Four walkers down. One man up and gone. Forty remained.

"Forty," Ilse said, clicking her counter.

"Forty," Soren said, and found he could not say anything else for a while.

* * *

The glasswings came at a gallery where the road widened into a hall, and the hall was full of them, though at first there seemed to be nothing there at all. That was the point of glasswings. Wings like window-glass, bodies like a held breath. They did not drink blood. They drank dreams, and they were drinking as the column walked.

The men began to smile. Soren saw it happen: a burn-team man slowing, head tilting, lantern drooping, the deep unguarded smile of a bridegroom. Another left the line entirely and walked toward a wall with his arms out, saying a woman's name twice, tenderly, like a prayer that had already been answered.

Smoke-sight saved the rest of them. Through the Eighth Essence gland behind his eyes the hall stopped being empty: the air stitched with translucent wings, hundreds of them, each moth a glass knife with soft edges, each one fastened to a dreaming man's forehead with its mouth. He could see exactly where the dream went in.

"Lamps down. Oil out. Burn a line across the road and walk it behind me," Soren said. "Nobody follows a nice thought tonight. If it feels like a good idea, it's a glasswing."

They burned the trench and walked it, and the swarm came apart along the fire like a window coming out of its frame, wings catching, moths dropping and shattering with small

bright sounds. Most of the smiling woke at the heat and wept, which Soren considered the correct response to being robbed.

One did not. A young tallyman named Pim walked into a side gallery with his lantern held before him like an offering, still smiling, still saying the woman's name, and the dark folded itself around him with a courtesy that was worse than any scream. Corwin started after him. Soren caught the man's shoulder and shook his head, because the gallery had gone quiet in the particular way that means a room has already eaten.

"Thirty-nine," Ilse said. Her counter clicked twice, for him and for Pim both.

* * *

They heard the Choir's Crossing long before they saw it. The road ended at a span of woven root, two cables braided into a walkway, stretched across black water where a drowned street still showed its chimney pots. And from the far dark, moving along the cables like weather wearing voices, the Choir came singing.

It sang in a child's voice first, a tuneless skipping song. Then it sang in Dax's voice.

"You owe me for the rope, Vale," the dark sang, cheerful, precise, dead. "You owe me for the rope."

Soren's stomach turned to ballast. Beside him, Ilse had gone the color of the bone in the vaults, because the Choir had found a voice she knew better: her brother's, counting a harvest-team out loud, one, two, three, the count that had never come home from the first tide.

"It steals what it hears the Fade take," she said. Her voice was level. Her counter was not; it clicked and clicked in her fist.

The plan was the plan. The cell crossed the span, the rearguard held its head, and saltfire cut the cables behind them before the Choir reached the crossing. What the plan had not specified, because plans are written by people who count everyone home, was who would stand at the span-head while three dozen souls crossed a singing dark.

"You're the point," Ilse said. "Points go through. Doors get held. I have been holding doors since before you could shave."

"Vann."

"Vale." She said his name twice, because she counted everything twice, and because once would not have been enough for either of them. She pressed the brass tally-counter into his hand and closed his fingers over it with her maimed left hand, the ruined one, so that he would know the gift was the whole of her. "Hold my count. When it ticks, that's me being certain. And Soren. Count the rest for me."

He crossed with the cell, and the Choir sang around them in the voices of everyone either of them had ever buried, and Ilse Vann stood at the span-head with a saltfire satchel in her good hand like a woman waiting for a coach. He looked back exactly once, at the last of the planks, because looking twice would have been more than either of them could spend.

The light when she fired it was green-white and total. The span fell. The Choir's song went into the black water and kept singing anyway, muffled, patient, counting.

Ilse did not come back.

In Soren's fist, for the first time since the fish exchange, the tally-counter began to tick on its own. Small. Regular. Unhurried. Like a clock that had been waiting forty years for permission.

He counted the ticks while he walked. They did not stop.

* * *

An hour past the crossing, the road widened into a dark that their lanterns could not put a shape to, and the engineers' chalk began to lie. Every line they drew across the stone came back curved. The walls had stopped being walls; they had begun, gently, to be the inside of something. The air warmed. It smelled of milk and iron, of a thing newborn and a thing midwinter, and under the smell ran a pulse so broad and slow that at first they mistook it for the sea they were marching under.

"Where's the gate?" Brack said, finally saying what all of them were not saying. "Root-anchor, warden-seal, a door, a seam. Where's the blasted gate?"

Soren put his palm flat against the warm woven dark. Far beneath it, something enormous turned over in its sleep and settled again, and every hair on his arms rose to attention, and the counter ticked against his hip like a small determined heart.

It was not a gate. It was a nest.

CHAPTER 25

Betrayal at the Gate

They made camp on the rim of the nest and nobody slept much. Drill teams collared the outer root-crown with saltfire charges, ring after ring, and the engineers chalked their readings and redrew them and chalked them again, because the readings kept coming back curved. When the lanterns guttered, the woven walls showed faces. Every face asleep. Every face breathing. Soren stopped looking after the third one, which wore an expression he had last seen on bodies he had washed.

Ilse's counter ticked at his hip. He had stopped flinching at it. He suspected he would never stop listening.

Thirty-eight of them held the rim, and the number was a wound that walked with the column. Corwin, the Chirurgeon walker who had held a stranger's arm together at the third mile, worked down the charge-lines with his sleeves rolled, sealing each collar of saltfire to the root-crown, and between collars he talked, because the man had never met a silence he could not improve. "She held the door," he said, to no one, for the ninth time. "Thirty-eight of us owe her the rest of our lives, and I intend to be pedantic about collecting."

The tide came at what the engineers swore was dawn. Light came down the root-road the color of a struck match, and with it came the sound of many boots on root, and then the Court itself, in all its unbearable elegance: chitin carriages rolling like clockwork beetles, molted knights with limbs of smoke-dark glass, pikes of lantern-crystal held at an angle so disciplined it looked rehearsed for a century. The Court's elegance was the elegance of a thing that had never once been hungry in public, and the banners over it were threadbare in the way of flags that had lately stood at funerals.

Above them, on poles, flew the gray wing of House Blackwing.

The cheer started in the Concord lines and died there, unfinished, like a man walking into a door he had opened a thousand times. Those were Concord banners. Those were Concord banners above the Court of Lanterns, at the gate the Concord had sworn to burn.

Brack said, in the voice of a man reading out his own death warrant: "That's our wing. Why in the deep is our wing over their heads?"

Primate Aldous Crane rode at the head of the tide, travel-stained, kind-eyed, his primate's chain bright against a dust-gray coat. Beside his stirrup walked a figure a head taller than the knights, robed in lantern-glass panels, its face a lit window with a shadow passing behind it. The herald did not announce itself. The road announced it: every root the column crossed

straightened slightly, the way a spine straightens before a judge.

The herald unrolled a letter sealed in black wax, and Soren knew the sigil before anyone said a word, because he had grown up under that sigil and seen it on his mother's vanished work. Blackwing's wing. Beneath it, Crane's own signet.

"By covenant," the herald said, and its voice was quiet and enormous, like a name read from a ledger. "The Ascension shall be managed. The Warden shall be fed by schedule. The city shall be fed to the Warden by order: the fog-touched first, then the debt-bound, then the remainder of the sixth district, thence by district and by density. The Concord shall administer the count. The Court shall guarantee the ration. Greyharbor shall continue as a garden. Indefinitely."

The word order went through the Concord camp like cold water through cloth. Soren found he had walked forward without deciding to, and that Crane had walked out to meet him, and that the two of them were alone in a moving island of silence.

"You'd feed them in order," Soren said. "The poor first."

"By exposure, not by purse." Crane's eyes were as kind as ever, which was the horror of them. "Soren. I have signed the burial orders of four thousand people whose names I made myself learn. What is coming otherwise is a house fire with the doors barred. I have chosen a hearth. A managed fire warms. An unmanaged fire eats a city in a night, and then eats the county, and then there is no one left to forgive me."

"And the poor are first because?"

"Because the fog took their district already. Because they are nearest. Because someone must be first, and I would sooner it were the people the city forgot than the people the city counts." Crane said it like a man laying a flower on a grave, and it was arithmetic, and both things were true at once, and Soren understood for the first time that this was how granite convictions worked: they did not feel like falling. They felt like standing still.

"And Dax Merrow?" Soren said. "Sixth district. Debt-bound. Nineteen. Which ledger did he go in?"

"The levy went out under my seal," Crane said, and did not look away, because granite does not look away. "I signed the paper that pressed his mother's rent into the Court's hands. If I had known what the paper was for, I would have signed it anyway, and slower, and hated myself in a more comfortable chair. That is the whole of my confession, Soren. I am not sorry in the way you want. I am sorry in the way that builds schedules."

The herald's voice rose again, and this time it said the thing that ended the world's usefulness.

"The Warden sets its crown aside. The Seventh Seed shall sit it. The first citizen of the canopy. Let the Concord bring its Seed to the gate, that the covenant may be completed."

Every face on the rim turned toward him. The Court's, because it was their covenant. The Concord's, because half of them had never been told what he was, and you could watch the arithmetic happen behind their eyes and go wrong. The molted knights came on in a slow crescent, pikes level, unhurried, courteous as undertakers. Crane's tallymen raised their count-irons. Half the expedition's own tallymen raised theirs in answer, and the two halves looked at each other across thirty feet of root and seven years of shared graves, and a knight, patiently, cut down a tallyman who hesitated, and after that nobody hesitated, they simply chose.

Corwin's count-irons came up and then, with a motion Soren would remember longer than most of his memories, went down again, and the Chirurgeon turned his back on his own code's hierarchy to stand over two burn-team men who had chosen nothing yet. The count of Soren's friends got very short and very bright.

"Take him gently," Crane said, to no one and everyone, his tears running freely now, his hands folded like a man at prayer. "He is to be wed to a god, not grieved."

"Now that," said a voice like perfume given a mind, "is the single vulgar sentence of your career."

Lady Wren had not left the first carriage. She leaned from its chitin door as from a box at the opera, fan furled, unmoving, and her court around her was very carefully not taking part in the crescent. "My court is not paid in you, little seed," she said, and behind the boredom something was awake and fast. "And I owe your mother's face one kindness, though she would deny it to my face and enjoy doing it. Run."

Soren counted what he had. The burn-teams pinned behind the knights. Corwin bleeding but standing. Ilse's counter ticking at his hip, her absent hand steadying his. The nest's walls behind him, and every face in the weave awake now, and every face turned to him, and beneath them all a pulse like the sea under the world.

He reached for the count of his allies and found it short by exactly one, and the one was permanent.

He spent his last look the way Ilse had taught him to spend everything: deliberately, in pairs, twice. Once for the charge-collars that would not be fired now. Once for Corwin's turned back. Then the second count, because certainty lived there: the nest behind him, awake, holding its thousand faces up toward him like lamps.

Soren opened a Fold. No door. No iron ring, no hymn-chalk, no permission from any banner or any god. That was the Seventh Essence's one free gift, and it had already cost him

more than the Concord's whole treasury would admit to on paper. Somewhere behind him Crane was saying his name the way men say prices, and the herald's window-face was turning, and Wren was saying good, softly, in a language made of scent.

He stepped out of the battle, alone, toward the nest, and the war shut behind him like water over a coin.

CHAPTER 26

Court of One

The root-roads behind him filled with lantern-light and the tick of count-irons, and Soren ran down into the dark with his blood keeping a bad rhythm and his shoulder on fire where an iron had grazed him. The weapon did not tear. It wrote. A count-iron branded a running tally into what it struck, little notches that itched like debt, and the tallyman who had marked him was already calling his count to the others: running, eastward branch, wounded, slowing.

Ilse had taught him to run wounded, back in the weeks when he had still been a recruit worth correcting. Run bent. Lead with the hurt side; they aim at your strength. He ran bent, and the notches on his shoulder itched their itch, and behind him the pursuit kept its spacing like something that had drilled, because the Court's vanguard drilled the way water drills stone: patiently, and for centuries.

Twelve molted knights. Eight of Crane's tallymen, the ones whose irons had come up level without a wobble. Behind all of it, far back, the battle on the rim went on without him, and he could not let himself hear it.

He could hear the Lacuna.

The organ behind his sternum turned its attention toward the hunt the way a man turns in bed, and opened, and asked. It had asked before, quietly, at every tier, and each time he had paid on the installment plan: a sip of spilled shadow here, a consumed creature there, a memory set aside like a coin he would get back later. The dark around him was rich with the essence of the tide that hunted him. He could pay everything at once, and go up a tier in the middle of a battle, and let the Predator genome write itself the last of the way into his flesh.

Or he could keep running at a wounded man's pace down a road full of glass-limbed knights, and lose.

"I was always going to die of work," Soren said out loud, to the road, to the tick at his hip, and stopped running, and paid.

The growth fever hit like the harbor coming down. Heat first, then light, then the sense of being a page on which something enormous was writing quickly. He stayed on his feet because a mortuary assistant learns to stay on his feet around things that are not his business to fall over. The new gland opened behind his eyes like a third eyelid, and the world resolved into counts.

The True Tally, the old texts would have called it, if the old texts had dared. Every knight wore its count like a smell: ninth molting, third service, unhurt, certain. Each tallyman: fourth iron, second oath, wavering. And the tide itself, the whole ascension host pouring down the root-road, resolved into a single sum, and the sum was not free-floating. It was moored.

He saw it with the new sense as plainly as he had ever seen a wound: a chain of mooring-spires driven along the road at intervals, living root struck through with lantern-glass, each one singing one held note, and all the notes converging into the herald's voice. The tide was not an army. It was a ledger, and the herald was the hand that held the page open. Break the count, and the sum went to zero everywhere at once.

The first thing he read with the new sense, because you read yourself first, was his own line. One mortician, sixth essence, Predator to the root of him, frightened, bleeding, alone, and still counting. He noted the line, filed it, and moved on, and the filing was the strength of it. A count you keep is an anchor. A count that keeps you is a god.

Then the Fade came for him, the way it always came: politely, taking the far things first.

He felt it lift the far shelf of himself. The sea, long gone, was only the absence where a sea had been. His mother's face, long gone, was a doorway he had learned not to look at. Now it went deeper. Ilse's voice began to thin, the exact pitch of her "Forty-one" going gray at the edges, and Dax's grin, that quick crooked brightness, started coming apart like wet paper.

Soren held on the way men hold on in floods, to whatever is nearest and does not float.

The counter ticked at his hip, and the tick came in twos, because Vann counted twice.

He pulled the cord at his neck and the wedding ring came up, Dax's mother's ring, and inside the band, scratched tiny and worn nearly smooth, the words he had never shown anyone: for my boy.

"Vann counts twice," he said, to the dark, to himself, to the things unwinding him. "Merrow's mother wrote 'for my boy.' The rest can burn. Not these."

He chose the burn list himself, then, deliberately, the way you sign an amputation paper: the color of the mortuary's morning light, the name of the publican on Sallow Court, the taste of the good tea. Names, faces, prices. The Fade took what was offered and left him the two things he refused to offer, and the refusal was the whole of the man, and the whole of the man held.

The Fade receded from those two small objects the way a hand recedes from a stove, and Soren stood up out of the fever with the Sixth Essence moving in him like a second tide, and turned to face the road he had come down.

He went through the vanguard the way he went through a shift at the mortuary: by the count, in order, nothing wasted. The kill-sense told him which heartbeat would stop first and his body went there; Fold-step put him between one blink of a knight's glass eye and the next; the long knife found joints because joints are where the count of a body can be divided. Tallymen tried to mark him and marked the air. A knight took his left forearm to the glass and he repaid it by counting the creature's own leg out of true at the knee. He did not fight like a soldier, because soldiers are trying to win. He was trying to finish.

One of Crane's tallymen he caught alive, disarmed, young enough that his oath still showed. Soren put the long knife away and left him his life and an errand. "Run home," Soren said. "Tell the Primate the count is broken. And tell him Vann counted twice, and one of the twos was him." The boy ran, glad to be sent anywhere at all, and Soren let the mercy cost what it cost.

The herald stood at the first mooring-spire with its lantern face tipped toward him, patient as a cancelled appointment.

They stood a moment like two clerks at the same window, one of them holding the ledger and the other holding the knife, and the mooring-spire between them sang its held note down into both their bones.

"The Warden asked for you by face," it said.

"It can have my face," Soren said. "I know where it lives."

The True Tally read the creature whole, and he hated how well it read: one herald, ninth molting, holder of the count, alone in its office, tired. He killed it anyway, once, cleanly, and then counted twice, because a woman with a maimed hand had taught him that the second count is where certainty lives.

The note the herald had held went out of the world like a finger lifted from a harp string. Down the miles of root-road the mooring-spires went dark one after another, and the sum of the tide came apart, and the ascension host stopped mid-stride, masterless. Knights stood like furniture. Some knelt. The hunt was over because the arithmetic was over, and there was nothing left on the road but Soren and his own breath and the tick at his hip.

He took inventory of himself, because inventory was the man. No sea. No face. Her voice, barely, a gray thread. His own name, for now. The counter and the ring, and the fever's new eyes, and the old knife.

And warmth. Ahead, down the last of the root-roads, the woven dark of the nest stood open the way a door stands open when the house within has heard you come up the path. He had not asked. He had not knocked. He was being let in.

The woven wall came apart in front of him without being touched, coil by soft coil, the way a hand opens when it means to give something rather than take it.

The Warden opened the nest for him. Gently.

CHAPTER 27

The Warden's Succession

Inside, there was no dark to speak of. There was light the way there is light in deep water, sourceless and everywhere, gray-gold, and it came from the walls, and the walls were faces.

Soren stood in the core of the Warden and understood, with the calm of a man finally shown the back of the clock he had been repairing for a year, what the god was made of. Not stone. Not flesh, exactly. The core was a cathedral whose stones were faces, every size from a coin to a cartwheel, set in living root by living root, and every face was asleep and singing, and the singing was the architecture. The Warden was not a creature wearing a city of the dead. The Warden was a congregation. Every memory the Fade had ever taken was in the walls, wearing its face, and the god was the space their singing made.

He looked for the faces he knew, because that is what people do in crowds. A bride, mid-vow, young enough that her ribbons had been fashionable twice over. A lamplighter with his ladder. A child caught in the exact middle of a laugh, the laugh kept like a fly in amber. And the singing beneath all of them was not mournful, which was the worst of it. It was patient, and full, and horribly like a city at evening.

And toward him, out of that congregation, came a face he had sold to the dark without meaning to.

He could not have described his mother to save his life. That was the Fade's oldest theft, taken in a corridor of House Blackwing while he slept. So there was something unbearable in the way the face arrived and fit itself into the exact shape of the hole he had, a woman of forty-some years with tired eyes, and he knew it was her the way you know a room you were born in: not by the furniture. By the fit.

"You show me her face," Soren said, "and I can't even tell if you're flattering me."

"I do not wear it to wound," the Warden said. It spoke with her mouth and with a thousand others, a chorus in one throat, and it did not sound like a trick. It sounded like a library. "I wear

it because she is here. She is the newest of my great holdings and the oldest of my griefs. You asked once if the canopy had a king. It has a shelf, and she is on it, and she has been waiting to be read."

The throne stood at the crown of the core, grown up out of the floor like a thing that had been rehearsing for an audience that never arrived: a seat of root and glass, high-backed, patient. The succession, offered now in the open, with the tide broken and the herald dead and no one left to speak for the canopy but the canopy.

"Sit," the Warden said. "Be the mind of it. Keep the city as a garden, fed on schedule, ruled by count. You will never be hungry again, and nothing you love will be taken unless you take it. This was the offer I made you in dreams. I make it now in person, and I will not make it again."

"I'm a mortician," Soren said. "Hunger is my whole business. And I've seen what your garden does to the flowers." He put his hand on the seat once. It was warm. He took his hand back. "I didn't come for your chair. I came for her last."

"You will dream for the city," the Warden said. "They will bring you their forgetting like the sick, and you will be kind, and it will cost you nothing, because nothing costs a god."

"I've buried paupers," Soren said. "Nothing costs a god the way nothing costs a debt. Somebody always holds the paper."

The Warden was quiet for the length of one full turn of the great pulse beneath them.

"Then walk my shelves," it said.

The shelves were the walls. The Hollow was built, literally, from everything the Fade had ever taken, and it was stored, and it was sorted, and it was worn. Soren walked a gallery of strangers' Tuesdays. He passed a shelf that hummed and breathed salt, and his chest ached on a hinge he had no memory of owning, and he understood that somewhere on it was a sea he had sold for a vial, and he kept walking, because if he stopped he would open every jar in the building and there would be nothing left of him to carry the next one.

Here and there a shelf was marked in a hand rather than a glyph, inked onto the root with a stylograph: catalog numbers, dates, and once, small, in a tired lowercase, the word mine. He did not stop for that either. Stopping was a country he might never have walked out of.

He found her at the center, because he was a Seed, and Seeds are keys.

It was a case of gray glass the size of a heart, planted in the wall by hand, waxed shut and marked with a glyph: a seven-lobed bloom drawn in one unbroken stroke. The mark from the old gene-script. The mark from the sealed corridor. His mother's sign.

"Read her," the Warden said. "She wrote it to be read by her children. I have waited forty years to hear it read."

The case opened like a book, and the memory began, and Soren stood inside his mother's last clear hour.

A laboratory. Younger faces than the Concord wore now, and among them a woman with ink on her fingers, writing gene-scripts in an alphabet he had been taught at House Blackwing and forbidden to use. The Seeds, seven designed lineages, and the intent, plain as a scalpel on a tray: the Lacuna was never meant to be a mouth. It was meant to be a bridge. The giving-script was written to grow a Hollow that fed on memory offered, not memory taken; to re-seed the canopy with human remembering until the hunger turned inward and died of fullness. Gravid as gardeners. Symbiosis, not feeding. She had designed the cure before the city knew it was a patient.

And then the two readings, unfolding like hands dealing a deck he could not stop. The Court had found the work first and read the Seeds as feed-stock, and taught the Warden appetite, feeding it on the forgotten for a generation until taking was the only grammar it knew. The Concord had found the Court's interest and read the Seeds as a bomb, sealed the corridor, buried the giving-script under doctrine and fear, and called the burial caution. The Court fed it. The Concord locked it. Both starved it, and both, in their different churches, prayed it would stay small.

"Did it hurt you," Soren asked, when he could speak, "keeping her?"

"Keeping is all I know," the Warden said. "It is the hurting I am learning to stop."

Her voice, near the end, recorded in stages, because she had known she was being eaten while she worked:

"If you are hearing this, you counted true, and the count was long. I am sorry for the length of it. They tell me I have a son. I have written this before, in versions of me that no longer exist, and each of them remembered less and meant it more. Build the bridge. Do not feed it. Do not lock it. Teach it to ask."

The memory folded itself closed. The case sat open and empty and warm.

Soren put his hand flat on the wall beside it, which was the closest he could come to holding anyone. Somewhere in the cathedral of faces, a version of his mother that the dark had half-eaten had spent her last clear hour writing instructions for a child she was told she had. He decided, with the part of himself that was still a mortician, that he would finish her sentence for her. That was what assistants were for.

Around him the singing changed. Every face in the cathedral turned toward him, the way they had turned once before across a horizon of dream, and the Warden came out of the

congregation and, wearing a dead woman's face, knelt.

For the first time in an age, it asked instead of took.

"Teach me," it said, in a chorus of everyone it had ever eaten. "Teach me to ask."

CHAPTER 28

Greyharbor Rises

The Warden carried him up its own body like a thought, and for a quarter of an hour Soren saw Greyharbor the way a root sees it, from below and everywhere.

The dockline held. He watched it through the god's veins: the militia and the truce-armies in their oyster-shell sandbags, pikes and tally-irons and the old harbor guns hauled around to face the water as well as the sky, and above them the canopy, which had leaned on the city for a year like a collector leaning on a display case, going still. A root as thick as a barge sighed backward out of a warehouse wall it had pinned since spring, trailing moss, minding its manners. A soldier touched the withdrawing wood with one finger, snatched the finger back, and then, when the wood did nothing at all, touched it again and left it there. All along the dockline the pressure let go at once, like a fist unclenching, and the truce-bell rang half-notes, because the ringer was crying and could not manage the whole ones.

A militiawoman with a harbor-gun crew stood her post through all of it, because standing posts was what she had, and when the root finally let the warehouse go she marked the wall where it had been with a smudge of chalk, the way tallymen mark a debt paid, and the whole crew pretended not to see her do it. The tram wires, dead for a season, began to sing in the changed wind. Gulls came back over the docks in singles, then pairs, then in scandalous quantities, arguing about the return of the fishing.

Below, in the warm gray-gold core, the throne waited with the patience of furniture.

Soren put his hand on it once more, because a refusal should be made on the thing refused, and took it away.

"Kings get counted," he said. "I do the counting. Grow me a bench instead."

The Warden considered this for the space of a tide. "The city will make you its king anyway," it said. "Cities are lazy with their gratitude. They will put your face where the fog used to be."

"Then the fog is coming back," Soren said, "because that face is staying right here, behind a sink."

The Warden grew him a bench. It came up out of the floor through the night like a tooth through a gum: bone of the god's own rib, polished, slate-surfaced, with burners that burned blue spore-flame and racks that held glass at exactly the angle a scribing hand needs. The first bench the Hollow had ever licensed, and the licence was the god's own consent, witnessed by a cathedral of the dead. Soren ran his thumb along the slate and thought of House Blackwing's teaching benches, and of the first rule chalked above every one of them: a brew is a promise made in a body.

"Then we'll keep it," he said.

Three ingredients, and the first was the one no apothecary in history had ever used, because no apothecary had ever been given it. The Warden opened a vein of pale gold along its wall and gave. Not spilled, not harvested, not milked from some screaming thing in the dark. Gave, the way a host pours. Essence ran into the copper bowl and lay there glowing, and the Lacuna behind Soren's sternum went silent for the first time since the Sporefall, stunned, perhaps, or perhaps merely polite.

The second was the script. He scribed Maerwen's giving-script out of the sealed memory onto glass, in the old alphabet, and his hand cramped, and then the last third of it wrote itself while he watched, the way a word finishes when you finally stop interfering. Seven lobes. One stroke. A promise that the mouth is a bridge.

The bench wanted reagents, because benches do: a measure of harbor brine, boiled and cooled; the ash of spent saltfire, which burns root to a root that will not sprout, asked now, gently, to be a mineral and nothing angrier; and a grain of the Lantern King's perfumed debt out of a phial Marrow had sold him in a different life, surrendered at last to the only creditor who could call it in. He fed the desk the way the old teachers fed their desks, and the old teachers had never once known what it felt like to have the desk feed back.

The third was human memory, and this was the tithe that mattered, and he chose it like a man choosing which fingers to give.

Rain on slate. The exact sequence of the quarantine bells, rung wrong for seven years and now, maybe, rung wrong forever. Bread from the canal ovens at four in the morning. The first snow on the abattoir roof, and the specific silence of a city that has stopped to look at it. He poured them through the scribing desk into the brew, and each one went through him like a coin through a grate and came out the other side lighter. Ilse's tick and Dax's ring he kept out, and told the bench so, out loud. Some things are not currency.

The first New Codex tincture came off the bench gray-gold and luminous, smelling of rain and salt, and under that, faintly, of a struck match in a garden. Half of it he drank. It tasted like the smell of a childhood kitchen you cannot place. The other half the bench drank, root rising

through slate, the god receiving from a human hand for the first time in its long and starved existence.

Something opened in him that had no name yet, and he felt the canopy's appetite the way skin feels weather: pressure dropping, hunger fronting over the city like a storm that had nowhere left to make landfall. Then the storm felt the new thing growing in the roots below it, and turned, and began to rain on itself. Down on the dockline, in the changed air, the first man to notice would only report, afterward, that the sky had stopped leaning.

The re-seeding began as a sound, or the memory of one: a chord resolving. Light ran up the roots of the world in slow rings, out along the miles of the Warden's body, into the canopy over Greyharbor, and the Hollow turned over like something waking and began, at last, to eat its own hunger. It had spent an age consuming outward. Now it consumed the appetite itself, courses of it, years of it, the whole groaning banquet of want that the Court had taught it and the Concord had starved, and the expansion did not die with a scream. It died with a sigh, the sigh of a held thing being put down.

In the walls, the faces changed their singing. Some of them, here and there among the thousands, stopped singing altogether. Not silenced. Released.

Far up the body of the god, at the crown of the nest, the throne he had refused put out one pale shoot toward the space where he had stood, found nothing to hold, and stopped. The Warden let it stand there a day, and then grew it, patiently, into a shelf for the brew-glass he had left behind, which was as close as anything in the Hollow had ever come to taking a hint.

And then, in the turning of the tide of memory, the Hollow began to give things back, down the lines along which they had been taken, the way a bank that has caught fire returns its deposits. Somewhere above, he knew, an old woman was getting her street back. Somewhere a musician a tune. The god had hoarded an age of takings and now it spent, and among the first of the coins it pressed into his hands, unasked, came one he recognized by weight alone.

Salt. Kelp. Gull-cry. The cold green light under gray water, and tar and rope and the slap of a hull against a breakwater he had stood on at fourteen with his trousers rolled, and could not, until this moment, have remembered to miss. He had sold the sea to Marrow for a vial of First Essence and thought the price fair, because a man dying of hunger does not haggle over scent.

The Warden had let him sip it once before, in a dream, the way a lender lets a debtor smell the coin, and the sip had faded by morning, as dreams do. That had been demonstration. Proof of holdings. This was the deed, signed over in full, principal and interest, and there was a difference, and the difference was the rest of his life.

The sea came home to him all at once, the whole of it, wind and all. His hands, hanging at his sides, made small motions of tying off a line he had not tied in nine years. He laughed once, which in the circumstances was the noise his crying had decided to make.

It smelled like the sea.

CHAPTER 29

The New Codex

Nine days after the stilling, Greyharbor began handing things back, and the handing-back was stranger than the taking had been. An old woman on Sallow Court woke remembering the name of the street she had lived on for fifty years, which the fog had taken, and wept into her tea. A musician got back a tune his sister used to hum, all but the last bar, and walked the canal for a day trying doors in it. A docker remembered his daughter's face. A docker's wife remembered leaving. The re-seeded Hollow returned what it had hoarded, down the lines along which the Fade had collected, and the city spent the week flinching from its own gifts.

A lamplighter on Chain Row remembered his son's laugh, which he had buried without noticing the burial, and stood under his own lamps for an hour with one hand on the pole. The Circle posted a table in the fish exchange: what the Hollow had taken, what the re-seeding had returned, and a third column, honest and mostly empty, headed still out. Every morning there was a queue to read it like a tide table.

Soren went up for the arrest of Primate Aldous Crane because he had the veto now, and the veto meant being summoned to things.

They did it in the re-roofed hall of House Blackwing, in front of the re-formed Circle of Leaves, and they did it with Crane's own tallymen binding his wrists in count-cord, which was the Circle's idea of mercy or of poetry. Crane watched the knots being tied with the interest of a man checking another man's stitches. His kind eyes found Soren across the hall.

"I would have fed them in order," Crane said. "Order was the only mercy left in my hands. God forgive the arithmetic." He raised his bound hands, both of them, like a man asking a question in school. "One thing. When the ledgers are opened, count the ones I would have spent. Put the number in my cell where I can hear it. It will be lower than the number that would have been, and I would rather live with the smaller of my two evils than the larger of the world's."

No one answered him, which was an answer.

Soren stopped at the door, because there was one thing owed. "The number will be counted properly," he said. "By someone who counts twice." Crane nodded the way men nod at sentences that will keep them company in a small room.

Soren left before the chains came out, because he had counted enough, and some counting is only a way of watching.

He went up again, past the stilling canopy, to the crown, where the Molted Court was leaving. They went in a long glittering line of chitin carriages, lanterns dimmed to coals, up and out through Folds that led away from any city, to soil that was promised to nobody. Lady Wren waited for him at the last carriage with her fan furled and her face arranged into something almost like candor.

"The canopy will feed on memory given now, not flesh taken," she said. "My court was built on the old diet, little seed. We would waste here. Slowly, gorgeously, and to no purpose, and Wren does not waste. So: exile, above and away, by our own choice, before the New Codex makes us beggars with manners."

She looked out over the city from the crown, and the look was long, and she permitted it to be seen. "It is smaller than it believes and lovelier than it deserves," she said. "Keep both facts true, little seed, and the Concord will outlive my court's whole future reputation for generosity."

"Will you starve out there?"

"Wonderfully. But on our own accounts." She looked at him for a long moment, and the knife-honesty came out, as it always did, wound in courtesy. "Twice I offered you apprenticeship. I have never been gladder of a refusal. And since I am leaving: your mother court-spied for the Concord and paid her gin debts in bad verse, and I liked her enormously. This farewell is the only honest inheritance I have. Spend it well. Starving things become simple. Fed things become interesting. Keep your Concord interesting, or I will be back, and I will not be alone."

She stepped up onto the carriage's running-board, then turned, because Wren never left a debt uncalled even to remit it. "Give the god my regards," she said. "Tell it the Court is sorry. It will know what for. It keeps our oldest accounts."

The carriages took the light with them. The crown of the Hollow, for the first time since the Sporefall, was only a roof over a city, and it rained.

The Circle of Leaves re-formed around the New Codex in the third week: every ledger open, every corridor unsealed, every brew licensed twice, the giving-script chalked above the teaching benches where the first rule used to hang.

Students filed past the unsealed corridor all that week, touching the doorframe the way pilgrims touch the shoulder of a saint. Somewhere in the house a seer's forty-year-old message grew one new line of wallpaper that nobody could account for and nobody dared remove. The veto went into the founding ink in Soren's own hand, and he scribed it twice, and the registrar notarized both copies, because certainty lives in the second count. They offered Soren the primate's chain, because cities are grateful in the laziest possible way, with the heaviest object they own.

"I count things," Soren said. "Chains get counted around necks, and I've fitted enough of those in the mortuary. Take it back."

"Then what will you take?" asked the Leafmaster who had signed Dax's harvest warrants, and could not look at him while asking.

"A veto. No feeding, no sealed corridor, no Seed conscripted, no brew burned into any body without my consent. And the ledgers open to anyone who can read them."

"That is a small throne."

"It's a leash," Soren said, "with me on the far end. Take it or leave it."

They took it. Then they asked him, gently, whether he had noticed anything coming back, and he said he had, and the Circle had the good manners to pretend that was paperwork.

It came back at the mortuary sink, of all places, on an evening of no importance. Not from the outside in, the way memories return when a smell unbolts a door. From the inside, up through the sternum, through the Lacuna, along the re-seeded lines, from the Hollow's gift. Tired eyes. A mole under the left eye, like a period at the end of a sentence. Hair escaping its pin at the right temple, and the frown of a woman counting.

In his vest pocket, the stopped watch ticked. Once. Then again, and then went on, in the smallest voice in the world, keeping time for the first time in seven years.

"Hello, Mum," Soren said, and his voice did something embarrassing, and he let it.

The face was not her. It was the memory of her face, returned, and it was everything, and it was not enough, and he held it anyway, the way you hold a cup of something hot in winter: carefully, greedily, knowing it cools.

And under the face, like a foot pushed under a door, came the way she had said his name. Soren, with the o gone soft, as if it were being counted too. He kept the watch wound from that night on, out of a superstition he did not examine, and it never stopped again.

The Circle's registrar brought the Seed ledger to the mortuary two days later, because the veto meant the paperwork, and paperwork finds the man with the veto. Seven designed lineages, made before the Sporefall. Three burned in the Sporefall, names and dates and the

registrar's small tidy notation. Two never bloomed: dormant lines, quiet, accounted. The Seventh, Soren Vale: present, accounted, obstructive. And the Sixth.

"File burned in the schism," the registrar said. "No harvest record, no bloom record. Whereabouts unknown."

The registrar dipped her pen and wrote the sixth line as it stood, and the ink dried in the lamplight like a door closing politely.

The registrar blew on the ink, packed her ledger, and paused at the mortuary door with her hat in her hands. "For what it is worth, Vale," she said, "the sixth line is the only one in that book that keeps me up at night. Dead lines rest. Unknown lines wait." She put her hat on and left him the silence, and the silence ticked.

Of the seven Seeds, six were accounted for.

CHAPTER 30

First Light in Greyharbor

The fog lifted on a Tuesday.

It went the way weather goes when it has finally run out of arguments: thinned from the top down, then from the edges in, and by mid-morning Greyharbor could see itself for the first time in seven years. Slate roofs steamed in the sun. The canals came up green-gold and embarrassed, like rooms opened after a funeral. And out past the harbor mouth the sea lay flat to a horizon of struck tin, so bright that men on the dockside took off their hats to it, and not one of them could have said why.

The churches rang their bells out of order, because none of them had heard a sunrise in seven years and every one of them had something to say. Nobody minded. Out-of-order bells were the correct music for a city learning to look up.

The fish exchange opened with its shutters all the way up for the first time since anyone could remember, and the honest smell of it drifted over the canal. Market stalls came up like mushrooms after the rain they had finally seen. Children who had been taught the fog the way other children are taught religion stood in the middle of streets pointing at clouds, and their parents let them stand there and did not count minutes to curfew, because there was, as of that morning, a motion on the Circle's books to strike the word curfew from the city code, and everyone knew it would pass, and everyone went out anyway, on credit, so to speak.

Soren kept the mortuary.

It had changed less than the city had. The sixth floor was still a Fold, though the garden behind it had gone quiet, and its keeper, whatever she had been, had stopped leaving calling cards. The slab-room smelled of carbolic and honest work. He had hired Wick back in the hungry month for the only qualification that mattered, which was that the boy had asked, at the interview, what happened to the ones nobody claimed, and had not liked the answer, and had stayed anyway.

Old Nesta Fenn came in on the Wednesday, dock-widow, eighty-one, dead of age and nothing else, which was its own kind of festival, and he prepped her with the care he had been taught and had taught onward: line, grain, one motion where three would do. The new assistant, Wick, sixteen, all elbows and questions, held the tray and watched the counting.

"Why twice?" Wick asked, when Soren ran the instruments a second time. "You always do it twice."

"Because the dead are owed exactness," Soren said. "And because a woman named Vann once counted me twice, and it kept me alive. Count, Wick. Twice. She held a door for three dozen of us so the habit could survive her."

Corwin came by at midweek with the last of her kit in a canvas roll: a whetstone worn into a smile, a folding knife with a Chirurgeon's mark, and her spare counter, the backup she had carried for twenty years and never needed, until now, in the sense that she would never need it again. "She'd want it counted on," Corwin said, and could not finish the sentence, and did not have to. Soren put the spare in the ledger drawer with Marrow's note, and the drawer by then was becoming, without his noticing, a reliquary.

On the sill by the sink, Ilse's brass tally-counter ticked. It had ticked since the Choir's Crossing, small and regular and unhurried, and he had stopped asking what it counted. He liked to think it counted what came back. In his vest pocket his mother's watch kept time now, ticking properly for the first time in seven years, and the wedding ring hung at his neck with its worn engraving against his skin, and between the three of them the room felt guarded, the way a city feels guarded when the fog goes and everyone can finally see the gates.

A crate arrived by the noon cart, spendthrift-heavy, packed in straw: sea-salt caramels, two stone of them at least, and a note in gray ink on gray paper.

For the man who ended the market's only famine. No charge. (Truth: everyone owes someone. Today it is my pleasure to owe you.) — M.

Marrow never lied and never told the whole truth. Soren ate a caramel, decided the caramels were the whole truth, and put the note in the ledger drawer with everything else he intended to keep.

He still walked the docks at dusk and counted the lights, because the habit was the man and the man had promised.

Two hundred and eleven lights the first week of the sun, and he counted them twice each evening from the harbor steps, and liked the two hundred and twelfth best because it was new: a lamp hung by some unknown hand on the pilings under the fish exchange, burning for nobody in particular, which is the definition of a vigil and also of a decoration, depending on the town. The Circle had offered him a seat three times by post, each letter more embarrassingly deferential, and he had declined three times by the same post, each reply shorter, and on the third occasion Wick had asked him why he kept refusing power that everyone agreed was his.

"Because I've laid out what power leaves on the slab," Soren said. "It comes in here looking exactly like an accident."

Wick considered this with his whole face, which at sixteen is still under construction. "Then why keep the veto?" he said.

"Because I'm cheaper than a king," Soren said, "and easier to bury."

The courier came at the turn of the tide, in Concord gray, boots salt-white to the knee from a ship that had sailed farther than any ship Soren had ever seen in the harbor. The letter was in a house hand, formal, waxed, and heavy with distance: House Ondrey, of Vesperquay, apothecaries, keepers of the far signal, the Concord's oldest cousin across the water. Their bloom-glass, dark for forty years, had sung in the night, the letter said. The same gray-gold note, the letter said, that had run through the roots of Greyharbor when the canopy re-seeded, and the house's signal-keepers had stood a whole watch around it with their hats off, the way men do at a birth.

The courier had the look of a man who had been briefed to expect a god and had found, instead, a sink and a ledger drawer, and was visibly uncertain which was the disappointment.

The paper was good rag, the wax a deep green-black, and the seal was a seven-lobed bloom drawn in one unbroken stroke. He sat down on the stool without deciding to, because he had last seen that sign in a sealed corridor, in a wall of the Hollow, and in a memory that had cost a god forty years of waiting to deliver.

The closing lines had come loose from their formality, the way writing does when a hand stops being an office's and starts being a person's:

We are given to understand the count stands at six of seven. The signal was answered here too. The house would correspond with the Seventh Seed, and begs him to forgive the impropriety of a first letter sent at dawn.

Soren read it twice at the window, in sunlight, with the sea visible for the first time in seven years and Ilse's counter ticking on the sill behind him like a small determined heart. Somewhere south or east or past the edge of the charts, another house had watched a dark vial wake up and sing, and had thought of a seed.

He folded the letter along its creases and put it in the ledger drawer with Marrow's note and the memory of a rearguard, then stood a while at the window, doing the thing he did instead of praying, which was counting: the gulls, the masts, the bells still ringing wrong, the seven years, the six of seven. The count came out the same every time, which is the property of true counts, and he found he did not mind the open line in it. Open lines are just work that has not started. He had been a mortuary man long enough to know the difference between an ending and a sending-off.

Somewhere across the water, a seed-signal had been answered there too.

EPILOGUE

The Overseas Letter

Vesperquay had not worn fog in a hundred and forty years. It was a warm-water port, all white stone and terraced gardens, where the harbor lay at night like a spilled field of stars and the sea came up the streets in a whisper instead of a roar. Apothecaries ran the place the way other ports ran navies, and the oldest of the apothecary houses was House Ondrey, keeper of the far signal, and on the top floor of the Ondrey signal-tower a vial of luminous water had sat dark on a velvet shelf for forty years.

Mirren Ondrey, nineteen, ink to the second knuckle, youngest of the Ondrey line and keeper of the signal by virtue of being the only one willing to climb the stairs at night, was re-trimming a lamp when the bloom-glass woke.

It did not blaze. It sang. A small gray-gold note, the color of rain deciding to be light, and the vial filled from the bottom up like a glass being poured by a patient hand, and the whole tower smelled suddenly of a garden after lightning. Mirren stood very still and counted her own heartbeats, twice, which was a habit the house taught its children along with letters.

Then she ran down four flights and woke her grandmother.

Grandmother Signe came up the tower stairs at two in the morning with a shawl over her nightdress and no surprise on her face at all, which frightened Mirren more than surprise would have. The old woman stood before the singing vial for the length of one long breath, listening to it the way one listens to a voice rather than a sound.

"There is a case," Signe said. "There has always been a case. It came to my grandmother's keeping with the founding correspondence, before your mother's mother was a rumor. Founder's instruction, in her own hand, sealed to the lid: open when the bloom sings. My grandmother's grandmother, and her grandmother before her, and every one of them told the next: the house does not own this. The house keeps it. Go and wake the cellar-warden, child. Tonight the keeping ends."

The case lay in the deep vault behind three locks and a law, a box of black walnut the length of a forearm, sealed all around in black wax. On the lid, pressed deep into the wax by a signet worn smooth with use, was a single glyph: a seven-lobed bloom drawn in one unbroken stroke, the kind of line a hand makes only after a lifetime of practice.

Mirren had seen it before, on the spine of the oldest ledger in the house, and had been told, as all the children were told, that it was nobody's sign and everybody's inheritance, and not to ask.

They broke the wax at the long worktable with the whole house standing around in nightclothes and candlelight, and nobody spoke, which in a house of apothecaries is the loudest thing that can happen. Inside, packed in wool a century old, was a lattice of gray root-glass curled tight as a fern furled for winter, and it was warm. Warm through the wool, warm against Mirren's palms, beating with a pulse so slow and small you had to trust it rather than feel it, and alive, unmistakably, gorgeously alive.

Beneath it lay a letter, the ink brown, the paper cold as the cellar stone and just as patient. Her grandmother held it to the lamp, and read the first lines aloud, and her voice, which had sworn in three languages and buried two husbands, went unsteady on the fourth word.

"To the house that kept the light. If the bloom has answered, then it learned to give instead of take, and everything I was afraid of was worth being afraid of, and everything I planted is worth what it cost. My children were made to be planted, not spent. Plant me gently. — M.V."

Nobody asked who M.V. had been. Every face around the table had understood, in the way of people who have spent their lives reading small signs in large darknesses, that the letter had traveled further than any of them would, and had been waiting longer than any of them had been alive, and that the waiting had just ended.

Mirren lifted the lattice into the lamplight. It turned. Slowly, the way a flower turns that has never seen a window before, it opened toward the warmth, unfurling one gray-gold coil, and then another, and out in the harbor of Vesperquay the water lay star-still under a sky with no fog in it anywhere, and had not had any for a hundred and forty years, and none, Mirren understood now, looking at the small warm thing unfolding in her hands, that a seed had not already promised to lift.

"Count twice," her grandmother said, with the last of the black wax still on her thumb, and there were tears on the old woman's face and she was laughing.

Mirren counted. The seed was warm. It opened like a hand.